

Engl 220 The Art of Storytelling

Numbered Transcript

ENGL 220 • Gregg Hurwitz & Dr. Andy Martin

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Lecture 1: Mythology and Passion

At a glance — Mythology and passion as the roots of story.

- 1.1 I want to kick off with a couple of random thoughts. "I'm very skeptical of books. I don't want to say no book is ever worth reading, but I do believe something pretty close to that. I think if you wrote a book, you fucked up, and it should have been a six-paragraph blog post." I wonder if anyone recognizes the author of that, Sam Bankman-Fried, ex-billionaire, and very good advice, I think, for anyone planning to rip off a lot of people and get arrested for fraud.
- 1.2 On the other hand, here's another thought. "There's nothing more powerful than a good story. Nothing can stop it. No enemy can defeat it." And you will recognize that if you have seen the Game of Thrones all the way through to the last episode, because that is Tyrian speaking. And that is why taking Tyrian's argument for our theme, we are going to be discussing the art of story, with none other than Gregg Hurwitz, our resident writer and author of The Nowhere Man.
- 1.3 The Nowhere Man is here today, and actually not just the Orphan X series, but I threw that together. I couldn't cram all of his books into this page. So that's just a sample because he is the author not only of the 8-strong Orphan X series and 16 stand-alones, but a whole bunch of Marvel and DC comics that I can't even show a picture of because they're very exclusive. But anyway, so it actually reminds me, the great Jules Verne was once asked the question, "How much have you written, Jules?" And his answer was, "About a meter." And I think Gregg Hurwitz has gone well beyond a meter now. And over the next 3 seminars, he's going to tell us everything you ever wanted to know about writing fiction, but we're afraid to ask, and how to create killer stories.
- 1.4 Today, we're going to focus on myth; tomorrow, mimesis; and finally, momentum. Gregg and I are going to get the ball rolling, but after the interval, it's open season on Gregg Hurwitz. So feel free to pitch in your thoughts. But to begin at the beginning, The Last Orphan, I'm guessing this probably isn't The Last Orphan. So that's a tease from you. But can I ask you to go back to the beginning then? And how did you get started as a writer?
- 1.5 So my parents did not allow me to watch television, which was horrible. I considered this a great tragedy. I was only allowed to watch Alfred Hitchcock movies and when the Red Sox were on TV because my dad's from Boston and the Red Sox was like a religion. And so I read all the time. And I thought in stories. I mean, I used to go to bed with an illustrated dictionary when I was a kid. And it was the only way that my mind worked. And I always thought in stories. I always thought in scenarios. I'd be sitting, whether it's on an airplane or in a crowded place, and I would think the recurrent question from me was always, "What's the worst or most exciting thing that can happen right now?" And I

was constantly constructing stories. It was my way of being and functioning in the world.

- 1.6 And then probably the thing that led most to it, I had illustrated, like, I wrote mysteries illustrated with crayons. In fifth grade, I wrote Willy, Julie, and the Case of the Buried Treasure, where no one says anything. Everyone retorts. Everyone has these active Hardy Boy verbs. But the most important thing I think that I did was I just pursued everything that was of the most interest to me. I always went to where there was something that I was passionate about. And so it's very important for writers to pursue that which compels them, that which calls out to them.
- 1.7 I meet a lot of people living in Los Angeles, as I do now, who are, like, "I studied writing, I got a master's in screenwriting, and then now I'm a screenwriter," and there's not necessarily a wealth of experience or other issues to stitch into the writing. And writing has got to draw from both. You have to integrate it. And no matter what you do, if you're a writer or anything else, you want to follow the thing that's calling to you the most.
- 1.8 I sort of wonder if there was a big trigger. I have a good friend who's a crime writer, and she says she owes it all to getting kicked in the head by her horse when she was a kid, that it set her up as a writer, that changed her life in some way. And there's a comic book version of all of this. And this is a drawing done by one of my sons, actually, of Clayface. And he is snorting. He's snorting some illegal substance, which turns him into this superhero. And I was just wondering, not that you were necessarily snorting anything, but was there a moment—
- 1.9 This is not supposed to be that personal a conversation.
- 1.10 No, of course. Set that aside. Was there a moment? Was there a someone? Was there a guru? Was there a drama? Was there a crime, in fact, actually, that perhaps triggered and set you off?
- 1.11 I'm very impressed someone got kicked in the head with a horse, and that was the outcome. Usually, it's a much less fortunate outcome. So this is Clayface, one of Batman's villains. I wrote Batman for a few years. So I think that's a line.
- 1.12 Yeah. "I didn't just talk about it. I became them." Yeah, we can come back to that?
- 1.13 I got obsessed with Stephen King when I was in fifth grade. So I was reading a lot. I was mostly crawling up my parents' bookcases to get, like, Jaws was on the top shelf and Clan of the Cave Bear, which had forbidden fruit scenes. But I remember I was reading Stephen King at a fairly young age, and I was just astounded by the array of emotions that he inculcated in me. Here's someone who could put down a combination of familiar words in an unfamiliar order, and it elicits emotion. It was the weirdest thing. And so I still remember reading—Salem's Lot to me was the most terrifying—under the bed, with a flashlight. My parents were gone. I was terrified. I was 25 years old.

- 1.14** But I remember just thinking, I want to do that. I want to figure out how to elicit that. It's so weird that across years and across the country—he's in Maine— that he could put these words down that elicit this emotion in me. And the relationship between a novelist and a reader is incredibly, it's a very special relationship. It's very intimate. And so when I write screenplays, if I write TV, if I write movies, if I write comics, everyone who reads it sees the same comic. If I write a Batman, everyone's going to read Batman. The movies that I've made, everyone sees the same movie. They can have different emotional experiences with them.
- 1.15** But with a book, everyone who reads it brings their own emotion, their own hopes and dreams, their own vulnerabilities, and constructs the story within themselves. And so if I sell a million copies of a book, there's a million different movies that are played. And so a lot of that goes into the writing, because with a novel, you don't want to overstate or overwrite. You want to elicit emotion. You want to intimate. You want to fill the gaps and the holes so that people will step into them and fill them themselves. And that's that sentiment that I'm sure that we've all felt where you read something and it's too overt, it's too cloying, it's too overly romantic. It's telling you what to feel. We don't want to be told what to feel. We want someone to make the connection themselves.
- 1.16** I'll give two quick examples. One of them is in one of my books. I have two characters who are quite menacing. One is large and the other guy is smaller, and the tall guy set a task for myself that, in every scene, he would just say one word, and the younger guy would lead. And there's a scene with a home invasion where there's a couple on a couch and they're going to proceed to torturing them. The big guy is standing there quietly. He's got a duffle bag on his shoulder. It's very heavy. And it's all set up, and the couple's there waiting. And he says to them, the younger guy looks up at him and he says, "Where do you want to start on him?" And he dips his shoulder, and the duffle bag falls with a weighty clank filled with tools on the floor, and he looks at them and he says, "Joints." And that's the only thing that he says.
- 1.17** So a few months later, I'm at a book signing and a woman comes up to me and says, "That scene you wrote. It was so much gratuitous violence. I almost couldn't sustain to read it. It was so horrifying. I can't believe that you showed all that." Well, that's where the scene ended. I never showed anything past it. So if I wrote this incredibly gory scene of him using a ball-peen hammer to smash up all the joints, it's very overt. It might get a cheap thrill on the page, but if I end the scene there, everybody's going to fill that with the worst thing that is within them.
- 1.18** And so you always want to leave room for the reader and also, in fact, the viewer, to step into it. That's the famous dictum from Jaws, which is like, "We don't want to see the shark." The shark didn't work very well. They had a lot of mechanical problems. But the thing that was wonderful about Jaws is that there's this constant sense of tension because you can't see it in full. And it makes it much more horrifying.

- 1.19** That is so important, isn't it? Less is so often more, I guess—that kind of economy. But I wonder if I can ask the question that a lot of aspiring writers, particularly if they're sitting in front of a blank sheet or, God forbid, they're suffering from writer's block, would like to ask you, which is, where do your ideas come from? How do you go from zero to hero?
- 1.20** So with writing, I think—look, there's some amount—I'm going to paraphrase Stephen King. There's some amount of factory-issue hardware that you have to have. You have to think like a writer, just like engineers have to—it's a different sentiment. It's a different mindset. I tend to really think in words and scenes and scenarios. But if you have that, if that's something that you're drawn to, so much of it is that you learn, as with everything, by attempting it and failing.
- 1.21** I had a lunch early in my career with a screenwriter who wanted to switch to novels and said, "I just have to talk to you because I don't like to start anything unless I really know I can do it successfully. So I want to talk to you about how to write a novel so that, when I embark on it, I'll really know what I'm doing." And it's like, the only way that you can learn to write a novel is doing it and screwing it up. My first novel, I started quite young. I was 19. I think I finished an egregious rough draft by the age of 21. I rewrote it 16 times. I took it apart like an engine block. I mean, I wrote a very not-functional first draft that had some fire and heat in it, but I had to completely disassemble it. I rewrote it 16 times.
- 1.22** My second book was a very similar intense editorial process. I was very fortunate to sell both of them. But my third book was the first book that, at the end of a first draft, it even held the shape of what a novel should be. So don't be afraid to fail. Don't be afraid to just get down a vomit draft. As has been said by many writers previous to me, you can't fix a blank page. But if you get something that's down, if you give yourself permission to forge forward, even if the result is not compelling, you can always cut and paste. You can always get in a bunch of paragraphs and maybe find a momentum and have a few jewels in there that you can derive lessons from.
- 1.23** Right. So you have to screw up. I think that's very good advice.
- 1.24** Generally in life, too.
- 1.25** And then recover from that. I wonder if we can get archaeological for a moment and go back to a time before Gregg Hurwitz, before literature, in fact, right back to the origins, the big bang of story. And obviously this is hypothetical. But how do you think human beings got started? Do you think fiction has some kind of evolutionary necessity?
- 1.26** Well, I'm very much, I mean, in college, I studied Jung. I studied English and psychology. And psychology, I was very taken with Carl Jung. He wrote about—basically everything he wrote about was a narrative, whether he's writing about myth or dreams. And even when he wrote about alchemy—right, like, why did he spend the second half of his career writing about alchemy? Well, it's the transition of base matter into something

that's pure. It's the hero's myth, but it's embodied in materials, and it's the same sort of structures. So I have a belief, as someone who is an enormous admirer of Jung, that there's an evolutionary basis for storytelling. I think that we think and we function in stories in order to tell us how to contend with the internal and external unknown.

1.27 And so, to give an example, if there's a tribe in the middle of the Amazon that's cut off from any contact with any other culture, when we find them, we know a few things. We know that they're going to have opposable thumbs. We know they're going to have eyelids. We know that they're going to have a hero's journey with all of the steps of a hero's journey of some kind. And it holds its form, whether from Gilgamesh to Jesus Christ to the Terminator. These stories have an arc. They have a shape to it. They're part of, foundationally, how we think.

1.28 And a lot of that is that I think that there's an engagement in stories that teach us, like I said, to contend with the internal and the external unknown. And you can read a story, we can encounter things. That thing that I was talking about, how it inculcates in us a sense of wonder and horror. When I read Thomas Harris' *Red Dragon*, which I think is the finest thriller ever written— it's the one that just precedes *Silence of the Lambs*—I was an adult grown-ass man and put the book down and went and looked in all the closets and under the beds. It's like, how is that? That's alchemical. What a bizarre experience to read something. But we get to have contact with all these emotions without actually risking our own necks. So we can experience all sorts of things.

1.29 And in fact, at times when I've been in very difficult personal circumstances in my life, I've thought back to a variation. William James, the great psychologist, has a quotation that I love. He said, "Act like the person you want to be." And when I've been stuck in my life, I've thought, if I was writing the character of myself in this trying circumstance, how would I write myself to act in the way that would be most heroic? And then I act like that. And in doing so, at times I've been able to embody a version of myself that's deeper and wiser and better than, in fact, I am. It's allowed me to reach forward in a certain way to that.

1.30 And when we read books, that's what we're learning a lot of ways. It's a way to have contact with crisis points, with hope, with variation. Now, that said, what's so interesting is there's this structural foundational underlay that's, let's call it archetypal narrative or myth. You can't write from there. No one wants to read a story where you say, "Well, I was really thinking about having a hero's myth and here's the parts." A lot of the courses that are taught teach structure because you can teach structure. You can't teach dialogue because it's different every time out. You can't teach the tiny details that make you connect with character or pull forth an emotion from you. But structure is learnable.

1.31 But a lot of the worst things that you read are beautifully structured nothingness. And so you need to be able to put the house on these. It's not just the scaffolding and the infrastructure. You need to put meat on all the bones of a story. And a lot of times that

comes from somewhere else. It comes from the deeply personal. So the stories for me—it's like you want to have this deep understanding of narrative structure, in a way. But where the mythic, where the mythological meets the personal is the point of story.

1.32 If it's purely personal, you can have this rambling text of the best stoned conversation I had with my roommates in college. It doesn't do anything. It just decomposes. It disassociates. You can't have the purely personal, but you also can't have the purely mythological or else you're swimming in abstractions. So it's a very weird meeting point that you're trying to forge the way from almost the top and the bottom to the middle. And my way in always is from the personal and from the story, not to say, let me fill out some preexisting form that I know will be functional.

1.33 Right. So if we adopt a Jungian perspective, you would probably agree that we're recycling or repurposing old stories. And I just want to mention this basic hypothesis, which has been put forward by various people, but I first came across it in E. O. Wilson's book, *The Origins of Creativity*. And he's talking about contemporary Bushmen and examining their—in Africa—and examining their narratives. And they're usually based, he refers to these myth-like accounts of actual hunts.

1.34 So he says that, or he hypothesizes, that story begins with a hunt and that everything we—well, we may verbalize it or in Gregg's case, we're writing the story. There, as it were, variations on that theme of the hunt. And it strikes me in reading your books, that the core of every narrative is in some sense a hunt. It's a pursuit. As much as a quest, we're tempted, I think, bearing in mind that hero's journey and Joseph Campbell and all that, to talk about the quest, but the hunt—tracking something down physically, but also, and perhaps we can come to that, intellectually.

1.35 So for me, perhaps less intellectually, I think of writers in three ways, that people who write from the heart, the head, or the gut. So the head for me would be like James Joyce, right? And the heart would be F. Scott Fitzgerald, *The Great Gatsby*. The gut's like Faulkner, right? And when I'm writing best, I'm writing from the gut. I don't come from an intellectual place necessarily. And with the hunt, it's interesting you're talking about that. We've talked before about, I think a lot of times that the novels that I write and the stories that I'm engaging with are often also about a process of undeceiving.

1.36 And so the outside, the external plot—if we're just reading a plot, we've all been in those movies, where they have the endless action third act, where you're getting punched in the face with action, and you're just exhausted, and it's all the same stuff. If it is merely external, you don't have a sense of engagement. And so for me, the combination where something functions is where the external unknown is also illuminating something that is internal. And the two of them are in concert, and they can't be too cute, if it's too clean a combination. "I've always been afraid of swimming, and then the last scene has him on the verge of drowning and he learns to swim." We know all the cute shortcuts.

- 1.37 But the process of what's happening externally should be mirrored in certain regards for something internally. And because of that, very important notion goes back to the Greeks and certainly Shakespeare, which is one of my passions. But the tragic flaw, or let's just say, the precipitating incident that sets in motion the narrative structure, it has to be from some failing or misstep, often ethical in some way, that is from the main character. And if you don't have them open the door to unforeseen consequences, even if they open the door a crack, and then it smashes open with the furor of the world, then you're just writing about why bad things happen to good people. And that's not narrative, that's life. That's pancreatic cancer, right? That's the proverbial Acme Safe, right?
- 1.38 And so the hunt that is external often should be brought into being. It should be engendered by something in the main character. And often you want, and this is something else we can talk about at greater length, which is, you want your main characters to be flawed. If they're not flawed—when I wrote my first book, the aforementioned book that I wrote the crappy rough draft of and then had to really fix, I mean, I have a line in it that I still cringe at where I said, "He was the best of the best." It was an FBI agent. It's like, no one needs that. Nobody needs that.
- 1.39 What we love, what we relate to in our personal lives, in our marriages, in our relationships, in our friendships, often it's the frailty, it's the flaws, it's the vulnerability. The crack is the place the light enters you. To have a character who missteps and then feels conflicted or terribly about it, that's the human joining in something. And so that mistake, that aspect of humanity has to crack into the story that opens up the story that then has a narrative function.
- 1.40 OK, well, we've mentioned Shakespeare and we've mentioned James Joyce. I just wonder if we want to mention the Punisher now. And that son of mine has done a rather good drawing of something that Punisher gets up to when he says, "All right, let's find out what the fuck is going on around here."
- 1.41 This is another—you're pulling out my most cerebral quotations from my comic book work, I see. But yes, this is from a Punisher story that I wrote called Girls in White Dresses.
- 1.42 Right. OK. Where the Punisher has to go somewhere south of the border in pursuit of a drug cartel, if I remember, actually, and is initially bamboozled until he starts sorting everyone out, basically. And then he does get to the bottom of the great mystery. And I just want to throw in a phrase, just to clarify what the Punisher is getting up to here, which Carlo Ginzburg has helpfully suggested the phrase the "cynegetic paradigm." And we can come to the etymology, by the way, "cynegetic."
- 1.43 But he asked this interesting question: "What do Sherlock Holmes, Freud, and hunter-gatherers have in common?" And the answer, to some extent, is contained in the etymology from cune or cuon, dog, and ago, to lead, therefore hunting, the hunting

paradigm. But he says the thing that they all have in common is, "They are like dogs." They're actually—and we are like dogs when we write or tell a story because we follow a scent. And he puts it rather nicely. He's got this. I'm just quoting from Ginzburg here, if I may.

- 1.44** "We've been hunters for thousands of years. In the course of countless pursuits, we learn to reconstruct the shapes and movements of invisible prey from tracks in the mud, droppings, tufts of hair, entangled feathers. We learn to sniff out, record, interpret, and classify such infinitesimal traces as trails of spittle. We learned how to execute complex mental operations with lightning speed in the depth of a forest or in a prairie with its hidden dangers."
- 1.45** And one thing I remember from that, which isn't in the Punisher, but at the bottom of that panel, I remember, there's the classic phrase, "To be continued." And I feel as though that hunting scenario, we're all continuing that to some extent, whether for real. I have a good friend in Montana who lives that out, who literally is picking up droppings and sniffing them and following trails of spittle.
- 1.46** What's weird is he's not even a hunter. It's just a hobby.
- 1.47** Right. But, yeah, and to some extent, I see this in Gregg's work. Gregg's work—you may have noticed this reading it—he always has a dog in there somewhere. And the dog is often a major—sometimes it's like comic relief because the dog is not interested in the major story at all. The dog is off sniffing, looking for a bone or something, instead of following the trail. But often the dog is really integral to the whole thing. So if I can just quote a couple of lines from, well, one from *The Nowhere Man*.
- 1.48** "For a second, he considered"—this is a couple of Dobermans who turn up—"for a second, he considered shooting them so he could rush after René," who's the bad guy. "But they were dogs, and even bad dogs deserve the benefit of the doubt." I was so glad that he didn't shoot the dog in that story, I remember. But now here we come in what your Y. A. young adult book, *The Rains*. Gregg writes at the end of it, as it were, like a dedication, "No Rhodesian Ridgebacks were harmed in the writing of this book." And often, Rhodesian Ridgebacks, they're probably your preferred dog. Now, tell us about what is the secret significance? Because this is your signature, I think, the dog, and specifically the Rhodesian Ridgeback. I mean, Ian Fleming, Lee Child, they do not have the Rhodesian Ridgeback.
- 1.49** Well, I think they're the perfect animal. I mean, they're bred by you Brits, who were in Rhodesia. There was a small ridge dog in Rhodesia when they were there that was fearless, that would go up and attack and corner lions. And so they bred them with Great Danes for height and mastiffs for breadth and sight and scent hounds. And they built the—I like a very doggy-looking dog. They're a very classical-looking dog. And they built this perfect lion hunter-tracker. So they're magnificent animals. So in some ways, they're the ultimate hunter.

- 1.50** The hunting thing—it's very interesting just to step back to Freud for one moment because we were talking about the archetypal, and you included him with Sherlock Holmes. I was obsessed with Freud. This marriage— I always feel like if you follow your interest, it doesn't make any sense as you're moving forward and all of a sudden you look back and they've knit together into a tapestry. So I was obsessed with Freud. I was obsessed with even—and there's a marriage in the Hitchcock. There's that wonderful Dalí. I don't know if you know this designed in Spellbound. There was a dream sequence that Hitchcock hired Dalí to design that's based on Freudian imagery.
- 1.51** Well, Freud's case studies read short stories. They're these perfect short stories, right? And so you have Freud who's writing the personal, and Jung's writing about the archetypal. And I was so embedded in both of them. But there is a hunting aspect. So for me, dog are—there's such a great animal purity. One of the things you point out is the dogs are there for comic relief. They're so tough, they're so loyal, and they'll also collapse on the floor and lick themselves when it's least convenient, right? Having them there in the real form, I don't write super dogs who can communicate like Lassie. It's a pinning down to primal instincts. And so they feature very prominently in my books.
- 1.52** The other thing that I'll say is, when you're writing fiction, you can kill kids, you can kill women, you can drop atomic bombs, you can do anything. There's two things you cannot do or you'll hear about it till your death. One of them is if you kill a cat or a dog—like, especially the cat people, they'll come after you. You can be dead and buried and they'll disinter and bring you out just to scream at you more, though I haven't killed a cat. And you can't make a gun mistake, especially in a book that features guns.
- 1.53** Because the gun guys will come after you?
- 1.54** Well, they just know. It's like, you don't want to get that wrong because then you're writing a tough guy thriller or tough girl thriller, whatever you're writing. You're writing a scene that revolves around weaponry or ordnance, and then you're dropping something in. I have—we get to this issue when we talk about experts and consultants. It's very important to get details right. But with Ridgebacks, I've had four Ridgebacks, so I get to be the subject matter on that front, which is very enjoyable.
- 1.55** OK, we'll come back to the question of dogs. I know that at some stage, but I wonder if I can ask the question to which that funny word, "apotropaic", is perhaps an answer. What is the point of writing? Or what is the purpose of writing? And specifically, what I tend to think of as forensic fiction, I know sometimes this dread phrase "genre fiction" is used. You might want to address that, but we could talk about thrillers, mysteries, and so on. But the word "apotropaic" is kind of a fun word, from the Greek, of course—apo and trepein, to turn away. And I'm giving the image of the Greek vase with those eyes painted on it, the idea of the eyes being that they would, that they are apotropaic eyes, that they would ward off evil in some ways, specifically if you're drinking a potion. Hopefully, no one has poisoned that potion.

- 1.56 And I wondered if this useful theory of the eyes and so on, is that what—you know, you mentioned some of the terrible things that could happen in one of your books, excluding the killing of dogs, thank goodness, and cats. But is the idea of writing them so that that might not happen in reality? That to some extent you're recording those things because they're real, but the idea of reasserting them in some way— is the theory behind that, or at the back of your mind, "OK, it would be great to put an end to that in some way, to ward off that evil"?
- 1.57 Well, I think you're talking too consciously about what's subconscious. So for me, well, for me, I just think of a story, and it's amazing because I've written books. I wrote a book that I completed the entire book and went back and looked at it a year after I wrote it and thought, "Oh, that's about my complete fear or terror about the new vulnerability of becoming a parent." It's apparent as you could see, if you read the plot. It's not like this is some deep reading of the text. But when I'm writing it, I'm just writing a story. And so they tend to overlap. I don't tend to move from the abstract towards the personal. I tend to move in story and images.
- 1.58 And that's one of the things that's continuously terrifying, I think, about being a writer or an artist of any type, because you don't know where it's coming from. And so you don't know if that tap is going to turn off. And we can get to this when we talk about discipline, which I think is coming in a bit. But for me, it always has to be these germs of—it's often when a character meets an ethical dilemma that they would handle differently than anybody else.
- 1.59 If you present a dilemma or conflict or a situation, and your protagonist is going to engage with it in the way that most of us would, it's not really a story, right? So what's the unique thing in the character that's going to match the unique circumstance, and they're smashed together? And it's a compelling scenario enough for me to make the decision to spend more waking hours with it over the next year than I do with my family because that's what it is, right? I'm writing 8, 10 waking hours a day. Sometimes. And so, it's not that, but it is that, but I don't know that it's that.
- 1.60 Right. Yeah. OK. I get that. I wonder if we can come back to the question of myth because it strikes me reading your work that there are a few recurrent myths that come up again and again. And one I was particularly struck by, Theseus and the Minotaur. Talking of great psychoanalysts, one thing I retained from the French psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan is the word "lack" because it's built into his name. And it strikes me that myth arises out of a feeling of lack, that if God is not available to us, we're going to invent God. If a hero is not available to us, we're going to invent a hero.
- 1.61 And one of the archetypal heroes, I think, is Theseus. And the story of Theseus and the Minotaur, which I'm sure everyone is familiar with, but I was struck, I think, recently reading about our very own Prince Harry, that he's a kind of a Theseus type, an outsider prince who has to some extent lost his way and has to go and tackle the monster. And I just wondered if the idea of particularly—well, the Minotaur is, of course, in the

labyrinth. And so the hero has to descend into the labyrinth in order to tackle the monster. And I wondered if that—and I'm going to quote a couple of examples that struck me. So there's one from *Into the Fire*.

- 1.62 "One more time, he'd shatter through into the underworld. And if he could make it back alive, carry someone out of damnation. One more time, sacrificing a pound of his flesh to win a piece of his soul. And then in the rains, I was already following," sorry, "I was following the already dead out of the cemetery, like some mythological hero trying to escape the underworld." So I suppose I was thinking, are you conscious of the myth that underlies your narrative? Are you trying to escape it? Change it in some way?
- 1.63 With this, I very much am. So let's do a quick Jungian archetypal myth breakdown, just so that we all have context for it. So often whether it's *Beowulf*—let's do a classic dragon myth. So dragon is terrorizing, or a monster of some sort, is terrorizing the castle. Everybody holes up and they're terrified. It comes in, it grabs them, and it devours them. If you hide from that which you fear, it gets stronger and stronger and eats you and eats your children. You can't hide from it. So the hero is the one who voluntarily goes forth. That's the key. To voluntarily chooses to go forth. Often he has a shield, and the shield has a cross on the shield. So he's bearing a mark of civilization. He goes forth to find and confront the dragon. That's the colossal unknown, that which you fear.
- 1.64 And when he goes and confronts the dragon, what's the dragon guarding? Gold and treasure. Why does a dragon need gold or treasure? It doesn't make any sense. There's nothing. It's completely illogical. You kill the dragon if you manage to, and the treasure is representative of some piece of self-knowledge that you then have access to, or often it's a maiden in distress, which is also the marriage of the anima, the Jungian feminine, or it's reversed if it's the feminine to the masculine, which it less often is.
- 1.65 And so basically, you venture forth voluntarily to go to an underworld to confront something that's deadly. You pass trials and travails. You slay that which you fear, and then treasure is your reward. The thing of value is in the place that's the most dangerous. I talked about how Jung wrote about alchemy, the transference of base matter into gold. Well, all the ingredients in that is like, "Well, we need a jewel found in a toad's head." The thing of greatest value found in the biggest filth. Well, that's also the Freudian cathartic technique. You're terrified from trauma in your childhood that you've repressed. Go to the place that feels the filthiest, the most filled with shame. You probe it deeply and you release something, but it's painful. It's a descent to the underworld.
- 1.66 And the last stage is, you bring that back to culture. So that's *Beowulf* coming back with Grendel's paw and nailing it above the mantle. You bring something back then to share with others. And so that process exists on almost every level. So it exists on a big story front that we read that's grand. But the psychologist, Piaget, talked about, with kids, when they're learning, it's a process constantly of learning, of assimilation and

accommodation, how we take in new information. We accommodate it, we assimilate it. And any process of learning is a process of a bit of you dying. You can't learn something new. If you learn something new, there's some old worldview that atrophies and falls away to make room for the new thing.

- 1.67** And so it's this constant cycle, and you can see it in almost everything. If you learn something new that's an epiphany, it's cracking open a previous version of your understanding. If you have an argument with a friend or a spouse or a girlfriend or a boyfriend, and are willing or are humbled enough to concede that you're wrong when you're wrong, it's not the issue. It's not the clothes on the floor or where you're going to go on vacation. It's attached to some part of you of why you're holding with a tyrannical grip onto something that's making you stubborn. And if you acknowledge that and you can concede what that is, there's a part of awareness that you have that goes all the way to the core. It's a little symbolic thing at the top and it drops all the way down.
- 1.68** And so you eradicate that. And that's what you're trying to do in the course of your relationships. That's what you're trying to do in life. That's what you're trying to do when we learn something. "Oh, I always thought of the world this way, and now I have a new understanding of it." If you go to a new country, if you see a different culture of people who were once exotic to you, and all of a sudden you step through the looking glass and you just see the humanity in the eyes and the smiles, and you're integrated and have a different understanding of a culture, your old view of them as a distanced other dissolves and dies. So it's the process of how we assimilate almost everything in our learning. And books are bigger, more grand, projected on a giant screen version of that process, but that's what we're training when we're reading, in a lot of ways.
- 1.69** I can't help but wonder if—I'm just going to throw up a quote here that, although we've talked about myth, it strikes me that one of the things that you're doing is to de-mythify your own stories. And it's just a little quote. Joey is the sidekick hacker of Evan Smoak. And she's often making rather sarcastic and caustic remarks to him. So she describes him in this line here. This is from *The Last Orphan*. "The Nowhere Man, savior of the desperate and lost, champion of the downtrodden, paragon of white knighthery." She's almost satirizing what he's getting up to. And is that part of what you have to do as a writer, not be too much in love with your own hero?
- 1.70** Well, that's Lee Child, the author of *Jack Reacher*, talks about that he doesn't particularly like *Jack Reacher* at times. I feel that way. I feel like if you're too adoring of your characters, nobody wants that. It's funny when I taught a fiction course and I asked everyone to write down a description of themselves, and then we read it, and everybody was sort of charmingly self-deprecating. And nobody wrote, "I'm incredibly good-looking, I'm the smartest person in the room, and I'm amazing," because no one wants to hear that. No one wants to read that. So don't do that with your characters

either. Find a point of—don't write, "They're the best of the best," 19-year-old Gregg Hurwitz. Find a different way in that has them be accessible.

- 1.71** But one of the things is that I play with deconstruction. So Orphan X, basically, just to give a bit of backstory, taken out of a foster home at the age of 12, he's trained to be an assassin, sort of away from the world. And the line for me around which this series in this world coalesces is when his father figure and handler, Jack John, says to him, "The hard part won't be making you a killer. The hard part is keeping you human." And that's the tragic flaw embedded in him because those two things don't go together. And at some point, he leaves the program and becomes a pro bono assassin while he's on the run from the program that's pursuing him. And he takes these cases that—and I say he doesn't, he never learned to speak the strange language of intimacy. So in some ways, he's like Pinocchio and he wants to be a real boy. And it's about that process.
- 1.72** So for me, this series, the Orphan X series, is very much about his thawing out of a set of rules. He operates by the Assassin's Ten Commandments, but he's breaking all the Commandments. He's breaking into a new definition of himself. And part of that process is, there's a number of things in the early books that I establish that are these tropes of the series, like things that he says. He always answers the phone and says, "Do you need my help?" That's his sort of phrase. Well, by the time we get to the fifth book, I have a scene where he's fallen over on his back in humiliating fashion, and the phone rings, and he answers on his back and says, "Do you need my help?"
- 1.73** I start to play with the motifs so that it's not just this continuous badassery. I'm thawing him into the intimate real world because one of the tropes of the series is how a character who should be archetypal—he should be like Clint Eastwood or Jason Bourne—but he exists and lives among real people. And he's constantly, he can garrote somebody, a child molester in a Turkish bath, but he's completely undone having to make small talk at the mail slots of the residential tower where he lives in the penthouse. So it's this constant negotiation.
- 1.74** And in the series, part of what happens is, I want all the other characters in some ways not to undermine him, but to pick at him and to pull at him so that when he does do something that's interesting and unlikely, that we at least feel like I'm not building him up too much. And so he's like Ulysses, the man of many wiles. He's not the best shot. He's not the biggest guy like Reacher. He's not the best shot like Swagger. He's not the best-looking guy like James Bond. He has to bring the totality of himself to a mission to succeed. So he's constantly dealing with people who are better than him at one thing. So it's also a process of humility, as he moves forward. But at the end of the day, he's the hero.
- 1.75** You mentioned the Commandments, and this might be an appropriate point to give Jordan Peterson a little bit of a shout-out here, actually, because another thing that struck me— Jordan Peterson is kind of like equivalent to the Rhodesian Ridgeback to some extent, actually.

- 1.76 You should tell him that.
- 1.77 In that, he pops up regularly in odd moments. So, for example, here in this little—there are Post-Its around the house of Mia, who lives in Castle Heights, isn't it? There's the same apartment building. Says Peterson, "Compare yourself to who you were yesterday, not to someone else's today." And then Prodigal Son, another quotation of Peterson: "Do not hide unwanted things in the fog." OK, now that last line completely bamboozles me. I still don't know what it's all about. Maybe that's the point of it. But I was wondering, coming across the piece in quotations, to some extent are your books like a manual, partly exercise in positive thinking, or not exactly how-to self-improvement. But there's an element of that in your works, isn't there? I mean, you're sort of giving people advice on how to live better lives.
- 1.78 I don't approach it that way. Again, that's what happens, but that's not the intention and the motivation. So basically, so Jordan and I go back quite a ways, and he had this list of rules for life on Quora that was getting some attention. I had Orphan X as being raised with these Ten Assassin's Commandments that are like, "Assume nothing. How you do anything is how you do everything." And I wanted a more positive version of this. So he lives in a penthouse and downstairs from him is a single mother who's raising an 8-year-old boy. And I wanted her to have more positive, instead of "never kill an innocent," to be giving him advice to actually function in the world.
- 1.79 Right. So I thought, oh, well, pain and suffering, which is what Smoak is usually going on.
- 1.80 Right. So I was like, oh, well, I'll just include Jordan, my friend, this not-enormously-widely-known-then professor. This should be uncontroversial. And so I started to have that as a kind of counterweight, right, to again, the world of the archetypal, the Ten Assassin's Commandments, to rules of functioning in life, which Evan looks at this 8-year-old boy, and Evan being a foster kid himself, and an orphan, as many heroes are from Moses to Superman, has some affinity for because this boy's father passed away. And he's being raised properly in the world of intimacy to function. And Evan is sort of outside with his hands up to the glass, looking in.
- 1.81 And so that was part of the movement that is drawing him forward, not just through the individual stories, but through the body of work, because you want to have—I want to have somewhere to go that each book is building and moving somewhere different. But I'm not thinking in my head, "Let me write a self-help manual in the form of a thriller." I'm thinking, "What's the best thriller?" What are the ways thematics come together? And when they do, when you focus on the work—
- 1.82 So a key piece of advice is, you never want, as the author, you never want to be present in the story. Your thinking, and your desires, and what you think the character should do. The best thing to be is that you have the story and you recede behind the veil. And so there's types of language that I'll use. There's times I'll use fancy words. It has to be

all in keeping of the context. I never want someone to feel like Gregg Hurwitz is butting his head into the pages and having an opinion about something. And so it's a very weird dance because when you're creating, everything has to be subservient to the story and the characters.

- 1.83** Right. I think it was Flaubert, wasn't it? He said, "The author has to be everywhere but nowhere." Hence, The Nowhere Man is a good kind of analogy for that. But I wonder if I can ask you to—because you use the word archetype—and to come to Gregg's current book, well, actually, I said current. The book The Last Orphan is due out next month, in fact, actually. So this is a quotation in advance of that publication. And I wondered if, Gregg, you wanted to read that. If you want to be these two characters— Evan Smoak, the great hero, and Tommy Stojack, who is Evan's armorer.
- 1.84** Nine-and-a-half-fingered armorer, early UDT diver, like a crusty old war vet.
- 1.85** I don't know where you got him from, but he's a brilliant character.
- 1.86** I had a dear, dear friend. I take last names from baseball players and spec-ops guys. And his last name was Stojack, though I didn't name him. He passed away. I didn't name him when he was alive because spec-ops guys don't want their name. But everyone knew. People would be on an airplane, they'd read it and go and call them and say, "This is you." So he goes to him. Somebody calls him an archetype. Again, I'm poking at the convention.
- 1.87** Yeah, I think it's one of the bad guys who says to him, "So you're some kind of archetype."
- 1.88** And so Evan, later on, is having a drink with Tommy Stojack. He says, "Do you think guys like you and me, that we're archetypes?" And Tommy says, "Deep down, everyone's an archetype of one sort or another. There are no new stories. You can take the man out of mythology, but you can't take the mythology outta man." Evan thought that even if he didn't want to be an archetype, he sure as hell didn't mind acting like one from time to time.
- 1.89** You were actually thinking about, "Well, am I making my hero an archetype? Or do I need to—" You've got your hero worrying about being an archetype, which is very unusual, I think, as it were, pondering a Jungian sort of question.
- 1.90** Yeah. Well, part of that is, one of the things people forget is to start to deviate and play with a form. One of the biggest mistakes that beginning writers make, me included, is when you start a project, often people say, "Well, what genre is it?" It's like, "Well, it's kind of young adult and it's a thriller, but it's also a postmodern take on a thriller." And it's like, "What section in the bookstore does it go in?" When we're starting to hybridize something that we're going to recreate the whole world, starting out tends to happen more often. But it's like you can't do that unless you—I don't want to say master the form, you never master any art, you just don't. But until you have intimate familiarity

with the form, you can't start to disassemble or rotate it like a Rubik's Cube. And so I wrote Orphan X 16 novels in, and I didn't start really playing with it in this fashion until many, many books into the series—four, five, six, seven.

- 1.91** And so people forget, you know, Picasso could paint realism exceptionally well. No one thinks of it that way because you think of later Picasso, but he could draw realist paintings in a way that's just jaw-dropping. Then he started to play. Then he started to manipulate the form. And so for artists and writers starting out, there's a difference between, and we're going to talk later about maintaining your voice—what's the thing that you're bringing that's unique to you? But you really want to pay attention to fulfilling the requirements of the form first, knowing how to fill that properly, before you start to play with it. Whatever the form is, I don't mean something that's some sort of strictly ordered structure, but you need to know what you're doing within a form, whatever the art is, particularly in writing, before you start to play around with it.
- 1.92** I know you're very conscious of your precursors, and I wonder if I can ask you to read out the dedication. This is from the first Orphan X book. I've actually shortened it, but it gives us some of your reference points.
- 1.93** To all the bad boys and girls, rule breakers and vigilantes—Philip Marlowe and Sam Spade, Bruce Wayne and Jason Bourne, Bond and Bullitt, Joe Pike and Jack Reacher, Hawk and Travis McGee, the Seven Samurai and the Magnificent Seven, the Lone Ranger, Robin Hood, Beowulf and Gilgamesh, Ellen Ripley and Sarah Connor, Jack Bauer, Dirty Harry, for being so wicked, they're good.
- 1.94** So you had all those models in your mind to some extent when you came up with Orphan X. Was part of your imperative then to do something different at the same time?
- 1.95** I was terrified to start this series. I mean, I wrote 4 other novels putting it off because I thought to write someone. And there's a piece of reading I'd like to recommend to everybody watching, and you can get the transcript online. There's an amazing conversation between Lawrence Kasdan, Steven Spielberg, and George Lucas as they're developing Indiana Jones. And you see the development in real time of, like—you can find it online. "What's a different weapon? Do we use this? Do we use that? Well, how about a whip? How about a hat? How about if the hat has a personality to it?" And you're seeing these 3 masters developing something new, something that is iconic.
- 1.96** And so for me, having read these types of stories from a young age, and I list so many of them, I wanted to wait until I had a handle on what the anchors were that could differentiate an Orphan X story from a Bourne story, from a Reacher story, from a Bond story. And what you want is for every aspect of character, and it's so tricky, this is in any form of writing, if it's your original character, writing for preexisting or Batman or other, that's a different tightrope walk. But you want every interaction to be unique to the character, right?

- 1.97** So what's a James Bond action scene? It has to be distinctive. An Orphan X action scene can't be like what a Bourne scene is. It has to function differently. His engagement with a scene has to be different. Reacher is huge. Reacher handles things differently. Evan looks—in every book, I say, "He's just an ordinary guy, not too good-looking." That's a line. He blends in. He's the Nowhere Man. So I needed to figure out what all these pieces were, and that's what you do.
- 1.98** I don't want to say building a brand. It's so cynical. But when you have Kasdan and Lucas and Spielberg engaging about how do we create an exciting new adventure with the exciting, different hero that's at the center of it, right, you can sort of engage in that and you see all the things that need to come together if you want to create something that's worthy of its place, possibly worthy of its place, in that pantheon. And it's a great deal of thought because it's very easy to slip back into pale imitations of previous works.
- 1.99** And you talked about the anxiety of influence, let's say, previous influences. And you mentioned Shakespeare earlier. Can we take a detour into Shakespeare?
- 1.100** Of course.
- 1.101** So we think of Shakespeare, of course—if he'd just written the Sonnets, he'd would be considered one of the greatest writers in the history of all writing. I was going to say the English tradition, but anywhere. But the Tempest is the only play that's wholly unique. It's the only one when he dreamed up, right? The histories come from Plutarch. Merchant of Venice is from the Jew of Malta. He's taking old stories and he polished them up. And to a certain extent, when people talk about people selling out in Hollywood, it's not like Michelangelo could paint whatever he wanted on the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel, right? So when he's taking Plutarch, when he's taking the histories, he's polishing the right parts of it to please Queen Elizabeth. That's the right lineage. When in the Jacobian era, you start to see ghosts and Macbeth, the witches start to creep in, he's writing to the interests of those who are paying, those he has to please.
- 1.102** And Hamlet perhaps becomes genuinely mad, or at least we don't know. There's a mystery and indeterminacy.
- 1.103** And the genius isn't like—aside from the Tempest, which is his farewell to the stage. It's so deeply, deeply moving in so many ways, but we won't detour into the Tempest, though I'd love to. But he's taking these old things and what the magic is—like the Jew of Malta is just a very anti-Semitic play. And even though people talk about the Merchant of Venice as being so in certain regards, Shylock is an amazingly dimensionalized character by comparison. The magic is from taking something that preexists and shaping it into something new.
- 1.104** Well, why is that familiar? Well, that's what genre does. You have Raymond Chandler and Dashiell Hammett and James M. Cain to Robert B. Parker, who wrote the Spenser: For Hire series, to Robert Crais and Michael Connelly and Lee Child. What are these

tropes? It's a private eye. And Robert B. Parker, who I adore, was the first one to take the private eye and set him in the real world, where Spenser cooks, and he's got a very, very smart girlfriend, Susan Silverman, who's a psychologist, who is his common interlocutor. And so we take these older themes and we evolve and we develop them.

1.105 And so what are other ways that Shakespeare—my argument is that Shakespearean tragedy, it's genre, right? They're highly structured, narrative-driven tales of lust, intrigue, and murder, designed to sell out and put asses in seats to sell at the Globe Theater, night after night. And you cut that Globe Theater in half and you have a perfect cross-section of Elizabethan society. You have the groundlings in the pit. You have royalty up there. The language has to work on multiple levels. Like when you see a Pixar movie, what's so wonderful about them is that they're incredibly engaging for kids. And then there's so much humor and insight for adults and for the parents. It's four-quadrant entertainment.

1.106 So Shakespeare will make a glancing reference to Ovid's *Metamorphosis* and then make a joke about being drunk, like, being drunk that adds to your desire and then makes you impotent. Like, from *Macbeth*, he'll make a joke for the groundlings, and he's vacillating to keep all the plates spinning, to have everybody enthralled at different levels all the time. And so that's the aim. And so if we think about, you talked about genre and how genre, it's like, what was Dickens? What was Shakespeare? He wasn't even writing things down for posterity. But Dickens was a bestseller. And then further to this point, Camus' *The Stranger*, the basis of that, or one of the inspirations for that is Camus, *The Postman Always Rings Twice*. He's borrowing from genre into something that then is considered sort of a French masterpiece. Well, it's from an American hardboiled masterpiece.

1.107 And additionally, I just went back and was rereading *Crime and Punishment*. And as I was looking at it with Dostoevsky, this theme of creeping the guilt, right? And the way that it's eating at him. And I thought this has so much in common with Edgar Allan Poe. And I went back through Dostoevsky's notes, and what did I discover? He's a huge fan of Edgar Allan Poe, right? There's all this cross-stitching, because reading *Crime and Punishment*, the counterpart is *The Tell-Tale Heart*, the short story of Poe's that he—where the guys killed somebody, buried them under the floorboards, and he hears the heart, and he hears the heart, it drives him crazy, and he's being interviewed, and he finally tears up the floorboards and reveals himself. Well, that's an iteration of *Crime and Punishment*.

1.108 And so it's very hard to distinguish genre. If something's bestselling, if something's—it's not like Dostoevsky was riding around in the height of glory from his sales. That doesn't necessarily matter. What sells the most doesn't matter. But a propulsiveness, the hunt, that's what strings us along. We're forward with anticipation.

1.109 Yeah, you're reminding me about Camus, that, who modeled himself on Humphrey Bogart. And if you look at him in the photographs taken during the war period, he's

always very careful—I'm doing it right now— to turn his collar up like this because he thinks it looks more, you know, detective-style. That's why he cultivated the trench coat because Camus came to New York after the Second World War and was taken to be a Bogart of literature. And I do think a trench coat look was part of that. But I was reminded when you were talking about Shakespeare and drunkenness and Falstaff and all that, is there a slight Falstaff element in Evan Smoak, specifically to do with vodka? Shakespeare missed out on vodka, I think, actually.

- 1.110** And I was struck by this line, again, in *The Last Orphan*. "He admired vodka. Base elements put through a rigorous process, distilled and filtered until the result was transformed into its purest essence. As a scrawny boy, Evan had undergone a similar process himself." So it's explicitly allegorical. But vodka, was that—I mean, was that one of your finds, your discoveries? Did that hit you as a sudden inspiration? Or was it you happened to be drinking vodka at the time you were writing, and you thought, "I know. We'll just slip this in there." But how did that happen?
- 1.111** So it's the opposite of Falstaffian.
- 1.112** Right. Yeah, because he doesn't lose it.
- 1.113** Because he drinks it. There's that moment: "I know thee not, old man," right? For how to emerge as a king, he has to get rid of his drunken associations of the past, and it breaks Falstaff's heart. And Evan, everything is precise. It's much more like the hat in Indiana Jones, let's say. Personally, if we're going to talk about booze, which I'm always happy to talk about, my personal preference is bourbon and Scotch. I love vodka also. But it's another thing where I talk about everything should accrue to character. Everything should point to character. And vodka is the purest of all the alcohols. And Evan is obsessed with purity. He's the Nowhere Man. And so it's almost a self-purification process. He has one drink. He never drinks more. He's never out of control.
- 1.114** And so the choice of what he drinks, and it's not actually a reference to James Bond, interestingly, though, of course, he famously had his martinis. That's it. By the way, it's another element, if you think about with James Bond, when we talk about the importance of character, I think of the key of story when people say, "What's more important plot or character?", I literally think of plot as character in motion. I don't see a separation of them. I think every fight scene should have something to do with character. Every interaction, the dialogue, what alcohol they drink, everything should be about character.
- 1.115** But to give an example, if we go to James Bond, if you stop someone and say, "What's your favorite James Bond action sequence?", people stop for a minute and think. And if you say, "How's James Bond take his martini?", everybody knows the answer to that. The character flourishes are what's key. You want to see a particular character with particular idiosyncrasies. So Evan's always admiring this distillation process, this purification process, that's symbolic for his own process, having been raised so

ascetically under such, like, grueling training, because he goes through an alchemical process. He's a twelve-year-old scrawny kid. He's the smallest kid in a foster home. And he's hammered and beaten and forged into the perfect weapon, an expendable weapon, a disposable weapon.

- 1.116** And so the vodka and what he drinks, everything should be a choice when you're writing. Every detail matters. The second commandment, in fact, from Evan Smoak, is "how you do anything is how you do everything." And so when you're writing or creating art of any kind, there's no gimmies. If there's a movie on in the background of a scene, if there's a character, if there's language choice, if there's references, you want to pay attention to every single detail. Every detail is an opportunity to make your characters distinct and to make your story, to give it a ring of verisimilitude.
- 1.117** A quick thriller note, by the way—I know we're going to talk about research later, so I don't want to detour too much into that. But one of the necessities for doing research, and we'll have some good stories, I believe, coming up in the series, which I'm happy to share. But you want to be out in the field in certain regards to pick up those details that make a scene real, that have telling detail that makes something ring, but that also is deserving of its place. Because if you're just writing something that's a scene that everybody's written, it becomes a conglomeration of every movie, every TV show, every book that you've already read. And so when you're there, though, things change.
- 1.118** I want to give another example from the great Thomas Harris. This is in Hannibal, where there's an image in first the book and then the film, where there's a stakeout and there's a bunch of guys, like a strike team, waiting outside. They're waiting to capture and they're in a van and they're sitting on a block of dry ice. It's like, why are they sitting on a block of dry ice? Well, if you're in a van on a stakeout, you can't have the air conditioning running because the car is on. And then it's obvious that you're in a stakeout. So there's this great moment where they kick open the back doors, in both the book and the film, and this mist pours out and these guys come out. It's a fully armed SWAT team, and they're emerging through the mist.
- 1.119** And so the mist isn't just there, like when Michael Bay sprays down the streets and everything's gleaming. It's not like a Hollywood magic moment. It's from a detail that arises naturally, and it provides ambiance because you pick something that is a telling piece of reality that then imbues the scene with mood and adds to the atmosphere of the scene. But it's based in reality. And so you're carrying the reader across the suspension of disbelief in some of these choices.
- 1.120** Now, I've got something potentially embarrassing to ask you about now, because just in case people think that Gregg Hurwitz is some kind of superhero, I have to reveal that he's also all the bad guys he has ever invented. I mean, he comes up with these evil plots that Evan Smoak has to deconstruct in some way. So, well, there's a very interesting thing that you said, writing about Batman and his counterparts, his villains. I mean, perhaps, well, you wrote this. Perhaps you'd like to read it out.

- 1.121** Let's see what I said. Let's see if I was articulate at all. "As I discovered when writing Penguin: Pain and Prejudice," well, let me step back. I wrote for Marvel initially. I wrote Punisher. This was in my comic book adventures, later when I'd had six books published about. I got a call from the executive editor of Marvel and wrote Punisher, I wrote Wolverine, and then I went over to DC, and they asked me, "Who do you want to write?" And I said, "Well, I'd love to write—there's a wonderful Alan Moore Joker origin story called Killing Joke. And it's the seminal, it gives the depth of the Joker character. The Joker, of course, has been imagined again and again at all kinds of levels. And Penguin always was this ridiculous squawky character from the '70s TV show. And I thought he was deserving of that. I said, "What I really want to write is a Penguin origin story." And that's not the answer anybody was expecting, right? Because usually I'd say I want to write Superman or Flash or Green Lantern.
- 1.122** And I still remember there was a poll online where they said, "What series are you looking forward to the most?" And there was a poll and there was 5 things listed, and Penguin: Pain and Prejudice was one of them. And I think I got 0.0013% of the vote. And my favorite all-time trolling anonymous comment where somebody said, "I'm really glad Hurwitz's mom voted for him." So it was like a series that was anticipated by nobody. But what happened was that it came out and it resonated with critics, in part from the way that I approached it, and then basically from there pivoted in and I wound up writing and reinventing a lot of the characters for Batman into Batman.
- 1.123** The lesson for that for me was don't write the biggest thing. Don't ask for the most commercial thing. I had this story in my head. It's a very important lesson for younger writers. It's like, write the thing that you're passionately driven to write, even if only your mom is going to vote for you online, even if nobody's anticipating it. Be driven by that interest, because then if you create something new from that, you don't know what'll expand. Versus if I'd written Superman, who I don't have a particular relationship with, maybe I would have written a mediocre Superman, and then I get to go around and say, "I wrote a Superman."
- 1.124** So you fully identified with the Penguin? And this was an interview, wasn't it? Yeah.
- 1.125** So I said, "As I discovered when writing Penguin: Pain and Prejudice, Batman fits uniquely with the villains in his rogue's gallery. There are two sides of the same coin, yin and yang, ego and shadow. But in some cases, maybe the match is even closer. Maybe instead of ego and shadow, it's shadow and shadow."
- 1.126** So that's what takes me back to, yeah, Clayface. "I didn't just act like my characters. I became them." And to my way of thinking, Clayface, villain though he is, provides a bit of a model for Gregg Hurwitz, that you are becoming your own characters to some extent. So you had to become the Penguin. You have to become, I know, René, for example—this extremely bad guy who kidnaps people, steals all their money, and then kills them, typically, and tries to do the same job as Smoak. Yeah. I mean, which is a

really bad idea, and I'm not recommending that to anyone. But where did that ghastly idea come from? I mean—

- 1.127** So part of what—the job of a writer, I think more than almost any other, is to be open to opportunity. You have to embody your characters in a way that's even uncomfortable. And so when I was thinking about Penguin, it's like Penguin fits uniquely in the rogue's gallery, and that I think he's the only one of Batman's villains who isn't insane. Joker's insane, Riddler's insane. You go down the list. And I thought, if you're Penguin, he's short, he's fat, he's unattractive, who's Batman? Batman is a bully. So when I'm writing a story from his perspective, I don't want to just write a story, literally, and I wrote about his history of trauma, his older brothers who were horrible to him. He had a father who was disgusted with him at first sight and dropped him when he was born.
- 1.128** And so when Batman swings in and shatters through the glass window and punches 4 people, I even have him out of frame and Penguin's looking up. He just humiliates him. And so when you're going to write a character, you have to embody that character all the way down. You don't make them a straw man or a punching bag in order to make your villain, your protagonist, greater. You have to be willing to go there.
- 1.129** Quick other story. I did an adaptation at one point—it's not produced—of a book called *Black Flags* that won the Pulitzer Prize. It's about the origin of Abu Musab al-Zarqawi, the ISIS member in Baghdad. He was sort of the fulcrum of the Iraq invasion, let's say. He was horrific. And he was planning a massive chemical bomb attack on Amman, capital of Jordan. It was the Mukhabarat, the Jordanian secret police, managed to avert it. And then he realized—he was very clever, unbelievably brilliant and horrific—that instead of having a big plan that can be disrupted, he could just kidnap one person and saw their head off, live. And he realized at that moment that broadband was getting more expansive in rural areas of America. And so he shot it to upload it in a format that would match that, so that he could depopularize the war's deeply personal terror.
- 1.130** He was like the Steve Jobs of terrorism in some ways. Steve Jobs thought about phones long enough till they were no longer phones. He altered them. He was almost, like, godlike. He thought about music until he altered music. And Zarqawi was like the horrible version of that. So I'm writing this series about his origin, and there's a lot about him that's unbelievably compelling, and he's brilliant and horrific. And I was embodying him because when you're writing a character, you're pulling on their mask and you want to see the world through their eyeholes. And so I wouldn't get too lost in a moral relativism. Every couple of weeks, I would go and I'd break out in a sweat and I would watch that video of the beheading of Nick Berg, because he beheads Nick Berg, to remember what it is that I'm dealing with, to not get too far in my—
- 1.131** Sympathy for the devil?

- 1.132** Well, I think like, connection with, to be able to write him from a position of sympathy from the inside out. It's not even sympathy, but just to embody him in a way. And that's what we're doing. Jordan and I have talked a lot about the art of listening. And Carl Rogers, the psychologist, is very interesting. There's this perspective shift that moved across all the arts and in psychology, when it's like, Einstein's Third Relativity, and then you have the Cubist movement, and then you have Faulkner writing *The Sound and the Fury*, one story told from four perspectives. Well, there's not a dissimilar thing as this sort of ripples across and that Rogers, instead of having Freud sit behind someone on a couch, sat face-to-face looking at a patient. It's another perspective shift in the field of psychology.
- 1.133** But part of what he said was that, to listen truly, you have to engage to listen with your nervous system. You have to take on what somebody is saying in a way that's complete. It's a version of what we want to do when we're reading a story. We embody a different nervous system that we learn from. And we see this, too, all the time in our personal relation. We know when somebody is listening, when we're defended. We know those bullshit apologies like, "Well, I'm really sorry you're upset." It's the affect. It's the nervous system. People can give you words that aren't nourishing. There's a moment when you embody the emotion of somebody. If it's a child, if it's a friend, and you take that on within yourself to become that almost. And that's a form of listening.
- 1.134** But that form is very—it can be dangerous. We see it right now in this incredibly polarized political and social environment. It's too dangerous for people to embody any understanding of other views for a lot of people because it's like, "I'll be unsafe, and then I'll slide in the other side. And if I'm the left, I'll turn on the right. If I'm the right, I'll turn on the left." They're not willing to engage, to really listen and get to the source of it. And to be a novelist, for me, is always, I'm fascinated by people. I'm fascinated by people even who do things that are abhorrent. And I try to occupy that experimentally, to not have to occupy and act out of my life.
- 1.135** And so it's a very weird thing that, at some stage, I realized that the process of trying to become a better writer is inextricably linked to me, the process of me trying to become a better person in some ways, because you have to have a confidence that you can contain the emotion of somebody else, that you can, in some sense, embody them and not lose your bearings, to be strong enough to go, in a certain sense, out into the unknown, out into that which scares you, and still know that you'll come back intact. You'll still get some piece of treasure, something you can learn for yourself.
- 1.136** But there's a loss in that. There's a dying in that, in a certain way, of yourself. And it's a fear that's governing people. I think we see it really clearly with this rigidity. There's a lot of conversations we have with people now where they shut down. They use short phrases to shut down conversation. We have all sorts of ways that we short-circuit. It's like contentious topics. It's almost as if we're barking at the perimeter of contentious

topics, race and gender, to make sure that we don't have any real conversations that could take place on the fertile ground.

- 1.137** And so being an artist, being a writer, is a willingness to go into chaos. You're on that, the sort of sine wave of the yin-yang, and you're willing to go and encounter the chaotic and try to organize it into something that's orderly that people can contain. But it's also a story, so it's necessarily chaotic. It's not— if I could conclude what it is in a paper or an op-ed, in our opening quotation, a 6-paragraph blog post, if I could do that, I wouldn't have to write a story, because the story has deeper meanings that are encoded that cannot be summarized. It's chaotic. It's confusing. It's supposed to elicit things in people.
- 1.138** And so when I think of the yin-yang, the sine wave is here. But the two eyes I always think of in a certain regard as that's where your feet want to be positioned. You're like Colossus of Rhodes, astride the sine wave, between chaos and order. And you're trying to order and pull from the chaotic into the structure that is the story.
- 1.139** Well, if I can dare to summarize what Gregg has just been saying, I think he's saying, "Be weird or possibly weirder." And we might pause there and get really weird in the second half. OK, thank you. Thank you very much.
- 1.140** Thank you.

Lecture 2: Crafting Stories

At a glance — Crafting stories.

- 2.1 Gregg, I think we agree that there's a certain kind of madness to being a writer. And I think there's a degree of madness in your best-known hero, Evan Smoak, and specifically his quality of OCD. And I wondered—I've given a couple of quotations here to illustrate that point. Do you want to read them out?
- 2.2 "His condo, 7000 square feet of concrete and glass, was spare and spotless. The workout stations were buffed to a high sheen, unmarred by fingerprints. The brushed nickel kitchen appliance gave a catalog-clean sparkle, even in the semi-darkness, vodka bottles positioned equidistant from one another, 3 inches of clearance on either side."
- 2.3 So he's very fanatical about detail. He's also minimalist. Now, is that you, in essence? Are you transferring some of your characteristics to the hero?
- 2.4 We're having this conversation?
- 2.5 I just wondered about the OCD because, you know, doesn't a writer need to be OCD because you're, you know, doing that job day after day, getting back into the groove and repeating your moves, to some extent? Isn't that, you know, isn't Evan Smoak, to some extent, replicating the arc of the writer in this?
- 2.6 For me, yes, though I don't think that's the case. There's a lot of writers who are chaotic and messy, right? You walk into their office, and it's like tumbleweeds are blowing through. I have to be very meticulous. There's a quote I'm gonna butcher by Flaubert, where he says something like, "Let your life be orderly and predictable, that your creative life can be chaotic and wild," which is a very bad paraphrase. So once we look that up, don't attribute that to me, this misquote.
- 2.7 But Evan's second commandment, that he's taught—"how you do anything is how you do everything"—that's a governing principle in my life, that everything matters. Every detail matters. So you can see very clearly where, in times of anxiety or stress, and for him, we certainly see that emerge in *The Last Orphan*, that will get stuck on a loop in his head, and you can start, like, he'll start pressing the wrinkles out of the bedspread. And every time he does it, it pulls somewhere else. And he can get stuck on things in a certain way, but he needs everything pristine.
- 2.8 It also illuminates that transition that I was talking about, of him moving from being like he's Pinocchio and wants to be a real boy. Everything is controlled. So he goes out in the world on these missions, he's not OCD, which is very interesting. He's in the muck and the grime. He has to come back and take a steaming hot shower. And meticulously, he burns all his clothes from every mission as soon as he gets home, right? He wears the same clothes. He has 10 shirts and 10 pairs of pants and 10 Victorinox watches and 10, well, now, Vertex watches, and 10 original SWAT boots. And he'll burn them. And

he'll redress the same way every day, so that everything is his focus elsewhere and outward.

- 2.9** But also, when he goes downstairs, I mentioned earlier that there's a single mom who's a district attorney who's got an 8-year-old boy. And her house represents, in some ways, that strange language of intimacy. Humans are messy, right? So he goes down there, and she's got colors, and there's throw pillows and candles. That's where the Jordan Peterson quotations are stuck in Post-Its on the walls. And there's crayon mashed in the carpet. And it's real life. And he looks at it as something that he has a kind of longing for but can't quite access. It's another one of those instances where his face is pressed up to the glass and he's looking at the kind of life that he wants.
- 2.10** And part of the sort of Tantalus-like trap that he's stuck in is that he can never live an ordinary life like other ordinary people. But at least he can protect that for others. At least he can be the wolf who hunts wolves, right? To protect other people, so they can at least have the kind of ordinary life that he himself can never have.
- 2.11** You know, I feel I've failed in my research on Gregg Hurwitz because I haven't been to his house to check to see if he has a floating magnetic mattress, which Evan Smoak has. And I don't know, for those of you who haven't read the books, can you describe how this bed thing works? Because I'm not sure if it's, if it's real or, dare I say, you invented it. But the idea of a bed that is not touching the floor, is held in place by very powerful magnets—is that how you envisioned it?
- 2.12** First of all, Andy, when you do come visit me, what makes you think I'm gonna let you see my mattress? That's the first question that I want to present to you. That's a real bed. It's tethered by cables. And then there's, like, rare earth, powerful magnets that propel it, so it's on a metal slab. And it just floats. And then the cables, so if you severed the cables, it would fly through the roof. It's very minimalist, right? It's like slab, mattress, and he meditates on it. It's these very—
- 2.13** There's no base. It's like a hovercraft. It's sort of floating above the floor. That's brilliant.
- 2.14** It's the opposite, in certain ways, of Ulysses. Right, Penelope. The bed is built on the tree. There's a tree that's severed at the center of the house. It's grounded, right? It's grounded in the relationship that is their marriage. And the house is built around the severed trunk of the tree that's the base of the mattress. And Evan floats. He tries to be pristine. It's almost like he doesn't want to be fully human.
- 2.15** I bet he tucks his sheets in, really? Does he have sheets? He tucks them in really tight.
- 2.16** Crazy.
- 2.17** Yeah. Right? He hates them being crumpled. I didn't know other people in the audience, if you had any particular likes, or for that matter dislikes, in Gregg's work that you particularly wanted to draw attention to.

- 2.18** Is Evan a narcissist?
- 2.19** No. In a lot of ways, he's the opposite of a narcissist. He doesn't want to be seen. He doesn't want to be known. He asks for no credit, no money, no permission. So he's, in so many regards, the opposite of a lot of the other kinds of heroes. It's part of why he's the Nowhere Man. He just recedes. He doesn't want to leave a trace. He doesn't want credit for anything. He wants to—and he has this sort of Zen-like existence where he's at the periphery.
- 2.20** What about an intrinsic notion of control? Whereas he plays the role of God to decide on other people's lives? Yes, probably along those lines.
- 2.21** Yes. Well, control's dangerous. That's OCD, too, right? And his OCD tends to flare up when things are most out of control. Like, that's what happens with our weak spots, right? In a lot of ways, I feel like we all have, we all have whatever flaws we have that we kind of hurl ourselves against more and more to sharpen ourselves, to use then as a stone to cut ourselves open and see what's going on inside of us. And so that control thing is something that certainly is seething within him. But his code is pretty— it's a very strict code that he was raised with, but that piece of being raised to be a killer, but also the hardest part is him remaining human. That's the collision course that he was on.
- 2.22** And when he saw that his own moral compass wasn't aligned with the missions that the deep black program was sending him on, he's sort of left to try and align things with his own compass. And where he tends to intervene is where there's corruption, either codified or otherwise. But the thing that's pretty distinct about Evan, that I don't know if it exists in other characters, is that if he's ever caught, he'll never shoot a cop. He'll never shoot an innocent. And if he's ever caught, he would take the rap and go down, even to the point of being executed, because he understands the necessity for the rule of law.
- 2.23** So he understands and shoulders the responsibility of his transgressions in a way that's stated quite overtly. It's like, "If I'm ever caught, you should kill me. Cause what I'm doing doesn't work in a civilized society. But there's people who are disempowered sufficiently that they're being utterly terrorized by other humans. And I have a skillset to intervene on their behalf, and I'm willing to do that, but I'm also willing to bear the cross of those trespasses in order to preserve society at large." He doesn't say it in those terms, but that's his belief, and that's what he states. And so I think it removes him in a different way.
- 2.24** And it's not something that I know that we've seen in other heroes who are vigilantes. Certainly many don't kill cops. There's that piece. But his understanding that he has to exist as an outsider, necessarily, and that he is subject to the same rule of law that he moves against for people, that's a different wrinkle, I believe.

- 2.25** So, earlier at the beginning, you talked about the difference between writing from your mind, your heart, and your gut. Can you kind of elaborate more on what writing from your gut, not your mind, looks and feels like?
- 2.26** That's a really good and a very difficult question. Um, if I'm writing from my head, for me, that's where I feel like I'm inserting myself into the writing process, like I'm thinking too much. A lot of the questions that you're asking me that were, where I say, "That's too abstract," that's not the right place to come from, right? I want to write a scene now. There's two ways. One is logistics. If I'm being governed by logistics, well, I need this scene, so I can get from A to C, and I need to go through B. And so I'm doing it in a way that's almost utilitarian, where I'm constructing a plot just so that it's functional. That's not a good—I want to be driven by something that's sort of just beyond my grasp.
- 2.27** That's something that's really inherent in a lot of ways to good narrative. If you think about it, like, if we reference movies like *The Sixth Sense* or *The Usual Suspects*, it's those moments where something turns on us and we feel like it's shocking and makes perfect sense at the same time. And often it's turning a second before we see it, right, where we're, like, right there to the point of revelation, and then it slaps us in the face. But it makes sense. Those kinds of moments, I don't arrive at through my brain. I don't arrive at thinking my way to them. They tend to sort of emerge when I'm in a different state.
- 2.28** And I never mean to be precious about this and talk about, like, beckoning the muse, but it's like anything. There's a lot of processes that I have to set up that are cues to be in the right state of mind. And so writing from my gut means my head's not in it. Often when I'm doing that, I feel like I'm seeing what's happening, is the feeling that I have, and I'm just writing it down, and I'm almost watching it. And characters will do things in real time sometimes and be funnier than I am and have moves within the plot that I didn't think of. And there's these perfect character-related movements that feel almost like they're disassociated from me.
- 2.29** And my head is when I'm thinking through, and the head is where I think a lot of writers fall down. "Well, I took this structure seminar course, and I'm in the second act, and we now, I'm coming to the end of the third act, and we need the moment of apparent defeat before we're going to turn around on this." And it's great. You get color-by-numbers. You get something that's generic. So the gut tends to be something where it's just instinct. I feel like I'm writing out of my lizard brain.
- 2.30** I can remember I was struck there when Gregg was answering that question, by his finger, where he's wearing a splint at the moment, and it struck me, reading one or two of your books, when Evan was struggling with, for example, a concussion, because some bad guy's just beaten him over the head, and he nevertheless powers through it. I was sort of wondering if, in the next book, Evan Smoak's going to get a broken finger just at the crucial moment, just when he does, which is going to—you know, that's

going to be awkward for a superhero, because, you know, it could, you know, he's going sufficiently use the other hand—

2.31 Then I think he'll do it to someone else.

2.32 Right. OK.

2.33 This is an injury, I'm thinking, that needs to be inflicted on somebody else.

2.34 Right? Yeah, he does that, doesn't he? But that's one of those kind of unpredictable things. I mean, I tend to approach things in a slightly quantum way of life, generally, as a series of kind of random collisions of particles. It strikes me that when one is writing, you're trying to reorganize that. As you say, some script writers refer back to the hero's journey formula and so on. But a really great work of literature, like *Ulysses* or James Joyce, *Ulysses* is full of kind of random occurrences as you wander around Dublin. Is there an element of that to *Orphan X*, that in your writing, you're allowing the unpredictable and the aleatory to get into the orderly sequence? Because Evan wants the orderly, orderly narrative.

2.35 Yeah. You never want to fall in love with plan B. You never want to fall. For me—

2.36 Yeah.

2.37 I never fall in love with an outline. Some people can only write from an outline where they figured everything out in advance. I can't do that, but I can't also just fly blind. So I have a really unusual process. Not really unusual, but I'm, like, right in between. Cause there's a conversation always between people who outline and people who kind of fly by the seat of their pants.

2.38 "Pantsers and the plotters."

2.39 And I have a big monitor, and I have two documents on it, and one of them is what I call a rolling outline. And it's about, I usually start—I have between 15 and 25 pages of bullet points, roughly mass snippets of dialogue, notions. One of the things is, when you're out in the world as a writer, I'm always listening. What are little tells? What are little things that you see people do that illuminate some aspect of character or something that kind of breaks your heart, right?

2.40 Or little things you can pick up and notice—like, you know, I was on a bus and saw a kid who had worn shoes, and I could see where the magic marker had colored the mark, right. Didn't have enough money to—like, there's these things that kind of hit you, hit you in a human way, and you realize that it opens up a sentiment towards somebody, or particular ways that people are bully—if you're overhearing a dialogue, let's say, between a husband and a wife. In certain ways, people are being, like, bullied or manipulated or shut down, to think, "Oh, that's so wonderfully nasty," right?

2.41 So we're like collectors in a way. We're thieving all these different things. And then there's just other scenes. There's plot. There's all the stuff that comes from that gut

instinct of being like, "I want to write a story about this." And I think a story is, in a lot of ways, like, if you're making a snow angel, like, you're settling into the shape of it, right? You're moving. Or, like, if you put a blanket down on a beach, right. It's all uncomfortable and lumpy, and you have to kind of settle into your shape. So there's a process of that for me before I write, and I tend to have 25 pages, and they're just blocked. Here's a character, here's this, here's that, and I start a story. You know those indoor rock climbing walls?

2.42 Yeah.

2.43 I can start a story when I know that there's enough handholds that are chunky to get me across the wall, and the wall is the story. I don't know if I'm going to get there with my left hand or my right foot, but I know there's a big, chunky second-act scene that's going to be a big action scene, right? And as I'm writing towards it, I'll have ideas, like, I can drop handkerchiefs that I'm going to pay off, and even as I write past it, I can go back and change it. So I have this big, messy document, and usually I know my first 2 to 3 chapters, so they're shaped like clay out of this mass that I vaguely have massed up into different shapes.

2.44 And when I first start writing, what happens is, the outline—I call it a rolling outline—the outline swells, right? And so this is what I said earlier, that part of the job of being a writer is being open to interpretation, being open to opportunity. So it'll swell, because all of a sudden, a character will start talking differently. And so I'm not going to railroad it back to what the outline was, right? One character might sort of magically take off, and I might say, "Oh, here's a great opportunity to have this scene that just happened. And then if I put another lever in, in the second act, I can pay this off in the third act." All these ideas happen.

2.45 So it starts to swell and expand, and then it starts to sort of shape up as I go. And then at some point, I'm cutting out of it, because I'm appropriating the book, and it grows. And it's frustrating, because sometimes I'm like, "It's still expanding. I'm on page 200. It's still expanding." Then it starts to shrink. And when I'm done, I tend to have a document, roughly 100,000 words over here, and the outline's empty, and I trash it. So it's like appropriating it into this other document. But they both have to live and breathe for me. Yeah, it's a weird process.

2.46 So I don't know if there are any questions from the audience. But there's a question in my mind that's been summarized for me by a couple of writers. And I wonder if anyone has a view on this, because I've sort of tended to separate Gregg out as doing something kind of weird and wonderful. But there's a sense in which we're sort of doing this all the time. And I'm quoting here from Daniel Dennett, the philosopher, who says, "We're all virtuosos novelists, who find ourselves engaged in all sorts of behavior. And we always put the best faces on it we can. We try to make all of our material cohere into a single good story. And that story is our autobiography. The chief fictional character at the center of that autobiography is one's self."

- 2.47 So I sort of feel like that narrativism is built into our lives. But I also remember what Sartre wrote in that great philosophical novel of his, *Nausea*. That he has the main character, Roquentin, who's trying to write a biography of an 18th-century nobleman, suffer disillusionment with a whole notion of narrative because he's living so powerfully, and he feels that all narrative is weak by comparison with it. So he says, "You can narrate or live. You can't do both. You have to choose." He thinks that narrative is a kind of delusion because you're writing from the end backwards, whereas you're living life forward. So that he thinks of narrative as a kind of mistake, admittedly, in the context of a narrative, a novel that is, of course, going forwards in time.
- 2.48 But I sort of wonder if the sort of thing that Gregg is talking about, if we're trying to be our own heroes to some extent and probably failing. I mean, I wonder if narrative is, in that positive way we were talking about earlier, and referencing Jordan Peterson, is giving you kind of rules for how to live. But I also wonder, isn't it possibly providing a kind of frustration? I mean, because sometimes I'll read Evan Smoak, doing something great and knocking back the vodka and so on, and I think, "Wow, I wish I could do that," and I can't. And so the hero narrative seems like a sort of mistake or delusion or, you know, that I cannot—that is misleading in some way for one's own life.
- 2.49 I think one of the things—
- 2.50 I mean, probably identify with the Penguin more than Batman, I suppose, basically.
- 2.51 Well, two things. So first, as a kind of detour, but I'll get back to this, we're talking about that marriage between archetypal and the personal. And I never took a writing course or, like, read a bunch of books on. I've read like 5,000 novels, right? Like, you want to imbue the form so that you understand it in a way, so that when you're writing, you're not thinking, "Is it narration or is it life?" It's what happens. It's what comes out of you. It starts to form and shape up. And ideally you've read enough structured works or seen enough movies that it's a process where you're mediating between your prefrontal cortex and the urge to create in certain regards.
- 2.52 As for this, I'm increasingly interested in these intricacies. I'd say early in my career I wrote heroes and villains, and then I just stopped. And I write antagonists and protagonists. And that process for me, to great, it's moving towards, I think, greater three-dimensionality, not just of the characters but of the plots. And I used to think that if you get a bad guy who's supremely bad, it makes your good guy even more good. And part of it is, if you have a character who's an antagonist, who's immensely compelling, where the reader feels the draw and the seduction of their worldview, where we really feel like we could put ourselves in their feet, and it's a complicated path that the protagonist has to navigate in order to somehow emerge through the ambiguity to reestablish some lower baseline of order from the chaotic situation that is the least awful that could happen, it feels like we can relate to it more.

- 2.53** And one of the things I was thinking about a lot as you're talking about this—we put the best faces on it if we can— in some ways, I feel like my job as the novelist is to be as unrelentingly harsh as I can be about myself and put myself under as much self-scrutiny as I can, without, like, dis-cohering, right. Because it's very easy if you're looking at— well, let me give an example. You have an altercation with somebody or you're angry, even with a loved one, right? It's like, pay attention to what's happening. Pay attention to the parts of you that are, like, that are whispering in your ear. And a lot of times we have curtains on this reality because, just to function, we want to kind of limit ourselves with an acceptable range of behavior, right? That's the coherence of our personality. That's the assimilating ego between superego and id.
- 2.54** But a lot of times for me, when those things happen, I want to, like, pick the curtain up, right? And you look past the curtain, and then do you walk past the curtain, and then do you think about it? Then do you revel in it? And how much of that do you do? How much of that are you willing to indulge in, right, before you start to lose your center? Like, you can't wander too far from the curtain and get back to your relative ethical position in the world or with other people. But it's like it's a meandering process. And so a lot of times, if you have a disagreement with somebody, you want to lead with, in the world, with any altercation, like, what's the piece I could have handled better or should have handled better, even if it's 1%? And a lot of times you're reduced to making something the least awful it can be, not making it great.
- 2.55** And so a lot of it, for me, it's like an excavation process, in a lot of regards. I want to give a practical example because I want, you know, at intervals, I want to keep tacking back to craft for the listeners who are, who are engaging in writing. You know, when you get editorial notes, I'm talking more on the screen—well, screenplay side or the novel side, right? It's very easy to dismiss people when you're the creator. So I kind of have a rule which is, you want to have a closed circle. There's some people who have, like 100 writing groups, right? I have this writing group and this person and my aunt read it, and it's like, where are you? It's too many voices. I choose very few people to read and listen to. And then the rule is, for me, I have to listen to them. Right? I can't shortcut it. That's part of that containing what someone else is saying.
- 2.56** Part of that is an example. And this is often, or more often the case on the Hollywood side, I would say. You get notes that aren't right, and it's really easy to dismiss them. Right? Like, someone will be like, "Oh, this third act right here, it's getting really boring. Can you tighten it up?" And you look at it and you're like, "Dude, the third act's fine. Like, I don't know what you're talking about. It's completely tight. It's 25 pages. Everything lines up. If you want to pull this apart, it'll pull the rest of the screenplay apart. Do you want to go back and tell me, if you pull these threads, what the tapestry is going to look like?"
- 2.57** It's a very defensive posture that one can take when you're writing, but there's another way that it can be approached, which is often that, if you try to excavate beneath the—

and to identify what the editorial anxiety is that's being expressed, right— so a lot of times, if somebody writes that on the third act, if I dismiss it out of hand, I don't think about it. But if I go off and really think about it, quite often, even if, let's say, it's a studio executive who I'm not even, not particularly enamored of, and a great number of them are very, very sharp, so I don't mean to imply that it's like the suits versus the creative, but I mean, now and then you'll get a note where you don't know what the hell they're talking about.

2.58 But I could go off and go, "Wait a minute. It's not that the third act's tight. It's that you're reading, and you're an imperfect human. And that's the point that you realized that you were bored. But the real problem is in the middle of the second act. So 20 pages previously, it lagged. You're reading a bunch of scripts that are on your nightstand. You're getting through your day, and that's where you wrote and jotted down, 'This is really dragging. I'm starting to get aggravated.'" And if I look at everybody as having some sort of input, I mean, unless it's outright inane, I'm not implying you listen to it all the time, but you're in a negotiation with the studio, right? You want to get my last movie that got, I mean, we're talking about tens of millions of dollars to finance a movie, right? It's not— and so, if you can think about it and excavate below and identify the editorial anxiety and come back and solve the other problem, then the note sort of vanishes.

2.59 And there's a sort of rule in that that's inherent to life, in a certain way. Like often if somebody's frustrated, it's very easy, particularly if you're verbal, right, to disintegrate, to savage the logic, to hang up on words, to point out the pieces that are wrong, right? And I'm not claiming I'm particularly good at not doing that. But the solution, where the gold is, is to go back and really consider and think about, "OK, this person is imperfectly thrashing around and telling me things that don't make sense to me. What are the parts of me that they're speaking to? Right? What's that little dragon I need to slay to figure out? Or what's the part of me that's resistant to that and all of a sudden feels, like, murderously oppositional about something, and let's go explore that for a little while."

2.60 And so there's these excavations, and I think that one's willingness to do that, to integrate these— this is more like shadow work from the Jungian sense than the animal work. But to really be comfortable in embodying these things and also identifying the ways in which people might be expressing something that I need to hear but don't want to, that opens up really rich narrative veins a lot of times for characters. But you have to open that up within yourself. I can't write about something that I don't have access with myself. And sometimes the writing of it is what helps me access it. Joan Didion has a quotation, which I love. She said, "I write so I know what I think." And that happens to me a lot.

2.61 It's funny then, isn't it, when you're being asked to change what you think, but because this might come as a shock to some people, that you perhaps imagine the writer

operating in a kind of vacuum, the solo operator, and then just handing down, as it were, these tablets from on high. And that is not how it works. Because in the real world, there's a whole bunch of people, let alone readers, who will give you feedback, of course. And I'd be interested to hear what the most negative feedback is you've had. I couldn't help but think of those editors and you, who are just about to launch the campaign for *The Last Orphan*, the publicist, and others who are trying to kind of control you and impinge on what you are writing.

- 2.62** I was sort of thinking, well, what's the trickiest editorial comment? I mean, I can remember my own experience, someone writing against some particularly prolonged, no doubt pompous, wordy kind of passage. "Joke here, please." And that's the hardest thing. I can't remember what happened. I probably tore the whole thing up, but I was completely lost. I couldn't inject a joke from nowhere into them. But how do you cope with some of those kind of stray, as it may be, of course, on, you know, on Amazon or wherever it may be, you know, in some kind of public forum?
- 2.63** You gotta stay off them.
- 2.64** Right. OK, I didn't.
- 2.65** Look, as has been said, if you want to believe all your good reviews, you have to believe all your bad reviews. So, like, maybe you don't play that game. Right? A lot of it is protective about—you know, the most powerful thing we have is where we put our attention. And so you're talking about with the, like, I don't, I have really a great deal of creative freedom now at this point in my career as a novelist, and I always did. What's great about novels is, like, you're hair and makeup, you're the location scout, you're the director, you're the cinematographer, you're the props guy, you're the actors, you're the director, you're the whole thing. It's way more responsibility, but also, you're at the center of it. And so a lot of it becomes about trying to protect the time more selfishly from marketing—the way, not in a bad sense, but the way that an athlete has to be selfish, right? You have to protect that time.
- 2.66** In terms of reviews, the worst review I ever got—we were so excited. I had a full-page spread in *Entertainment Weekly* for one of my books with a full picture. They did a whole shoot, and it was like, scathing review that recommended that I go into therapy. That was probably the toughest one, because it was like, why not have that be a paragraph? Why do I need to be there, presented in grand fashion?
- 2.67** With notes, the only time that it really bothers me is when I sense that there's another agenda at play. I've been increasingly careful, you know, as I progress in my career, I have more, I've increasingly had the opportunity, but also appreciated and enforced, who I start to do business with. Because that ultimately, especially on the Hollywood side, that's all you control. Because you sign your rights away. They're not going to have me say, "In the 11th hour, this adaptation doesn't work for me. Kill the whole production." And so it's very important who you engage with. But early on, I had some

frustrating times where I felt like it wasn't a good faith exchange, that a new executive came in, and their motive really is to kill the project because they didn't buy it. So if it gets made, they're not the hero, and they're giving these dumb notes, like, "Just make it more like *Crimson Tide*."

2.68 And it's like, no bearing on *Crimson Tide*, right, where you're, you're being run in circles, rather than somebody saying, "We're switching this." I mean, I so much prefer aggressive aggressivity than passive aggressivity and blunt truths. And so the kind of veiled agendas and manipulations are the things for me that bother me. Anything that's a good faith effort to convey a note, increasingly I really will try to engage with. But I'm also given a lot of latitude on the book front, certainly.

2.69 But in movies, I mean, I'll give a quick example. My first movie, it took me 18 years to get it made. I think I was 21 years old when I wrote the first draft. And I kept rewriting it. I grew up. I had kids. It's about family. Rewrote it. Rewrote all these years. And we cast the lead, or one of the leads is Naomi Watts, spectacularly talented actress. And I was on set, and there was this speech that I'd literally rewritten for the better part of two decades. And she gives this amazing speech, and I was in video village, right? So you're watching this speech, and at the end of it, she stops. It's an exchange with somebody else.

2.70 And this constellation of emotions moved across her face. It was like a universe of meaning. And I thought in that moment that she conveyed everything the scene was supposed to say. It was like a perfect 3-act play, all in her expression, fully embodied. And I realized in that moment that this speech that I'd written and written and written was likely going to wind up on the cutting room floor. Because it's a visual medium, right? And she just did it all with her face, with her skill, with her person. And the next thought I had was, I was so grateful that that happened.

2.71 I didn't take the sort of more possessive, maybe, that call that the novelist possessiveness, because I thought a screenplay is so different from a novel, because a screenplay is a recipe for a product, right? It's a recipe for a piece of entertainment, and it's also an invitation to collaborate. And so what your hope is, there's two versions of it. One is that you're with talented people and it's a positive feedback loop, right? Movies and productions, they're like marriages. They're either getting better or they're getting worse. They're not static. And so, either it's going well or it's going bad. And when it goes bad, it's terrible, because then you get territorial over the script and then you feel like you're the drunk guy behind a bar at 4 in the morning with a broken bottle, like, fighting to protect all your stuff.

2.72 And so the screenplays, in a lot of ways, on that front in particular, is a process of letting go. The director's going to come and have a vision. The director is king on a feature film. Now, I've had directors who have involved me immensely, but that's at the behest of the king. They're the director there, right? It's different. TV, the showrunner is sort of king. And the novelist. You're the novelist, you're the, you're the creator. But

there's all these passes that you take on a screenplay. So a selling screenplay, when you write a spec script, it's got to be very, very readable and dynamic, and you don't want to over-direct. That's a very amateur mistake. Like, "Pan here and do this," and director comes along and pats you on the head and says, "Oh, well, thanks, spanky. But, like, I've been doing this a while."

2.73 And so, but there's all these tricks when you're writing a screenplay, where you direct without directing. You have to figure out how to use space and imply and make it clear from the language without overstepping your bounds. So there's this whole art to writing the screenplay that's the sellable screenplay. It's all about the read. It should be, like, just rocketing, the read. And then there's a pass when you cast, right, then you're really thinking, who are we going to? Are they older? Are they younger? Are they a different ethnicity? How are we going to skew it? If you go out to somebody who's a piece of talent, they're going to have opinions. When a director's attached, they're thinking everything visually.

2.74 Any scene that does, that isn't absolutely essential to drive the plot isn't going to be there. It's not like a novel. You can't have a small character beat, though I try to integrate this into the novels, the different forms, because you have to shoot it. You stand it up. You cast it. It costs, you know—a day of shooting on a TV show, let's say, is \$250,000 a day. You can't shoot extra scenes that don't drive the plot. So then you're in a production draft, and then you do a pass for secondary characters, and by the end, with the production shot, it doesn't matter how pretty it reads. You're changing location. All of a sudden you're in a house and not an apartment, and you're in a stairwell, and you're converting the scenes. And so there's all these ways that you have to be willing to kind of move and roll. And if you're too precious about it, you're not reflecting the fact that it's inherently a collaborative medium.

2.75 But at the same time, you want to hold a firmness of boundary, that the DNA of the story has to go forth. And if people understand that, people understand the DNA of it, and they take it in, like Naomi Watts did with this scene, then more power to you, because I've handed the baton. My friend Billy Ray, who's a wonderful screenwriter, with Captain Phillips and Hunger Games, and he has a great line when he said, "Once it goes to a director or into production, you hand the baton off." He's like, "You can run the lap with him around the track if you want, but you've handed the baton off, so you don't really need to." Right?

2.76 So the director really wants to get rid of you, basically.

2.77 Sometimes. But, I mean, I had a wonderful director who wanted me on set because it was—the story was quite unique and broke a bunch of genres in defiance of the advice that I was offering earlier. It was a real genre-busting first film. And he said, "The voice is so weird, like, I want you around so that if we have pieces of dialogue, that it all fits together." But my last film was a big Netflix action film. Yes, Sweet Girl. And when that went, you know, we had a big star cast, and there was a set window, and when it went

to production, it just went to production, and then I saw the final cut. So you're in or out, as it depends.

- 2.78** That's a fascinating insight into how it really works. I mean, I'm slightly reminded of how I approach students who want to do a PhD. Most of the time, I'm trying to stop them and put them off, but every now and then, they get over the hurdles I put up in front of them, and they will continue. But I suspect many people thinking of becoming writers will become chemists or archaeologists, perhaps, in the light of your remarks.
- 2.79** But, well, I always, you know, I live in Los Angeles, right? I generally go on a book tour every year. I meet so many people who want to be writers. I meet much fewer, many fewer people who want to write.
- 2.80** Yeah.
- 2.81** So there's a distinction, right? I'm not on a chaise lounge with a smoking jacket. Like, people think it's every day, you're just there and you're pounding, and it's an immensely private and weird enterprise. And it's also very surreal because then, all of a sudden, if it's a movie, you're on a red carpet. If it's a book, sometimes, if you're fortunate, you're on a book tour. And it's the exact opposite. It's like getting ripped out of a cave, right? And all of a sudden it's like, be charming. You know, it's, like, what?
- 2.82** So when I walk up to you at your next show and I say, "Oh, Mr. Hurwitz, I've written this little script here. I wonder if you could take a look at it and give me your view?" Your response is?
- 2.83** If it's you?
- 2.84** Well, let me be just anyone.
- 2.85** What people forget when things are sent—and yes, there is a point of inundation, and it also gets tricky, unfortunately. We live in such annoyingly litigious times that, like, often I won't read a book to blurb it or to access it unless it is either, unless it's up for publication, in a way, because you can read unsolicited stuff, and then even if you're sent it, and then you publish something, and then it comes up, and then they claim that you took something— there's a lot of legal problems that are aggravating.
- 2.86** But I do mentor a lot of people. I do try and help a lot of people. And the thing is that people forget, at least for me, is every time I'm reading something that's new, I'm hoping that it's brilliant. I'm hoping that it's amazing. It's so easy to get hardened, to be like, ugh. There was a very famous essay that circulated some years ago. "No, I will not read your fucking script," is the name of it. It went through every trope of it. And so it's very easy to get cynical. But it's like, I'm hoping that people are great. And when you have that—I mean, I've read some first novels that are, like, you just can't even believe it. And you're there at the beginning of a career, and you can't even believe that somebody's written that as a first outing. And it's wonderful. It's this discovery process.

- 2.87** And everybody needs help in everything, but certainly in writing. And I had so much help, right? I had people who, no matter how much talent you have—so I always think about, there's talent, right? And then there's hard work. And in a field that's, fields that are so refined in this, or so rare in the success rate, that they verge on the impossible, right, if you want to be an actor or something—I feel like hard work is like, if you're a bird and you have to be flapping all the time, stuck in a house along the ceiling for that one moment that the hatch opens and you can go through, right? The heart of the endeavor. Your hard work is the flapping. So you can have, I mean, there's people who've gone to their grave with brilliant manuscripts in their closet. Like, you never know when something's gonna break or happen. And it's great if you're that, if you're there at that moment, or you're there to offer that encouragement.
- 2.88** Because you had, way back, I remember you telling me that you had someone who took you under their wing to some extent while you were still at Oxford. Was it a New York guy?
- 2.89** Yeah, it was a lawyer who represented M. Night Shyamalan. He had him from a movie, one before *The Sixth Sense*, and he read that immensely crappy rough draft and saw a lot in it. He represents a lot of younger writers and talent as a lawyer. He almost acted more like a manager and sort of flew me to New York and kind of wanted to engage on the book. I dedicated my first book to him.
- 2.90** So kind of, there's that moment where—
- 2.91** Well, and it's so important to be taken seriously, right? Because I'm not from a writer's background. I'm not from a creative background. I mean, I meet people in L.A. who are from kind of Hollywood royalty families. Their friends are actors and directors and everything. Like, I was a kid from northern California, went off to school, and just loved books. I mean, I was so dumb, I thought if I wrote a book and it was really good, I could sell it, like it was just something that could happen, you know. Like, thank god, the blindness of youth.
- 2.92** But the thing that my first attorney, his name is Mark Gleck, he passed away some years ago. But for me, what was so important is he gave me permission, in a way, to take myself seriously about it. Because when you're first doing something that's an aberration from the course of what your family's done, what your schooling does, what everything else does, it's very important if you have an artistic sensibility and you're taking your work seriously, and that means discipline and that means routine. It means a lot of things we're going to talk about, I think, in our next lecture, and we can talk about how you construct that and how you build ritual and how you build cues and habit.
- 2.93** You have to take yourself seriously because no one else is going to, until somebody does. But when somebody else does, it kind of, it makes it real in a different way, and you have to make that time sacrosanct, right? Because there's always something that's

more pressing than writing day 137 out of 365 on a novel, right? Whether that's dry-cleaning or working out or the house is a mess or I need a new shirt or there's a movie on. It's never going to be the most pressing thing, unless you just decide to elevate it almost into the realm of the sacred.

2.94 And you have to do it without being precious about it, because then that's annoying, because then you're an "artiste" and you make excuses for yourself, right? And then you're special, and then you elevate yourself out of a realm where you're engaging with people in a way that's real and genuine and you're learning from them and you're engaged with them in a certain way. So it sort of is a complicated thing versus other fields have constraints and infrastructure on them. If you're a doctor, right? If you're an accountant, if you're a lawyer, if you're a gardener, if you're a janitor, there's structure around your jobs. There's structure on your work and the way that you conduct it. And to be a writer, so much of that you have to just will. You have to will it, and you have to take yourself seriously enough to do it. And you start in small bites, and then you can work up.

2.95 You know, the writer Lee Child told me that when he gets on a plane, he gets asked two questions. The first one is, "What do you do?" And then he says, "I'm a writer." And then the second question is, "Have any of your books been made into movies?" So his answer to the first question is now, "Oh, I trade in drugs," some dark arts of some kind. He refuses to answer the first question, in other words. So I can't help, without wanting to ask that second question specifically. I mean, I'm struck that, on the one hand, you've written novels and you've written screenplays as well. What about when someone wants to—completely different writer—comes along and looks at, if I remember correctly, your novels are up for grabs, aren't it, is it by Paramount, possibly? But anyway, go ahead.

2.96 Well, I wrote 8 sort of Hitchcockian stand-alone novels that I call my Marked Man series, and I'm in the process of producing them with a wonderful producer who I admire very much as a writer and brilliant. He's probably my favorite person who's worked in adaptation. His name's Scott Frank. He did Queen's Gambit. He did Get Shorty. He did A Walk Among the Tombstones. He did Minority Report. I mean, so Philip K. Dick and Larry Block. And, you know, I mean, it's—

2.97 Sorry, what was his name again?

2.98 Scott Frank.

2.99 Scott Frank. OK.

2.100 And so we're actually producing, but what we want to do is find younger writers who were earlier in their journey that we can kind of oversee—oversee sounds too controlling—who we can sort of shepherd and foster. It's so hard to break in, in screenwriting right now. And one of the things that happens is a lot of the screenwriting courses, you graduate, you're in a huge amount of debt, right? It's not

like you're guaranteed a job if you get your screenwriting degree from X University. And then a lot of times with the studios, they're just throwing stuff against the wall. It fits. Maybe you get—like many fields, executives often will function on the principle of not getting fired, rather than taking risks. So better to spend \$3 million on somebody who's an established screenwriter than 200,000 and get a baby writer to do it. If they burn the time and it doesn't work, you're better to pay 3 million even if they burn it, because at least it's a name.

- 2.101** So we're trying to figure out ways that we can structure. So I have this kind of source material, and he's quite a masterful screenwriter and director to get other people up through the ranks. So we're kind of lending them and letting people take them. But you have to let go. You have to let someone make it their own. I can't have a screenwriter who is subservient to the novel.
- 2.102** So you're actually inviting young, up-and-coming aspiring screenwriters to read your book and go, "OK, this is my take on it."
- 2.103** I want to make sure that they comprehend the DNA of the story. Somebody once said, "When you're adapting a book, read it twice, and then throw it in a drawer and write the screenplay." You have to connect with the DNA of a story. If I have a conversation and they understand what it is and it means something to them and they've prepared it and there's a pitch and there's a board and there's a, like, visual board—we had amazing, we have a wonderful writer working on this first project. Then it, then it has to be theirs. They can't be subservient to me.
- 2.104** And the worst screenplays are slavish adaptations of the books, right. The best adapted books are screenplays that vary wildly. *Clockwork Orange*, *Jaws*, the *Godfather*, right? *Apocalypse Now*. Read *Heart of Darkness* and read *Apocalypse Now*. About Schmidt. If you read *About Schmidt* and saw the movie, you wouldn't even know that it's based on the book, right? And so it's a kernel, in some ways, the adaptation, somebody has to own it. There has to be ownership of that screenwriting process. And I can give input and I can say, plug into my brain. Like, I'm your database. I'm here to talk about tone. I'm here to mind the guardrails: "This scene's really important. Can we talk about it? It's really key. That's one of those big, chunky handholds. I'm not sure if you get rid of that, that it's going to hold together."
- 2.105** But ultimately I can't—there's a lot that's about relinquishing control when you adapt, the same way as when you hand your screenplay, which I've adapted other people's work. I've adapted my own work. I've adapted a Stephen King novel once. When you hand that off to a director, it's similar in some ways. You can't tell a director, "Shoot what's on the page," even if you had the power to do so.
- 2.106** I wonder what Stephen King—does Stephen—because, you know, thinking of *Apocalypse Now*, I sort of like to imagine what Joseph Conrad might, having written *Heart of Darkness*, sees *Apocalypse Now*, has a word with Francis Coppola. "You know,

did you read my book or what, man? Because you've changed it so radically, I can't even recognize it now." But as you say, Conrad would have to let it go in some way. But did Stephen King let it go? Or did he say, "Hey, Gregg, come on."

2.107 Well, yeah, we had some, like, yes, he was gracious and wonderful.

2.108 He was. Oh, good.

2.109 I think he has certainly earned control over the creative process at a studio and network level that he's going to get because he's Stephen King, which he rightly deserves. And so that was the level. But creatively, he was— that part, it was, you know, play. Go have fun. I mean, we had to clear hurdles with him, as we should, because you should have to. But I think about, you know, you're mentioning if Conrad saw Coppola's—it's the last thing you want to see. Like, I think about, you know, I had a master's, I got a master's in Shakespearean tragedy because I needed a very practical degree to fall back on if my writing career didn't work out.

2.110 So practical. Shakespeare and tragedy. Yeah, that has many uses.

2.111 But, like, the last thing I want to see generally is, like, a straight production of Shakespeare again. Right? Like, it's wonderful when people play with it. Right? I saw *Timon of Athens* that was set in the Roaring Twenties. I saw, like, Baz Luhrmann's *Romeo and Juliet* with Claire Danes and Leonardo DiCaprio. Was just sort of like a wild, surreal adventure. Like, in some ways, you almost want to see something that's new from an older text, or something that's interpreted or pushed visual in a way that's alarming and surprising. It's not unlike the thing I was talking about earlier, that in movies, when that moment happens that is shocking and makes perfect sense? A visual interpretation that does that's amazing. *Clockwork Orange* is that way. I mean, that movie's a masterpiece, and the book's a masterpiece.

2.112 Oh, yeah, the Burgess novel. Yeah, it's great.

2.113 Speaking of Joyce, he's a Joycean scholar. That's why there's so much invented wordplay.

2.114 And the Kubrick movie. Yeah, it's quite faithful to the novel, if I recall.

2.115 Yes. But it's also wildly inventive, visually. There's so many ways you could shoot it, but if you're Kubrick, you shoot it like Kubrick, and all of a sudden, it blows a hole through your spinal cord when you see that movie.

2.116 There are those brilliant collaborations, of course, between writers and directors. I can't help but think of Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey*, where he was working with the writer. They were evolving. It started with just— *The Sentinel*, I think, was the short story that that was based on. And then it evolved into novel and the movie simultaneously. I mean, are you working with—you know, there you are in Hollywood, and are you working alongside? I mean, do you think of movies as kind of like they're almost competition for you or, you know, it's all part of the same game, essentially?

- 2.117** I think each form requires a different muscle, and it helps very much to be an overall writing shape. But they're different events in the decathlon. Right? So comics function quite differently than screenplays function quite differently, features than a TV pilot. Right? A TV pilot's very different than a feature. But novels, for me, have always been the spine of my career. But what you want to do when you go to any form is you want to maximize the things that only that form can do. So thus the story I was talking about, an actress who can convey something with her face, it's a visual format.
- 2.118** It's also why people tend to eschew or have a reaction to too much voiceover in movies, right? Because you don't want to be read to in a movie. The movie should show it. And comics are amazing because comics can do something that no other form can do that, except opera in a way, because in a comic, you can have a panel where there's an illustration and the character is talking, and there's a caption of what they're really thinking versus what they're saying. So the subtext exists concurrently in the image.
- 2.119** And the only other form that really does that simultaneously, the best illustration is Wagnerian opera, right, where Siegmund and Siegfried see each other come in from the cold, but the orchestra's playing the love motif, so you're keying the orchestra is almost like the id, right. And then the book is, the dialogue is occurring at a surface level, and both of them are coming the same way. So there's tricks you can play with that.
- 2.120** So when I was writing a comic, to give one example, I wrote one comic, and there's a character who's coming in from New York who's an assassin. I'm very big on assassins, evidently. And I'm doing this buildup of how he's this, like, amazing badass assassin, and I'm tracking him, panel to panel, with the captions describing him as he's flying in the plane, like, you know, "I hate travel. I'm gonna do this. I'm gonna do this." And what you don't really notice is there's this really scrawny little guy who's at the periphery of the scene and kind of hidden in the back, who the big guy is kind of terrorizing through the flight, puts his seat back and hits him.
- 2.121** And so you're moving, moving, moving, and then it turns out the character, the assassin's name, I named him Sickle Moon. And so the little guy has a little hat, and they get to the baggage claim, and he shivs the bigger guy who's been annoying him, who we think has been talking the whole time, and he walks out and gets in a cab, and he takes his hat off and he's got a sickle moon on his birthmark on his forehead, and you realize that you've been following the wrong character's voiceover all the time. I've been purposefully misleading. Well, that's a trope. You can't do that in a movie, right? The voiceover, you're going to hear and connect the voice. You can't really do it in a novel. So it's something that's a unique aspect of the form.
- 2.122** And what you want to do is to always maximize and play with something that can only be done within that form. Like, that's always one of the goals, right? And so there's ways within novels. Like, there's—humor works very differently in novels than spoken. I

mean, if you record a conversation that you're, let's say, you're out with your friends, having a drink at the bar, and everyone's catching up. It's one of those amazing nights, and you're thinking, "God, if we could record this, this would be the best screenplay ever." It's like, actually record it, right. And then transcribe that, and then read it. And it's not funny. It just doesn't read. So humor on the page reads differently. The cadence on a page reads differently.

- 2.123** And even, in fact, for screenplays, and this is something that I'm, because I'm meticulous, I even like to reserve big plot turning moments sometimes for when you turn a page on a screenplay, right? So even the way it's broken down, not to get too E. E. Cummings about it, but even the way in the positioning, right? And when I was talking about trying to direct without directing, right? So instead of saying, "Evan drops down through a skylight, pan over, turn around, and there you see Van Sciver." That's his antagonist from the first books, like, "pan to him, close on him from Evan." And so you have all these stage directions or all these direction that you're writing into the screenplay because you went and bought a screenwriting guide at Barnes and Noble, and you're using all the words from it.
- 2.124** Well, instead you say, "Evan drops in, falls to the floor, turns around, paragraph, scene heading, Van Sciver, return again, standing right behind him." Well, I've used none of the camera work, but in the way I'm laying it on the page and in replacing, for instance, a character's name with a scene heading instead of, like, "interior hall, turn around, pan to or cut to Van Sciver," you can describe it in the cadence. And books work that way too, even if you're not being overly cute about it. I mean, I don't mean to imply that you're spreading everything out, but where are your paragraph breaks? What's the cadence? How does humor work? How are you fussing with dialogue? What words are you leaving out? What are you letting the audience fill?
- 2.125** One other point that I want to raise, while we're kind of free-range about screenplays. I assume everyone has seen *The Sixth Sense*. Is that right? That's a fair assumption of viewers? Well, I won't give away the twist, in case one viewer hasn't seen it. But my favorite scene in that—there's this wonderful scene. We're talking about what you leave, what you put in and what you leave out. And what you leave out often is as important as what is on the page. Right? And so there's this wonderful scene where Cole is the little boy, is in the car with his mom, who's played by Toni Collette, you know. And the one thing we know from her, he's a little kid. He's seeing dead people. It's a mess. It's stressful. She's a single mom, and she loved her mother. She lost her mother. She's so close with her mom, right? It's a big emotional through-line for that character.
- 2.126** And she's in the car with him, and there's traffic. I don't know if you remember the scene. And they don't know why there's traffic. And all of a sudden, the dead guy appears and he's a biker who got his head caved in. He's right outside the window. It's kind of this jump scare. And Cole reacts to it, and she says she just can't do it. She kind

of starts breaking down. And she says to him, "I can't," like, it's been too much. The strain of him being delusional or schizophrenic.

- 2.127** And he says to her, "I see Grandma sometimes." And she just starts crying. It's like it's the last straw. Of all the things, this is her one sacred place. And she says, "Don't. Like, just don't." And he says, "She says you go to her grave once a week. And she says that you ask a question and she wants you to know that the answer is, 'Always.'" He says, "What do you ask her?" And she just starts sobbing. And she says, "I ask her if she's proud of me." This is a wonderful scene.
- 2.128** So now let's reverse that. Same exact scene. They're in the car. She's exasperated. Dead guy in the window. "I see Grandma sometimes. She says you go to her grave once a week. She says that you ask her if she's proud of you, and she wants you to know the answer is 'always.'" Zero emotional impact. It's a totally cliched scene and moment. So by reversing answer to question in that moment, what Night did so masterfully in that is, in fact, it pushes the construction of that internal to the viewer, because we're the ones who do the math, right?
- 2.129** It's that process I was talking about in novels where I ended the scene, the torture scene that I never wrote, that everyone was so terrified of? Because your version of that and your version of that and your version of that is your worst torture scene. I can't write that. I'm not gonna go in and spell it all out. Because you're like, "Oh, that's just gross. That doesn't freak me out." I want you to freak yourself out. And in that, in having us have to do the emotional math, literally, of flipping answer to question, it pushes it internal to the viewer. And there's this moment where we feel it. You feel it in your spinal cord when it happens.
- 2.130** And so it's an example of where you give room in a different way, and there's different ways that those tropes exist. There's a function of that in horror. Let's think of some generic, like, campfire tales, right? There's the little old lady who's doing the puzzle in her house, and as she's putting it together, she—"Wait, that's my couch, and that's my TV. And wait, there I am on the couch, and this is my house, and there I am, and there's the window behind me." And she puts the last piece in, and it's a figure at the window, and then she feels the cold, hard steel at the back of her neck, right? And that's a campfire story, right?
- 2.131** Or the couple who's making out in the woods, and they hear that, on the radio, that someone has escaped an insane—there's like a scratching on the door outside, right? They go tearing off, and they hear that someone with a hook, guy with a hook hand, has escaped the insane asylum. And they pull over the road, and there's a hooked hand dangling from the thing. So what is that? It's terror and a lack of safety recalled from a different position than later of relative safety. And when we invert that, it has a horrifying effect. Right? If you switch the order to it, "Oh, someone's escaped from the insane asylum, he has a hook hand, and there's a scratching at the door," it doesn't do

anything. We're doing the math. And there's a horrifying effect to that, just like there's an emotional effect.

2.132 And so, and that's sort of the basis of horror in certain ways, is you, like, recall things or you're piecing information. We talked about undeceiving, or we talked about the hunt, right? The pieces of information in the order that they come in are as important as the information itself, and they have different effects for horror or for emotion. And so one thing, for instance, I think about a lot is, let's say that you're writing a scene, and the point of the scene is for a father to say to his son, "I love you." And you write that scene. You write that line. What you want to do is to construct the whole scene, and then you pull that line right out, and the whole scene just holds place without it, so it's never said. It's never stated. You don't want to state the overt. You want to keep it veiled. You want to keep it at distance, because then that's where we're engaged with it. That's where the construction that we're making of it becomes personal to us.

2.133 That is so important. We're going to come back to that very issue under the heading of momentum— how do you sustain a narrative and how do you hook people? And I do want to be a bit of a devil's advocate here and not pull the rug out at all from under you, but at least to contemplate the rug for a moment. But before I do that, I don't know if anyone else wants to pitch questions to Gregg that are not the devil's advocate. Questions, actually, that are more on the side of the story.

2.134 Hi. I just remember you mentioning earlier about how rereading a novel, you saw how you were speaking to yourself almost about your uncertainty about having a child. I was just wondering about, out of all the novels you've written and presumably reread, how many have offered you this kind of revelatory experience?

2.135 In the wake of them?

2.136 Yeah, yeah.

2.137 Just a quick amendment. It wasn't as much about my uncertainty of having a child, but the terror at the expanded vulnerability when you have a child, because it's almost like you feel like your surface area has expanded, of ways in which you can be wounded or hurt. Almost all of them. Almost every book, because they don't make sense. It doesn't make sense when you write a story, right? That's our 6-paragraph blog post, right? Six-paragraph blog posts can make sense. You can know what it is. You don't know what a story is when you're writing it. And novels, in fact, to some extent, are even more so, because with the screenplay, you can orient yourself inside a screenplay all the time. It's 110 pages as opposed to 400 pages of final product. It's 110 pages with lots of white on the page.

2.138 So I can be in the middle of the second act and reach forward to the lip where the first act ends. And I know where the end is. And you're oriented. With a novel, you go down and in, and you push through and you pop out the other end and look back and hope it doesn't suck. Like, there's so much movement through the wilderness with it that quite

often I'm kicking over stones, that later on there's so many things that are revelatory, to use your phrase, that I didn't even, that I didn't know. And some of them are so obvious, it's embarrassing, I think. Did you have a question in the front?

- 2.139** You mentioned the scene where the potential torture scene, where the finale was the "start with the joints," and you mentioned some potential backlash that you got from this person that, from a scene that never happened. And it just brought back to me one of the greatest movies I've ever seen, which is Inception. And at the very end, where the tumbler is just spinning and spinning and spinning, would you consider that those things left unsaid might just ruin us for so many years, which is part of—or would you say it's a way to respect the creativity of the other side, of the audience?
- 2.140** When we don't say something overtly? Boy, that's a good question. When you talk about respecting the audience—
- 2.141** The fact that we're individuals, creative individuals.
- 2.142** That's right. So one of the things that's changed a lot in my lifetime— I'm going to sound like an old guy now—is people. We're all so pop culturally aware now. It's night and day from when I was growing up. And so one of the things I realized, like, my first book's a serial killer novel, right? And one of the things I realize is, I can't write a serial killer novel without everyone in the book being familiar with—I don't know anybody who hasn't seen Silence of the Lambs. So how do I write a fictional book in a world that nobody's familiar with serial killers, right?
- 2.143** So there's a level of awareness that we have to imbue the characters with in some ways, and some of that teasing at the edges, or playing with the genre within itself that you were asking—not postmodern, because that's too cute and clever and look at me—but the ways that I play around archetypes, we're dealing with audiences that are immensely sophisticated due to streaming and social media and fan groups and communities and magazines. There's a whole other level of access to storytelling, stars, writers. Everyone's got a platform. Everybody has opinions about it.
- 2.144** So I can't all of a sudden port myself back, writing contemporary fiction or writing a contemporary movie, and pretend that it exists in a world where nobody has seen a bunch of movies that exist like that. It won't be satisfying, right, to the audience. But by the same time, I'm not placating them and getting so cute, to be like, "Oh, here's my allusion to James Bond, and here's my allusion to that." You see that a lot where you, where people think that they're clever—think that they're clever, that's so nasty—but where they're, like, integrating pop cultural references that no one's going to remember in 5 years or 10 years. Like, you're claiming that you're of it.
- 2.145** What you want instead is to invite the reader as a—along on the journey, right? You want to lead. You want to lead the reader enough from the world that we live in, with their whole base of references and reference points, into a story that takes place today, even if I'm writing about a previous time, because we've all seen a bunch of movies

now, we've all read a bunch of books. "Once a month, a new movie comes to the drive-in in our town." We don't have that world anymore.

- 2.146** And so it's very interesting to be respectful of the audience, but not pander to them, right? And not join with them. You don't want to be an audience member. You don't want to say, "Oh, I'm a big fanboy, too. Let's fanboy together." You don't want that. There's a distance from it. But I have to be respectful of the incredible level of pop culture intelligence that viewers and readers have today.
- 2.147** I wonder if we can talk about the power of story, and I want to ask you a question now. Anyone who has seen a Fast and Furious movie. OK, there may be a few here who have not, OK, but whatever number. You go to see a Fast and Furious movie. You walk out of the movie theater. You get into your car. What do you do? What do you not do? Because I assume you try not to land on top of the truck in front of you or go under it, possibly, or take off into outer space or something to hook on. I don't know what. So, in other words, I think the first thing you have to do when you get into your own car is try to dispel the, dare I say, absurd images that that movie has planted in your mind, because otherwise you're going to get arrested, or die, or some combination of that.
- 2.148** So you have to, as it were, transcend the narrative that's just been spun in front of you. And, you know, it's in that context that I think of that as a specific example. But I wonder if there's a general problem there of the power of narrative over our minds and our susceptibility to powerful narrative. And it's a point that—Will Storr, amongst others—is a great book I'm reading right now by Peter Brooks called *Seduced by Story*, and perhaps we can come back to that. Peter's sort of skeptical of everyone telling their story now. Everyone has a story, but this is a point that Will Storr makes in his book, *The Science of Storytelling*.
- 2.149** "The hero-maker delusion is implicated in more misery, fury, and death than is possible to calculate. Mao, Stalin, and Pol Pot believed they were right, as did Hitler." Every one of them had a good story, so to speak, that they were trying to spin. And I don't know if Gregg wants to draw, you know, differentiate between story and propaganda, you know, if there is a difference, or is that something that you're grappling with? I mean, it also got conspiracy theories.
- 2.150** Well, propaganda. Propaganda is a story where you've already decided everything that you think and you're just fulfilling it, right? So I think of Ayn Rand as—her books feel propaganda-like to me, in that nobody suddenly takes a detour from—like, once you sort of know what it is that she's doing and proposing, she kind of just lays out, right, this, like a vision, which she's decided ahead of time, that's based on a somewhat abstract version of, right, her worldview.
- 2.151** This is the didactic novel, effectively, kind of, which is giving you a lecture. Yeah.
- 2.152** I mean, propaganda. Like, I, again, I go back to Joan Didion. "I write to know what I think," right? I'm figuring out as I'm writing a lot. I don't know which way it's going to

turn. And you know, I write within genre, I write thrillers, and so there's certain constraints where—you know, it's very interesting, like, writing Batman. I wrote Moon Knight. I wrote a Spider-Man swung into Moon. There's rules you have to adhere to when you're writing other characters that way. So it's kind of, they exist. It's a different tightrope walk. Like, I can't have Spider-Man kill a busload of nuns, right? Like, there's certain things you can't do, and you just know you can't do them. My editor on Batman famously remarked—

2.153 You're obviously tempted to do that.

2.154 My editor for Batman once famously remarked, like, "Batman should never be sitting down." If you think about it, you're like, "Wait, Batman doesn't really sit down," right? Like, there's weird stuff. I dropped Wolverine into a tank of, like, molten steel, like, at the end of Terminator, and there was a whole debate from the think tank in New York about, like, how long would it take for him to reconstruct himself from his adamantium skeleton, right? You have to have rules. You have to have rules, especially in science fiction.

2.155 But there's also parameters. So it's like this trust that you're keeping, but it's also not propaganda, right? Propaganda is something else. Propaganda is utilitarian. It's designed to have a particular effect, to make people think and feel a certain way, and that's quite different. But it's a bit reductive about the hero maker delusion, because, yeah, Mao and Stalin and Pol Pot did believe they were right. Like, so did Mandela and John Lewis and Gandhi and Winston Churchill. Right? Everybody does. There are very few people who say, "I believe I'm firmly wrong and am going to continue in this."

2.156 I mean, that's one of the, right, the bad guy never thinks he's the bad guy. That's the premise to writing a bad guy well. It's a premise to writing the Penguin differently from the absurdity that is the Penguin. There's some rich ethical ground around what I'll call the Andy Martin Fast and Furious proposition that I think we'll cover, because I think we're getting to ethics.

2.157 Yeah.

2.158 But we should talk about the responsibility—responsibility in story-telling, about violent acts that are committed. Does the artist bear responsibility? I have a lot of thoughts around that that we can get to.

2.159 OK. I guess we've pretty much run out of time. And although we have run out of time, there's just one quick thing I wanted to throw at Gregg, just because he hit me with this the other day actually, and it's dealing with sympathy for the bad guy. Gregg has a specific reading of that great Nabokov novel, *Lolita*, and I don't know if he wanted to finish just by hitting, because it struck me, and because I asked him the question, "How is it that Nabokov managed to make Humbert Humbert, even though he is technically a hebephile, I guess? So sympathetic. And you had a—

- 2.160** Well, I mean, you know, I think one of the overlays of Lolita, or one of the versions of the story is, if you think of Humbert Humbert as England and you think of Lolita as America, right? Like the older, crusty, reserved person, lasciviously—
- 2.161** That's me.
- 2.162** Yes, that's you. That's Andy. Just call him Andy instead of Humbert Humbert. And, you know, and then Lolita is this sort of like wild, sexualized younger woman who's, like, completely captivating of him, right. And then proves to be, right, to not have substantial worth in a certain way. Like, he's got a greater sort of intellectual depth and breadth of knowledge, but he's enamored with her. And so it's this very interesting dialogue, I think, between England and America.
- 2.163** So. Brilliant. Thanks. Thank you, people.

Lecture 3: Mimesis in Fiction

At a glance — Mimesis in fiction.

- 3.1** Well, in our last seminar, we were talking about myth. Today, we're talking about mimesis. My presupposition is that the novel is a myth wrapped inside a mimesis. Well, let's see how that theory plays out. And the great word mimesis, which I think is indispensable when we talk about the novel, essentially derives from Plato. I think Plato was the first one to, and the Republic—I've given you a reference to it there— so it's the imitation of reality, says Plato. Now, he wasn't very keen on either mimesis or reality. He already thought reality was pretty unsatisfactory. And mimesis, the imitation reality, was therefore doubly unsatisfactory. And in the Republic, he recommends that we get rid of poets. We exile the poets. I don't think there are any novelists to exile, but he probably would have exiled Gregg Hurwitz, I imagine.
- 3.2** Fast forwarding, Erich Auerbach, giving you a reference there, Mimesis: The Representation of Reality in Western Literature, a great work of criticism, covering the field from Homer, I think he starts with. Certainly, I can remember the 19th-century novelist, including Flaubert. I think he touches on the 20th century. He sees mimesis as gradually improving in the course of Western literature, that we get more accurate, more transparent, more fully representational.
- 3.3** I think in the 20th century, we've become much more skeptical. Certainly recently, we've become more skeptical about the very notion of mimesis. We can go back to Shakespeare that Gregg was referring to yesterday, his great line about holding up the mirror to nature. And I wonder if Gregg Hurwitz thinks he's doing that. But I want to begin with a quotation from his novel, stand-alone novel, The Crime Writer, in which Gregg imagines another crime writer, Andrew Danner, and he refers to his "woefully unrealistic novels." So I wonder, Gregg, do you think of yourself more like Shakespeare, holding up the mirrors to nature? Or do you think of yourself as producing woefully unrealistic novels?
- 3.4** This is such an aggressive opening. So we open with me being excommunicated by Plato, and then you're asking me to compare myself to Shakespeare. Well, yes, I think of myself as Shakespeare, Andy Martin.
- 3.5** On a good day.
- 3.6** On a good day. Well, Drew Danner, I'm very self-deprecating about in The Crime Writer. Well, self-deprecating, that's a tell. But I didn't want to write adoringly of a crime writer who's a spectacular crime writer. That's just too precious. And so I undercut him. I think the books, as I envision them with his, are a bit more hacky than what I attempt. I am trying much more for mimesis, but again, as we discussed, you don't want to have a representation that is actual reality. You don't want dialogueue that's dialogueue.

- 3.7** I used the example yesterday, if you have a funny conversation, but any conversation—if you have a compelling deep conversation with somebody or banter, if you transcribe it precisely, it's not going to read, it's not going to play. And so what you want to do is have, you want verisimilitude, but not truth, right? And so in a lot of ways, I mean, that's in some ways what story is, is we're approximating a truth back to our 6-paragraph blog post, right? If we can state what something is in reality, or a closer approximation of reality, you don't have to write a story about it.
- 3.8** Well, likewise, dialogue that's realistic dialogue is cleaner. There's less pauses. There's more banter. There's more illuminating aspects. There are certain times that I have to speed things up, however. In *The Crime Writer*, which we're talking about, there's a murder trial that takes place at the opening. Most murder trials with anybody with means would take two and a half, three years. Well, I don't want that, given the Platonic unities. I don't want to stretch that across that long in a story. So I have to come up with an excuse to abbreviate it.
- 3.9** We were talking yesterday about—we can get in this a bit more with research. It's trying to find the balance between how much research is going to go into a book and how much is just the right amount that everybody believes. It brings the story to life in a way that carries readers, as I said yesterday, across the suspension of disbelief. That's a research discussion which we can have about how much.
- 3.10** I think you quoted to me the other day, Elmore Leonard? About skipping over.
- 3.11** Somebody asked Elmore Leonard, "How are your books, why are your books so compelling to read?" And he said, "I just leave out all the parts people skip over," which is pretty brilliant. So you have to know what not to show. I mean, the way I think of research, I do extensive research. I've gone undercover into mind control cults. I've gone up in stunt airplanes. I've gone on demolition ranges with Navy Seals and blown up cars. I've shot every gun that Evan Smoak, that Orphan X, shoots. I've been—well, I'll give one example about the importance of this because we're talking about.
- 3.12** So my third book was called *Do No Harm*. It's a medical thriller, and I needed to interview a guy in the hospital. And one of his jobs as a tech was to part out the cadavers, where he'd cut them in pieces and send the joints to the orthopods and the heads would go to neurology. And so the only time I could interview him was literally while he was parting out a body. So I'm sitting there with my notepad, wishing I'd worn galoshes, right? Because he's got like a Sawzall saw going and he's answering questions.
- 3.13** And he finishes with a body and he walks across and there's two enormous doors, giant steel doors. And he opens them and inside are about two dozen corpses, suspended from their heads with figure-8 scissor clamps so that their feet are swaying about two feet above the floor. And that's how they're stored, with the weight from a clamp on their head so that the bodies don't distort for anatomy for the medical students. If you lay them flat, they distort. And he took one, and they're attached to a chain, and pulled

it across the ceiling and laid it down on the table and went to work on the new one. And I thought this was just one of the most spectacular things that I'd seen. But one thing that occurred to me was, I had a scene in which my protagonist is being chased through the hospital at night, and I needed somewhere for him to hide. And so what a wonderful place to have him duck into.

3.14 With all the cadavers.

3.15 With all the cadavers. And again, as I was talking about the example on Thomas Harris of the dry ice, if I have a creepy bunch of hanging bodies because it's neat, that doesn't do anything for the story. But if there's a reason where it's been established, and that's a real place, and I can set a character there, that's pretty compelling ambiance. But if I wasn't willing to go, if I wasn't willing to have that interview and talk with him, I never would have seen this place. And so research isn't a process of going to people to just fill in blanks. You're going to research to be open again to opportunity.

3.16 And of course, you've got to know how to leave out a lot of your research. But I think I'm beginning to understand now how you can be quite so anatomically precise. You've definitely been there. And I think Leonardo da Vinci possibly studied cadavers as well, actually, when actually himself carried out the dissections, possibly.

3.17 And you talk about what to leave out. I think of research, if I'm writing about a topic, as the writer, I want to know the whole iceberg. What makes it in the plot is just a little bit that's above the surface.

3.18 Tip of the iceberg.

3.19 But to know what that tip of the iceberg is, you have to know all of it. And a lot of times, I mean, when I was younger in my career, if I did something, I'd want the research to go into the book in an earlier draft.

3.20 You didn't want to waste it.

3.21 Right. But again, that's the imposition of the writer. That's the imposition of the novelist or the creator into the work if you're doing that, because part of what that signals is, "Look how smart I am." Or in the case of the stunt airplane, which was, I was doing barrel rolls over the Pacific Ocean, and it was scary. It's like, "I'm not going to go through this to not write about it," but it didn't have a place in the project I was working on. So I never wrote about it. So knowing what to leave out. There's a line one of my colleagues remarked on one time about a rough draft. They said, "Your research slip is showing." You don't want to over-expose.

3.22 Were you a PhD student at Oxford in bygone days? I remember you did an MA at Oxford?

3.23 Yeah, MST.

- 3.24** A postgraduate. MST, yeah. Research. So is there a risk for the writer of slipping back into that good student-type mentality, where you put everything in and you reference it as well?
- 3.25** Look, I have the most footnotes, right? And that's not the point.
- 3.26** You know you're going to be examined on this.
- 3.27** There's the line where you talk about in writing, once you get to the editing phase, you have to kill your babies, right? You have to prune. And sometimes there's a great phrase or a flourish or a joke, but if it's not in, if it's not subservient to the scene, you can't have it in. But if it's really clever, it gets hard. It's a dance between ego and outcome, in certain regards. The other thing I'll say about research that's important while we're discussing this is you want to use resources that get beneath the surface. You want to get on-site. I always go so that I have a front row seat to the action.
- 3.28** I went to Oaxaca, the jungles of Oaxaca, and did a class 4 whitewater rafting. My eye got stung by a bee right before we went, some strange Mexican jungle bee, and my whole eye blew up, and we're going down this class 4 whitewater rafting. But if I can experience it, I can write about it differently. So I did some mixed martial arts fighting when I was planning for Orphan X, by which I don't mean to imply that I was great at it. It was largely a process of introducing my face continuously to the training mat. But being choked out in a certain hold, there's a quality. Like, if you've been hit in the face either with a fist or a ball, or at some point we've banged our face, there's a different quality to face pain. It feels differently. When you're getting choked out from proper chokehold, there's a type of claustrophobia that happens that was very specific.
- 3.29** And so what you're trying to avoid is the cliché. You're trying to avoid having a scene, if somebody's choked out and say, "And then everything went dark." What's the generic version of the scene? What's the version of the scene we've read dozens of times? And you don't want to do that. You want to find and pick out the details where a reader leans in and says, "Oh, I didn't know that."
- 3.30** I'll give you one example. One of my Navy Seals friends was talking about how, on missions, if you go up behind somebody, if you're quietly taking a compound and you're dealing with a periphery guard from behind, and you cut their throat from behind, you have to tilt their head down so the lungs don't suck through the slit. That's an example of a detail that, if you read it, is going to ping something differently in your mind to think that somebody is an actual operator, right, than just having them come up and be slashing throats and describing the gore of it, because who cares?
- 3.31** That is a very useful tip. I will bear that in mind. Future reference. Of course, the joke version of the fight scene, a classic fight scene in a movie, and I'm sure you remember this, is Shane, where you've got the barroom brawl, where people are coming up behind some guy, picking up a chair, smashing it over the head, and the guy goes and turns around. "What?" And will punch the guy back, although he's just been hit over

the head with a chair, which, if I remember, it's made of probably sugar or something like that?

3.32 The chair?

3.33 Yeah. So it doesn't really impact. So you see that scene, and people get hit really hard, and then they will turn around and hit someone else back, really, apparently. So in other words, to speak technically in our current terms, that is a scene completely lacking in mimesis, I think. Perhaps the screenwriters didn't do the research on barroombrawls. You probably have done a few barroom brawls over the ages.

3.34 Well, we're not going to get into that. I'll get excommunicated once again by Plato.

3.35 You were doing that last night, weren't you? So therefore, on that note, can we come to—OK, this is a classic line supposedly attributed to Paul Valéry, the great French poet, by André Breton, the surrealist. "La Marquise sortit à cinq heures." The Marquise, or Marchioness, went out at five o'clock. He says, "That is the classic sentence of a realist novel." He was probably thinking in terms of 19th-century realist novels, probably Balzac, even perhaps more than, say, Flaubert. But that, he maintained, they maintained, is a kind of exemplary sentence. And one can see why they said that because you've got the time. It's very specific. You've got the action. You're going out the door. You've got identity. So there's a sociology implied in La Marquise.

3.36 But it strikes me that one of the things that's missing, well, it's kind of implied, I guess, actually, is location. And I wanted to come to the question of location, specifically, partly because in addition to reading the great works of Gregg Hurwitz, I've also been reading Raymond Chandler recently. I was thinking about Los Angeles and how that great city is described, but also mythified by Chandler.

3.37 And I wanted to give you an opportunity, Gregg, to talk about your locations that you've used in your novels. And the two that strike me—one is Los Angeles or some version of Los Angeles anyway, your account of Los Angeles, and San Francisco would be the other one. Are they sort of rooted, and I know you're based on the west coast—are you drawing on them because your—you've mentioned research—presumably here you're drawing on your experience?

3.38 Yes. And with location, people talk about location being a character. That's a phrase that's used a lot. And for me, I have two books in which location is a full-blown character. And by that I mean, the books could not take place anywhere else. Actually, there's 3, the one, well, 4, sorry. But where something is distinct, like the story I wrote about San Francisco can only take place in San Francisco. But even when you're choosing it for background details, you know, when I'm writing about Hollywood, you don't want to pick the obvious things. You don't want to pick the Hollywood sign or Muscle Beach in Venice Beach.

- 3.39 So what are the places? What are the ways that you show that you know a city? Like the example that I was giving about how to properly cut someone's throat from behind. What's a proper way to approach a city that isn't the normal clichés? It's very easy to just feature the things that are expected. And so it's always about trying to crawl beneath and grab a piece of something that's specific so that it's a—
- 3.40 Showing that you're a local, effectively. It's a neighborhood thing.
- 3.41 Or you've understood a city, because being in a city and describing a city is different than understanding a city.
- 3.42 Well, I wonder if, therefore, you might be willing to read this passage taken from *The Crime Writer*, or *I See You in the UK*, I think it is.
- 3.43 You want me to go?
- 3.44 Please.
- 3.45 "Los Angeles, land of endless promise and endless failure. Los Angeles of the petty cruelties. Los Angeles of the instant hierarchy, the spray-on tan, the copped feel. L.A. of the bandaged, post-operative nose, the chai menu, the slander lawsuit. Of the hyphenated job title, the two-SUV garage. L.A. with its wide-open minds and well-formed opinions. L.A. of the high-octane sunset, the warm night air that leaves you drunk. L.A. of the prolonged adolescence, the slow-motion seduction, the ageless, replaceable blonde. L.A. where a porn star runs for governor and an action figure wins. L.A. where anything can happen at any time to some poor schmuck or lucky bastard, where anything can happen to you, where anything had happened to me."
- 3.46 Right, because that—just remind me—that novel starts off with him being accused, doesn't it?
- 3.47 Yeah, there's an opening scene where he comes to, he's got a bandage on his head, he doesn't remember anything. I was playing with the amnesia narrative.
- 3.48 Right. Yeah.
- 3.49 And he's got dirt beneath his nails and he's very disoriented. And these two detectives are pressing him. They show him a crime scene photo of a woman who's been cut stem to stern. It's a close-up on her body. And he's like, horrified. His head's swimming. He says, "Who is that?" And they said, "That that's your ex-fiancé." And as he raises his hand to touch his head, he sees that the dirt beneath his nails carry a tint of red. And he says, "Who did that?" And they say, "You did." And that's the opening scene of *The Crime Writer*.
- 3.50 That's a great opening.
- 3.51 And so it's—I'm playing with the unreliable narrator who is a crime writer who has to then—what he realizes is, he has no memory or no recollection of the events. He's told that he has killed his ex-fiancé. And in order for him to figure out what happened, he

has to sit down and write it as if it's a thriller that he's writing. And then his editor comes in, who's quite a flamboyant, witty figure, and starts to edit the book that he's writing. And we see the editing process. And so if you put together the book that he's writing to reconstruct what happened to him so he can trace his way out—and it's of course being edited because the editor is saying, "Well, why don't you consider this hypothesis? Why don't you consider this?"

- 3.52** So the editing process of a book, combined with the book that he's writing, is the story that we're engaged in, and that's what the novel is. Because the process of editing a book is the process of undeceiving, as we said. It's the process of trying to arrive at a conclusion. So I just had a character doing that literally for himself within the form.
- 3.53** I was just looking at the L.A. passage there, and would it be fair to say that's to some extent satirical? I mean, going back to that Shakespeare analogy, I think after the holding up the mirror, Shakespeare has some line about the form where it's not an exact representation, but he refers to, I think it's the "form and pressure of time." And it's Hamlet saying that. So I think it's like expecting, I mean, Hamlet has this moralizing take on everything. It's not expecting an objective account of anything. So is this location as a way of getting subjectivity in? Because this is certainly, it's a point of view, isn't it? It's not, as it were, a guide to—I mean, perhaps one could, rather as one does with James Joyce in Dublin, could one take your book and wander around L.A. and go, "OK, this is—"
- 3.54** In part. I mean, I don't get directions wrong. That's Tom Wolfe, if I can help it. I'm not also writing a travel guide. And so this clearly also is my hat tip to Raymond Chandler, who was the master of wit, right? "She was a blonde, a blonde to make a bishop kick out a stained glass window," right? His use of humor was so amazing. And humor is another thing that softens the approach to a scene. I was thinking about, you were talking about the barroom fight in *Shane*.
- 3.55** There's another famous scene in *Indiana Jones*, where the two guys come with all the swords, right? And he just rolls his eyes and draws his gun and shoots them. Well, that scene was rewritten on the day because he had a stomach flu and he wasn't feeling well and he didn't want to do a whole action scene. So they rewrote it in that fashion. So it's a shortcut. However, it's perfectly suited to character. It's such a—I mean, it's suited to actor Harrison Ford. He could do that as Han Solo also. He's always that sort of wry, cynical, but it's very suited to *Indiana Jones* as well because he's a roguish figure. So you couldn't do that with *James Bond*. That's not a *James Bond* scene, for instance, when we're talking about how scenes have to fit.
- 3.56** But humor is another way that takes the edge off and collects the reader or the viewer into something that feels like it's reality. It's not just that there's a reality piece, but we recognize the cleverness of that, and the cleverness of that is our engagement. If it's a Spike Lee movie, that's the prelude to an endless orchestrated choreograph fight scene. So in this, we're joined in on the fact that we have seen other movies and we're

subverting a kind of expectation. And so we're pulled into the narrative by not seeing what is expected.

- 3.57** So there's sort of two ways you can go with it. If you have some very interesting, cool piece of telling the tale, that can really draw us in in a way that feels real. But of course, Indiana Jones is fantastical. It has a pinky toe in comics. It's got a foot in adventure stories. And so it invites us into the world itself with the viewer when it makes a joke like that.
- 3.58** I wonder if we can, on a heavier note, bring in one really good theoretician on this subject, and see if that makes sense here. I think it's a useful theoretical hook to hang our hats on. I'm referring to Jakobson and his work on aphasia, two types of aphasia, where he makes this really interesting distinction between the metaphoric and the metonymic. Everyone now must be acquainted with aphasia, thanks to Bruce Willis, who is suffering from it. So it effectively means—it can mean different things—but effectively, it is a pathology of language when language doesn't work anymore.
- 3.59** And Jakobson, usefully, rather like good medics—if you want to understand how something works, try to understand how it doesn't work to begin with. So he looks at how aphasia works or doesn't work. And he sees there are two ways in which it doesn't work, the metaphoric and the metonymic. Metaphoric, he doesn't use it to mean a set of metaphors. So the classic one would be, "My love is like a red, red rose." And the important point he draws attention to there is that love is nothing like a red, red rose.
- 3.60** But the poet is suggesting there is a connection, but there is an obvious connection. OK. The thing about the metonymic is there is an obvious connection. I always mix up the metonymic with synecdoche. And the obvious synecdoche that springs to my mind right now is—is it the Netflix series, *The Crown*, about British royals? Now, *The Crown* is technically a metonym, or synecdoche, for specific royal people. And there's an obvious connection because the Queen or the King wears a crown. So therefore, it very readily symbolizes as a connection between *The Crown* and people wearing the crown. OK, so it's not like a metaphor.
- 3.61** So the metonymic suggests, as Jakobson says, contiguity, or causation in time and space. So my suggestion is that metaphor, the metaphoric, draws us in. The metaphoric is the myth. The metonymic is location. It's time and space. It's the Marchioness going out of the door at 5 o'clock and how those things connect up. That we want the dream, but in order to, as it were, dare I say, sell the dream to make the dream plausible, you need that great framework of the metonymic to make things hang together, to make sure time and space are orderly, not random.
- 3.62** Or if you chop up time and space, which writers are always tempted to do, to backtrack, fast forward, and so on, then it still has to make some kind of sense, ultimately. You have to be able to, as it were, reassemble time and space in your mind.

So you're working within a kind of framework. You have to impose that framework of plausibility on you.

3.63 Yes. And we're getting to narrative contract.

3.64 We're getting there because I think, in a way, you start with a dream, don't you, in some sense, or an image in your head? When you actually write the book, it's an idea that you wanted to—

3.65 There's one book that I have a very clear memory of how it evolved in my head, because often it comes in. I had the metaphor yesterday of settling into a snow angel or when you're on a blanket on the beach and you're trying to settle into a form, you're settling into a story, and pieces come in, and you amend it, and there's different ways that you find it. But I wrote a book called *The Survivor*, and I remember the first image that I ever had. This is a good way to talk about how story might build.

3.66 And I thought, what if there's a guy, he's standing on a ledge, we don't really know where, he's looking out at the distant beach, so Santa Monica—we'll put him there. Wind's riffling his hair, and he's on a ledge, and we realize suddenly that he's there to kill himself. He went to his bank building and went out on the eighth floor and out of the bathroom, went out on the ledge, and was going to deposit himself neatly in a dumpster that's eight stories below. And just as he takes his foot off the edge of the ledge and he's waiting to tumble, there's gunfire inside the bank, and the window to the side of him gets painted in a swath of crimson.

3.67 And he turns around and he looks in, and there's robbers who are moving through the bank and they're shooting people. And one guy puts his gun down right by the table in front of him and turns around and is rifling through everything. So rather than go off the ledge and commit suicide, instead this person who clearly has no fear now of getting killed and nothing to live for, goes in the window and picks up the gun to confront the robber in process. That was the first scene. And I thought, OK, that's a pretty compelling first image for me.

3.68 So all of that manifested itself to you straight off the bat, that whole scenario?

3.69 Then we have some questions. First of all, we have a character who is in a unique position in place in time. It's not the hero. You have the *Passenger 57* version, right, where there's a plane hijacked and guess what? Like, Wesley Snipes is in seat 17C. We have that narrative. That's also the formation of *Die Hard*, the hero in an unlikely place. But for me, what made this different in certain regards is he's not somebody who's cowering, who happens to be a former Navy SEAL, right? And he's one of the people who's in the bank who then has his moment. For me, what was interesting is his engagement and his arrival into the scene is from a very specific position of somebody who's ready to end his own life.

- 3.70** So when the guys pull the gun at him, like when he's threatened, he just laughs. Like, he doesn't care. "You interrupted my suicide," right? So it immediately puts him in a different position in terms of every engagement in terms of the action. So then the next question becomes, "OK, well, why is he killing himself?" And so for that, I had to kind of build that out and figure out, well, what's compelling? How can I make a reader care about somebody who's going to kill themselves? What's the motivation? And then additionally, if that's what he wants to do, what is something that's going to turn him around that's going to make him want to live for something?
- 3.71** And so there's these building blocks, and you have to engage with them in goodwill. And the narrative contract, which we can discuss a little bit more technically, is the set of choices you make at the beginning. The world is open to you at the beginning of a story. You get to choose. And so in the case of this, if somebody goes, "Well, what are the odds of that happening? What are the odds that a guy who's going to kill himself is in front of a bank building? That's so coincidental," and you say, "Of course it is, but I'm not going to write the 99,000 times that it doesn't happen." That's not the book you want. At the beginning, you're allowed to place the suppositions. You're allowed to set the terms. You're building the labyrinth.
- 3.72** And so there's this interesting thing when you begin a project, when you begin a story, you have a lot of freedom to set the terms, to set the world. If something's unlikely or coincidental, there's no problem. If you do that in the third act, if the culmination rests on the fact that there's some key event that's going to happen and then a robbery happens to occur for no reason, that's completely unconnected from anything else in the story, that's aggravating because you've broken the narrative contract. You set the terms early.
- 3.73** And there's a case of this with clues. The Sixth Sense doesn't work if you go back and watch the movie or when they do that, everything holds together. There's not a random scene where it doesn't make sense that Bruce Willis isn't actually there. And he goes back and plays that. There's a scene where he reaches for the bill, and his wife slides it out right before his hand touches it. He's missing everywhere, and we've seen it all. So you're played with fairly. So another aspect of this, with narrative contract, is you decide the terms of how many characters and what perspective and how we're going to enter the story and how you're going to engage with the story. And so once again, how many characters are there? You don't generally want to have—
- 3.74** Well, it's what was so unique about Psycho because Psycho takes you into the story with one character who we think is going to be the lead. And then, of course, she's killed in the shower. And Hitchcock does something really interesting that every cut is a cut, is an editing cut. So he's severing the form, and she's dead, and the new characters show up. Well, you can do that at the hinge of the turn of the first act. But you can't just introduce a character in the third act who's going to come in and solve everything. That's deus ex machina. That's a cheat. The same thing holds true for what language

you're going to use, what perspectives you're going to use. So that beginning, it's very important. Are you first person? Are you third person? Are you going to tell it from multiple perspectives? We should talk about hierarchy of perspective in a moment.

3.75 OK. I think, you have a certain responsibility as writer to play fair to readers. I'm not sure if that applies to TV writers. I mean, anyone who's seen the last season of *Lost*, for example. You know, well, actually *Game of Thrones*, perhaps, is a bit like that. And was it *Dynasty*, possibly in bygone days, where one of the main characters is killed in one season, comes back several seasons later, and they said that the rest of that was just a dream that actually didn't happen. We're going to start again.

3.76 Soap operas have different narrative contracts.

3.77 Oh, do they?

3.78 There's lots of twins, right? There's lots of doubling.

3.79 You can't have the dream thing come in. "Oh, that was just madness on my part. And we'll start again now" kind of thing. You can't allow yourself that getup.

3.80 But look, the rules hold significantly in TV. So a couple of things to think about with television form and how it's changed, right? When you used to watch television, when there was commercials, what television was was, from a straight financial model, was enough story to get viewers from one commercial break to the next commercial break. That was the form itself. That's where the money was made. So the creatives are constantly engaging with them. But there used to be—let's say it's an hour drama. The longest break that would occur for commercials was in the dead center of it. And so that was the biggest cliff-hang. And so if you look at early TV shows, there's a big peak in the middle because you had get people back from the refrigerator or the bathroom or sitting through a bunch of different commercials to get back to the story.

3.81 Well, with the advent of streaming, that starts to have an effect on story. So what's the biggest thing that they want? As soon as we finish a show, the next show will start in five, four, three, two, and you're in, and you're exhausted, and it's two in the morning, and you have to get up to have a discussion with Andy Martin the next morning about the art of story, but you're watching the next episode. And so in streaming, with streaming, the peak is at the end.

3.82 If you look at *House of Cards*, if you look at *Game of Thrones*, they usually end with something that's enormous because you're leaning forward to the next one. And so the forms change within that. But you do need narrative contract and you do need rules, because especially in horror and science fiction or in anything, because without rules, everything gets sloppy.

3.83 OK, well, can we come back to rules then, actually? I just want to go back to another your cities here under the heading of location. This is from *Tell No Lies*. This is the narrator's account of San Francisco. Gregg, you might like to read this, but you might

also like to explain why the narrator is somewhat—I mean, he has a particular take at this point, or it seems slightly hallucinatory, not because he's high, but has someone just kicked him in the head?

- 3.84** Someone's just kicked him in the head.
- 3.85** Right. OK. So he's got a concussion. So there's a medical background.
- 3.86** Well, and so it's dreamy, it's swimmy, the description, right? This is *Tell No Lives*, which is very much a San Francisco novel. This novel couldn't take place anywhere else, and he's from there. And he's in a state of disarray. He's from a storied family in San Francisco, and his kind of conception is starting to come apart about the different social structures and the aspects and advantages that he's always enjoyed. He's starting to see through a different light the ways that those are based. And so the journey for him into himself is a journey into his engagement with the city which changes around him. His perception of the world that he's lived in is altering. We talked about the external mirroring the internal.
- 3.87** And so as he's rolling through here, he's driving through the city and his head's swimming. And it says, "The sun broke across the horizon, fanning a sheet of gold through the iconic skyline. Daniel was weary, half-asleep behind the wheel, the early morning haze of the city a match for the early morning haze muffling the steady throb in his head. He cut past the Castro, where Latina drag queens in fishnets and feathers paraded the sidewalks, strutting past bars with inventively uninventive names—the Lonely Bull, the Missouri Mule, Dirty Dick's.
- 3.88** "He kept on skirting the edge of the Haight, where painted VW buses and druggie runaways littered the curves in search of a lost decade. During the summer of love, Janis Joplin strummed her Gibson in a one-room flop pad here, a tambourine's throw from where The Grateful Dead commune tuned in and dropped out. Relics of each era endured, layered like geological strata and storefronts, charting the evolution from Beatniks to hippies to yuppies to fauxhemians."
- 3.89** And there's a bit more if you want to read on this last paragraph.
- 3.90** "Forging north, Daniel sliced through Alamo Square, its picket row of pastel Victorians basking in the first pink-tinged rays of the new day. Beyond their fanciful gingerbread gables rose the green copper dome of City Hall, where ousted Catholic and local sandlotter-made-good Joe DiMaggio said "I do" to Marilyn, and where, a couple of decades later, five hollow-point bullets cut down Harvey Milk in the corridors of power. So much beauty and horror, a city that burned to the ground 6 times before its first decade, flamed out and yet rose from the ashes again and again, a boxer who wouldn't stay down."

- 3.91** Yeah, I love that last, well, that is a metaphor for the whole city. And that presumably is a kind of allegory also for the narrative. So you're seeing individuals and this larger collective entity all wound up in each other.
- 3.92** Well, his city—we all live in a different city. Whoever's in Miami, all of you live in a different Miami, right? I talked about, with the intimate relationship of novelist and reader, every reader constructs their own movie in their head. It's a collaboration between novelist and reader, unlike a movie where everybody sees the same movie, and you can have a different reaction. But we all live in a different city. And so how is your narrator, how are your characters engaging with the city or with their location, is as distinct as how they engage with their other characters, and they shouldn't have an engagement like everybody else.
- 3.93** And so every role should be imagined. It's very interesting. TV is great training for this because you have your cast list, and you talk about who's on top of the cast list as the kind of stars, and there's a hierarchy. The hierarchy is who gets listed in what order. It's generally matched to their billing and what they get paid. You have to do a read when you're done with a TV episode in every act to make sure that your leads have something to do concretely. Then you go back and you make sure that, even if it's a secondary, but if it's a character who's recurring, if it's somebody who's a member of the cast, you do a read for every scene.
- 3.94** You can't get an actor out of their trailer and into a scene if they're sitting in the background and everyone else is having a conversation. That's not going to go well. And not merely from an ego perspective, because you don't want to treat an actor like a prop, but they should have engagement in a scene in a way that matters. And so likewise, nothing should be a wasted opportunity. So even if you have somebody who's a store clerk, and someone's just going in to make a purchase, there's a way to have that be illuminating of that character, or of our character and the reaction to them, or of the city, or of this moment in the plot, or what is your character engaging or thinking about with them that throws a ray of—let's say, it's guilt that's compounding the guilt of the situation.
- 3.95** And so there's a wonderful Tom Stoppard play called *Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead*. And in that, he takes these two very secondary characters. It's a throwaway line, right? When they die, it just says, "Rosencrantz and Guildenstern are dead." And we don't bother to show it. We don't bother to mourn them. We don't bother to go there. And so he takes the title of these incredibly secondary characters, and he tells the whole play of *Hamlet*, but from their perspective. So in their little tiny scenes in the play, they're having a conversation. But then it shows them in other intervals where *Hamlet*'s walking in the background. "To be or not to be, that is the question." But we're focused on them. And so every character—
- 3.96** You've inverted the hierarchy, in fact.

- 3.97** That's right.
- 3.98** Hamlet's at the bottom now. He's not getting paid very much.
- 3.99** That's right.
- 3.100** Rosencrantz and Guildenstern are still getting paid.
- 3.101** That's right.
- 3.102** Stars.
- 3.103** That's right.
- 3.104** That's brilliant, isn't it?
- 3.105** It's brilliant. And so when you're writing, and let's say you have a throwaway character. We see this a lot with the depiction of, like, cops' wives, right, in previous decades in shows. "You're working too hard. Don't take a risk. Can't you be rather—" It's like a generic cop wife role. Or we have these generic things like the cop partner. It's another trope. He's going to be shot. They're on the stakeout and the crusty old veteran is like, "Well, just my last day and I'm going to buy that sailboat and move down to Florida." You're like, "Oh, the guy's getting killed." And that's going to set the template of it.
- 3.106** So there's these templates. And what your job is to go in and make them all real and subvert them. It'd be clever in that scene, for instance, if the guy gives that speech, and it's the rookie who gets shot. So how do we take a trope that we've engaged in? But your writing and every character should exist as if the whole rest of the world spins around them.
- 3.107** Yeah, of course. That makes sense. I tell you what, I love this idea of someone who doesn't care about dying. Becoming a hero because you're sort of immune. You're almost invulnerable.
- 3.108** So, "how do I make him vulnerable" is the question. And so in *The Survivor*, for instance, because we have to care, we need him to be vulnerable, and I need the audience to care about him. And so part of it was— so this is what unfolded.
- 3.109** Of course. Should we, without giving too much away, that he's got that— that comes at the beginning. So he's got that condition.
- 3.110** So he has—so I'll give you an example. This is an example. I will talk to you about sort of the construction of this story. It was called *The Survivor* a little bit. So I have this flash of him on the ledge. I wanted him to have some military expertise because he's going to go in and pick up a gun. I did not want him—
- 3.111** He's a vet, isn't he?
- 3.112** He's a vet, but he's not a Navy Seal or an Army Ranger. He's a vet who got drafted, went over to Iraq. He knows how to handle a gun. He still is an everyman, though. He's not a superhero. That was very important for the plot. Well, then I thought, well, what

would be a reason for him to want to commit suicide? It's like, if he has a degenerative, horrifying pain disease. So then that's starting to stack coincidences pretty heavy, all of a sudden. So I thought, well, what's a way I can marry this into the plot? This is how we're starting to stitch the tapestry of a story together. Well, ALS, Lou Gehrig's disease, is heightened by a significant ratio for vets, and people don't really know why. It might be exposure to certain chemicals, like the coating of bullets.

3.113 It was Stephen Hawking's condition, wasn't it?

3.114 That's right.

3.115 Right. OK.

3.116 But so I didn't want to say, well, "He's a vet and he's here and also he has pancreatic cancer." It feels a little floaty. But if I can marry that to him being a veteran, we're in the world, right? Like a lot of, like X percent of vets, he came back and got the lucky draw, and it fits in a story. So then how do we care for him? How do we have him be a good guy? And so I wanted him to have a family who he cares about, and a daughter. Well, if you're going to kill yourself and leave behind a family, that's not so sympathetic, right? So what if he came back from the war and was very traumatized and he was dealing with PTSD in the house and he loves his wife? I go back and tell a romance story with them. She's now living with somebody else.

3.117 He loves his daughter, but when he came back, he was so broken that his engagement in the house—like, he was waking up and stumbles out and, like, bangs in and splits his head open because he thinks he's in another place, and there's blood, and his daughter is horrified. She's young then, and he's a mess. And so he basically is separated, and then he gets this life-ending diagnosis. And basically, he realizes that he's got nothing, and if he thinks that his daughter is sort of very well cared for financially—this is how all these pieces come in.

3.118 You're giving away the whole story here.

3.119 I'm not. This is first act. This is narrative contract still. This is none of the twists and turns, right? But so the wife is with somebody else who's got a lot of money, so his daughter is very well cared for. He's already—and he doesn't want to put her and his ex-wife through this deteriorating process that he's going to go through. He's going to spare them that. Well, what happens? As soon as he gets—I won't give a lot of details, but basically, they key to the fact that he has a daughter. They come and they get him. He wakes up. There's a scene that I write where he's embedded in a block of ice. This is a torture technique that I read about, up to his waist.

3.120 And you're quite good on this torture technique.

3.121 Thank you very much, Andy. You cross too many more hardball questions, you see where you're going to wind up, my friend. And his arms are linked above with a chain to his head. And there's a chainsaw that's resting on it. And the bad guy comes in and

says, "This is something we've done. We can cut you in half and place the top half of you on the ice, and you'll be alive for about 5 minutes, like, severed, because the ice is going to preserve it unless you do X for us." And he's like, "That sucks and it'll be miserable, but go ahead." And then they say, "We know you have a daughter. Here's what we're going to do to her if you don't obey."

3.122 So then all of a sudden, as his body is deteriorating and as he has no will to live, I have a character who's entering the plot. He's got a ticking time bomb in his body in that his condition can worsen, his hands can tremble, but he has to save his daughter. He's motivated to do that. And of course, when he goes to his daughter, the other thing that he learns is that the husband, the stepfather, or the boyfriend who has had all this money, is going to leave and isn't going to support his family. So all of a sudden we have all these—we stack a time bomb in his body. We stack a connection with him. And so the book is his journey to reunite with and protect his family as his body is deteriorating.

3.123 Well, that's how I built a story around an opening image that I had of a guy standing on a ledge. And so that's the kind of stitching that you want to do when you're writing a story, is you want to make all the pieces connect. But then once we have this immense freedom at the beginning, right—so this is me building out narrative contract. It's from his perspective. I move to some other perspectives. As the plot progresses, what happens is the freedom of the characters expand, and then the choices should necessarily limit themselves to get to that feeling we have when something is shockingly surprising and makes perfect sense at the same time. Right?

3.124 And so you can't do anything that you want towards the end. If you're true to the characters and you've built them, if you're true to the scenarios, the options themselves should start to tighten into a more logical outcome in which you're constrained and the story comes to a whole. There's a way that you have to get your arms around it for it to conclude that feels both organic and surprising.

3.125 Right. I definitely want to delete the implication that Gregg is into torture, by the way, because the thing that he is into is mimesis, of course. And I want to switch from location to, well, it's still space, but anatomical space. And this is something that really strikes me. By the way, I'm reminded your story, *The Survivor*—OK, true story. I'm going to give this to you. It's a gift. OK, beginning of the next novel.

3.126 True story about an 80-year-old guy who's an old friend of mine at Yale. He had that survivor-type thing because he'd just been to hospital. And I don't know, they're giving all sorts of treatment, and didn't want it. And he parks outside. I think it was actually a convenience store in New Haven. And a guy, OK, and this is a true story, although it sounds like a movie. Guy comes running out having just robbed the store with a gun in his hand, jumps into the back of his car. My old friend is in the front of the car. Guy jumps in the back and, like a guy in a movie, points the gun at my friend's head and

says, "Drive or I'll shoot you." And my friend, who just completely depressed by his experience, turns around and says, "Please shoot me."

3.127 And I'm about to say, the poor guy who's holding the gun at his head doesn't know what to do, jumps out of the car again, runs down the street, and is arrested, of course. OK, so it didn't end well for him. And my old friend said that he was really annoyed with the guy for not shooting him. Anyway, OK. But to come to anatomical space, we can discuss that later.

3.128 So this is a little quote I'm giving you from Kill Clause. "He felt the soft give of the cricothyroid membrane, then cut a lengthwise slit through Dobbins's flesh." So that's a Tim Rackley novel. So Tim Rackley, on the one hand, and some poor devil called Dobbins, on the other hand. Now, how many of you here know where the cricothyroid membrane is? I personally have no idea. Or rather, I'm starting to get a bit of an idea, having read Gregg's work. So my question to you—well, here's another example.

3.129 Let's pause with that.

3.130 Please go on. Unless you would like to read The Nowhere Man.

3.131 Well, let's set context with this. This is a great jumping-on point.

3.132 OK, give us—

3.133 The cricothyroid membrane. So this is for, if somebody is choking to death, right? And he's trying to get a straw in below. In this case, somebody came up behind, I believe, we're going back, this is my fourth novel, and drops a plastic flex cuff. You know, the cops use to arrest people. If you loop one over someone's neck or a simple garbage tie, and just zip it shut, you can kill someone pretty easily and you do it quickly, especially if you pre-loop it and it's big. Because then it's just embedded in the flesh and the person can't do anything. So Tim Rackley is actually trying to help this guy, and he's doing the process—he's a federal marshal—of where you find the place to cut in order to insert a straw so somebody can breathe.

3.134 So a couple things. When you watch a show like ER, when you watch a movie like Zero Dark Thirty, there's a lot of banter that's happening, right? When they're doing a surgery, there's all sorts of medical talk. None of us know what all that medical talk is. We don't say, well, "Why is it you are using all these big words that we don't understand?" The point of using the words isn't to have them all defined cleanly and to turn something into a textbook. But the point is to put you in a cloud of reality around the terms, where you're bearing witness to something and you can see what's happening. And here you have the advantage, of course, of watching it visually.

3.135 So they're saying, "Hand me the whatever," and then the tool comes in. But when you're writing, what you want to do is do that with the reader. You want to put the reader into a world where they don't have to understand anything. But if I'm talking about, like, "Tim put his hand on his throat and felt for," you're oriented. And then

what you don't want to do is say, like, let's say there's a tool like a laryngoscope in a medical scene, to say, "Can I have the laryngoscope?" And then say, "Well, the laryngoscope is an L-shaped tool that is used to compress the tongue in order to insert a—", right, and give a little explanation, and then you continue. It's very awkward.

- 3.136** Some writers will do that. You'll see this in an amateur way where they're reading and defining, and they're writing and defining, I mean. So when you're reading, all of a sudden you're very aware that you're reading reading, because you're having a term defined for you. So what you'd want to say instead, for instance, is, "Hand me the laryngoscope." OK, well, we don't know what that is. And then I would say, for instance, "The L-shaped tool slapped the latex of the surgeon's palm." I'm describing what it looks like as I'm committing it to action. It's almost like you're tricking the reader by—you want the reader to be coming with you and not standing and saying, "Here's how this works. Here's the research. Let me define all these terms." You're ushering them along with you.
- 3.137** And so the more details that you're dropping in to explain what's happening in the scene, right, it's what we do with character. You want to illuminate character as the plot is progressing. You don't want to stop and say, "Well, he was born in this year, and he grew up here, and he studied this."
- 3.138** Exposition.
- 3.139** Where do you feed those bits and pieces that you don't feel like somebody all of a sudden gets to a big exposition scene, right, where the characters are talking and they're explaining things that they would never be explaining to themselves in real life, because people don't talk that way? And then the reader all of a sudden feels like apython who swallowed a pig, and you have to digest it. There's this giant lump of exposition that you're asking to process and digest, and it's exhausting.
- 3.140** Actually, you just sort of made me think of a specific Bond-like moment there, actually, which I wonder if you ever allow yourself—where the global supervillain will pause to explain to Bond exactly why he's just about to kill Bond. There'll be 5 minutes before he kills him. And then in that 5 minutes, his whole plan, theory, campaign, and why he's going to take over the world. Do you ever allow yourself that scene?
- 3.141** No, not anymore. Well, and that's the one where he's like, dangling with his pruriently named mistress above a tank of sharks, right? And they're bound with rope, and the rope has been sprinkled with salt, and rats are going to chew through it while they dangle. And then he'll drop into the shark pit and die, and then everyone leaves them alone, right? So we're asking for a pretty good catapult across a suspension of disbelief, but that's the form of early Bond. Early Bond was more fantastical than Daniel Craig Bond. They changed some of the rules of the contract. I thought they broke them in one of the first iterations. I can't remember the name of the movie, but when he was beaten and abused and was banged up and imprisoned, and it starts very, very dark.

3.142 Was that Casino Royale?

3.143 I think it was.

3.144 Yeah, the later Casino Royale.

3.145 But in a way, that breaks contract. That's not what happens to James Bond. He can get punched, but you don't want to see him, like, unshaven and tortured and down. That's not a Bond scene. That's a Bourne scene, right? Yeah. Estranged from home. And so what the best thing for me, when you're writing—what you want to do is have all the pieces sort of make sense to how somebody's going to die, and they're all established in these little bits and pieces that lead up to it, so that when you get to this sort of an unlikely scene, you're not stopping to have it explained between characters, which is such a cheat, right?

3.146 I'm going to tell you things that we already know, right? And I'm going to hide it in dialogue in a way because I've been too lazy to set it within, subtly within, the globe of the story that I've woven around the reader or the viewer, so that we're in it, so that when an event happens, we're caught up to it, and it should happen. And instead, I'm going to stop and have it be explained in discourse or put it in voiceover at the start of a movie. Those are all things when you hear voiceover, and you think, "I'm sitting in a movie and someone's talking to me." You're not lost in a movie. When characters are talking and explaining something, we have to patiently wait and go, "OK, this is all getting explained. Let's get to the cool action part. It's being explained to me why this is impossible."

3.147 And there's ways to play with that. Mission Impossible, for instance, does it really well where they go, "OK, well, we have to do this impossible thing." You need it explained because you need Tom Cruise to, like, squeeze through the eye of a needle. But as they're explaining it and mapping it, part of what they do is often they'll cut ahead and show it happening as they're explaining it, rather than I'm going to explain all this in a PowerPoint. Audience is going to know. We're explaining what we're going to do. Then we show them doing it. In a way, they're like, "Look, there's guards here, here, and here." Cut away. Like, guard killed, guard killed, guard killed, right. "Then we're going to have to get here. Then we're going to have to do this." Then at some point with that catch-up, you just move into the last leg of the impossible mission that he has to achieve. And the reader, at least, is being propelled rather than explained to, or the viewer.

3.148 I've got to say, while sitting here, listening to Gregg, I feel as though he would be capable of writing a really dramatic version of a seminar taking place in Miami, where you would be able to turn that into a kind of action scene in some way. Because would you have, as per Chandler, have a blonde walk through the door with a gun in her hand or a bomb going off somewhere like that, actually? Or could you integrate discussion and exposition into a narrative? Actually, I think you've got some quite academic in—

which one—The Program that Tim Rackley, The Program, where you have the academic psychologist that gives you a whole exposition on mind control. I found that fascinating, but OK, that may be the academic in me. But how did you approach that?

- 3.149** I went undercover into mind control cults. I didn't go away in a van. I wanted to experience it. This is, by the way—so, The Program, I invented my own mind control cult, and it's called The Program. It's the only time that I've done research and then I had to lower my description of what really happened because the reader wouldn't buy it. It's so outlandish. It was so surreal. But when you go, and so this was another example of me trying to experience something instead of just understand it theoretically.
- 3.150** So first I read a bunch of books, right? And I had some dynamics that I wanted explained in the course of research. Tim Rackley, my character, goes and talks to a professor. So I wanted an exposition scene for him to understand before he himself goes undercover. But when I experienced it, you're in this sort of lockdown facility by the airport, right? It's a big ballroom in, call it a Radisson. And they see everybody in a giant U, right? So you're around 200 people in a U-shape and they're talking. And they'll say something like, "Whoever is ready for change in your life, stand up."
- 3.151** And the pressure that you feel—we all think that we're so independent. We all think that we're the one war criminal, when they line up the prisoners to shoot them, who would step out of line and heroically line up with the people who are being shot. When 199 people are standing up and you're shaped in a way that everyone's looking at you, there's an incredible amount of social pressure that's brought to bear. And so I was playing a game because what I wanted to do is see all the layers of the cult.
- 3.152** But if you push too hard—and I did my research like Tim Rackley before I went—they'll distinguish you as—they think of people as goats or sheep. And if you're too much of a goat, they'll just remove you because, for group shift dynamics in psychology, it takes one consistent, highly disagreeable person to shift a group, and they don't want that. So I was kind of pushing and seeing who else would talk to me, and I was just really observing what the scenario was. But I learned it. Unbelievable. It's fascinating.
- 3.153** So you were a potential recruit?
- 3.154** Oh, yeah. They invited me. They do love-bombing, right? Love-bombing is where people really look at you. It's intense eye contact, but everybody is. And they're really interested in you and they're fascinated, and they lean in. So there's all these unspoken cues. And if I act like cult Gregg, there's more interest. I'm more the center of attention. If I act like Gregg Gregg, there's very subtle cues of just a lack of interest.
- 3.155** There's a famous debate. I think this might be apocryphal. Two quick stories. So B. F. Skinner, the behaviorist, and Carl Rogers, who is the humanist, right? "How does that make you feel?" Carl Rogers' line. Had a debate. And in the course of the debate, supposedly, Skinner conditioned Rogers to blink 5 times more rapidly than at the

beginning. And there's another story, I think perhaps also apocryphal, that William James was lecturing, and his students did this as a trick with him. When he went to the right of the stage, they leaned in the left, and then he fell off the right side of the stage, supposedly.

- 3.156** So when you're observing this and you know it, just knowing it doesn't not put you at the mercy of it. We've probably all been to a mediocre West End play or Broadway play. And at the end, all the out-of-town tourists stand up and applaud, and you're in a front row. And you don't want to sit there like some asshole and be the one person who's like, "No, my statement is, this wasn't up to my standards." So you rise and all of a sudden you're giving a standing ovation to the sixth-run cast of *Cats*. There's all these ways that these influences happen.
- 3.157** So the engagement in it, to understand both the psychology and then to engage in it, it's fascinating. But the thing I did not do—so limitations of research, is then they say, "You're so amazing, Gregg, that we want to invite you to a 3-day leadership council." And basically, it only takes 3 days to get somebody fully under your control. And they put you in a van and they distract you, talking and listening to you. It doesn't have windows. You're not sure where you are. You're up a mountain, you're out of a cell phone range, and then they have you, all of a sudden.
- 3.158** And they'll put you in a cabin with a broken sprinkler outside. So they start sleep deprivation. The events are early in the morning. There's a lot of rhythmic pacing. They do a lot of high sugar hits in the food. And everywhere that you're looking, there's privacy deprivation. And all your cues have changed. They've just shifted. So everywhere I look, it's cult Gregg and not Gregg Gregg. And they just take you slowly off-course. So that's worth looking into, right? Rather than writing a generic zombie mind control scene. To really know that working and then to create that with the characters. And then what's the personal challenge then, of course, if I'm going to drop my character in? How do I make this more personal about what it means for him?
- 3.159** OK, we're going to come to the question of psychological realism. But I wondered if you were coming back to the physiological real. Do you want to read that? The Nowhere Man?
- 3.160** "With everything he had"—this is Evan Smoak, Orphan X—"he stomped his heel down into Angel's instep, a foot destruction targeting the proximal interphalangeal joint of the first metatarsal."
- 3.161** OK, that's brilliant. And *Out of the Dark* gives you this—actually, that perhaps is rare where it gives you this explanation of why it is that we faint with pain. I didn't know this. I found this really interesting.
- 3.162** The vasovagal.
- 3.163** Yeah, I had no idea about that.

- 3.164** And these do opposing things, these examples. It's a good illustration. So this is, "The vasovagal response. Strong emotional or physical distress activates the vagus nerve, which in turn widens the blood vessels. That reduces blood flow to the heart, which slows down the heart rate and impedes circulation to the head, which in turn causes lightheadedness and—that's right—fainting."
- 3.165** So this is him impressing on somebody. And this explanation now, it seems I've broken my own rule of explaining something. But if you're explaining something, now this is in both instances. This is Orphan X, where within him stating very clearly why he's doing something, and part of this is supposed to be funny. Part of this is, it's like, that's what he's doing. And it's the example I gave of cutting someone's throat. But instead of saying, "He stomped his foot and then was released," which is very generic, it's like, he's Orphan X. So what he's doing is, he's precisely breaking a foot. That's what he's doing.
- 3.166** And so there's some times that I'll do this and I'll stop. But if you're going to stop and explain something, to not say "the laryngoscope is," in my previous example, he'll describe, you know, a tension pneumothorax, is when the lung is collapsed, and it collapses on itself, and the person slowly dies.
- 3.167** That's part of his character, in other words, to be so precise and a little bit laborious in his explanations.
- 3.168** And then to inflict that on somebody. And that's what makes it interesting. Because he'll say—
- 3.169** So that is funny.
- 3.170** And then he'll puncture somebody so that their lung collapses, and then he'll calmly explain what's just happened.
- 3.171** Yeah. So I was wondering, I think I heard, out of the top of my head, is that right that your dad is or was a doctor? Because not to put you too much on the spot, but if I remember correctly, Flaubert's dad was a doctor and Proust's dad was a doctor. So do you have to have someone in your family who's a doctor in order to become a decent writer these days? Is that a bonus or what?
- 3.172** Can you imagine if I said yes? Yes. Any of you who don't come from backgrounds with physicians, you're just—
- 3.173** Right. You know what I mean.
- 3.174** No, but my father, my grandfather, my great-uncle, my sister—I'm from a medical family. And what's amazing for me is to be of a family where that's one of the governing ethos. Talked about how when you write character, you want to pull their mask over your face and see the world through their eyeholes, right? But I remember I'd be with my dad, and if there was a waiter, let's say that there's a waiter of a certain age comes by and has a slight limp or shuffle, if I was sitting with my father, he would

say, "Oh, he's the age. That's polio, right before the vaccine." How he observes, and I'd be much more interested in, well, what's the injury? How did it happen? I'd be thinking in different ways.

3.175 And so when everyone observes the world differently through not just their own filters, but their experience in their profession—so when Evan is talking about breaking someone's foot, it's almost medical.

3.176 Right. Exactly.

3.177 But it's not medical, right. So I did write a medical thriller, and what was unusual with that—a lot of people have written legal thrillers who aren't lawyers or courtroom readers. But what was interesting when I wrote a medical thriller is a lot of the reviewers thought that I was a doctor because nobody really writes a medical thriller unless you're a doctor. Robin Cook and Michael Palmer and Michael Crichton. If you get on the list, they're all MDs. But I grew up in that enough that I could—

3.178 Appropriate that.

3.179 And embody that. I know how my father thinks. That was a governing ethos. I could see the world well through his perspective. One other observation, we're talking about research in this phase. And so it's like, well, what are your responsibilities? I wrote a book that's based on a case that my father had, that there was somebody who was on the grounds, was running around, a homeless guy throwing lye, which is drain cleaner in the faces of nurses. And so it's horrible. It gets down, it deteriorates, it blinds you. It's worse than acid. Its job is to unclog drains. And at one point, he spilled it on himself and was brought into the emergency room that my dad was overseeing it.

3.180 And my dad, at the time—some of the physicians and other people were so angry. They're like, "Let him burn." And my dad was, like, "I'm a physician. This is my Hippocratic oath, right? We treat him no matter what it is." And so that was the opening of a story, right? I just had that piece. And then I thought, well, what if the doctor saves his life, and then the guy escapes and then he has to pursue him? And in order to pursue him, he has to come to understand and diagnose him? And the diagnostic process becomes the investigative process, right? There's all these ways to then turn that into a story.

3.181 But I was shadowing in the emergency room for two weeks in UCLA where it takes place. And what I didn't want to do—I did a lot of research, and this is very important if you're doing research. You don't want to ask the obvious questions that you can learn on the Internet. You're not there to ask things you know already. And so what you want to do is get their perspective. It's really good going out and having a meal or having drinks with somebody who's an expert. How do they talk? What's their slang? What's the way that they see things? And if you're going to ask subject matter specific expertise questions that is demanding of their expertise, it's good if you've done the homework already.

- 3.182** So you say to them instead, "Look, if you swallow some of the lye, some people say that you should use water to wash it down, but then that also can—like, there's a controversy about this in the medical community because it exposes more tissue as it dilutes it, and what's your take on that?" So you want to have research that people feel like you're respectful of their time, that you're not using them as Wikipedia. You've done your math, and that you're really interested in their perception and the way that they think and the manner in which they see the world. That's what you want to do for an interview.
- 3.183** And people are very open to talking about themselves, if you, in fact, are fascinated by their ethic and their perspective. They're very open to that. And you don't generally want to talk to—for instance, police stations will have a PIO, the public information officer. That's all your generic answers. "How do you do this?" "Well, we would never do that legally." You've got to get people out. Often, the experts who you most want to talk to—there's one friend of mine now who's, I think, the preeminent demolition breacher in the world. How do you get through a hole of a submarine? How do you get through an airplane if it's a hostage situation? But we had a long friendship before he would start to talk to me, to trust me enough to have the conversation.
- 3.184** So the big storytellers are often not the subject matter experts that you want. And then we basically got to a point that we were close enough that I'd say, "I need to design a charge. How am I going to build it?" And we had enough trust that he'd say, "Here, we'd lay out the whole thing." And then he'd say, "Let's go back and change two things. I don't want to make a guide in my book. I don't want to have a step-by-step process of how you build a bomb." So we could tweak things, or I could be vague about one section that is the one that has the most, call it proprietary function. And so that gets in a little bit to the question of ethics.
- 3.185** Right. And we're going to come back to the question of ethics. And we're going to stop there. And I remember there's this old kind of symbol, isn't there? For cutting there. Now, I can't help but think of the cricothyroid membrane that I'd be cutting in doing that. So thanks very much.

Lecture 4: Compelling Fiction

At a glance — What makes fiction compelling.

- 4.1 Yeah, the Punisher. One of those great comics that Gregg has been involved with. I got that very helpful son of mine to do this rendering of one of the images in the Punisher, set in a graveyard, of course. There's several panels. If I recall the comic, there's a whole page dedicated to—there are several panels dedicated purely— and there are no voice bubbles on that page, if I remember, dedicated purely to this graveyard scene.
- 4.2 And that figure in the middle of the door is the Punisher himself, carrying a shovel over his shoulder, where he's actually digging the graves for the person that he thinks he's just shot. In fact, perhaps he, but in fact, without giving it all away, did not shoot, but nevertheless could have shot. And so while we're talking about the dark side, I wanted to zero in on this question of death because it strikes me not only in The Punisher, but this is also true, surely, of a lot of your mainstream novels, Orphan X and so on.
- 4.3 Well, actually, to think of the book that's coming out just next month, The Last Orphan, and I'm giving nothing away here, the first chapter kills off a guy who might be a hero, but he has a very short part in that novel. In the movie, he's not getting paid very much. He pops up and then, oh, actually, you do connect up with him later. He reappears to some extent, actually, OK, but only as a body.
- 4.4 Do you have to, you or your hero or your books, do you need death? There's a line from Walter Benjamin, the great German philosopher and critic. This is from his essay, The Storyteller. "Death is the sanction of everything the story-teller can relate. It is death that has lent him his authority." Does that apply to you?
- 4.5 I was trying to think if there's anything I've written that nobody dies. And I don't believe it's the case. I think I kill somebody in every story that I've written, just about. For Orphan X, certainly, he's a vigilante, and he adheres to a code. And so if he's somebody who's going to kill people, then the threat has to be lethal to be returned in kind. And so at the beginning of all those, I mean, that's the precipitating fact.
- 4.6 So your savior figure requires a sacrifice.
- 4.7 Savior figure requires a sacrifice. There can be different types, but it's the clearest. This is a useful moment to describe the difference between mysteries and thrillers.
- 4.8 OK. Yeah. That's helpful.
- 4.9 So a mystery, the biggest event happens at the beginning, usually even before it begins. Somebody's murdered, right? And then there's the entry of a detective. In a thriller, the waiting of the big event is at the end or the crisis to be averted, right? Is the suitcase nuke going to go off in New York City? That's the bigger event. Thrillers are much more propulsive. Thrillers also seat the audience in the superior position. When we're reading Silence of the Lambs, or watching it, we go with Jame Gumb. We go with the

serial killer. Well, to some extent, we have glimpses of him. But meaning, yeah, no, we go with him when the woman's in the well, right? You see that.

- 4.10** In a mystery, you don't. Mystery keeps the reader in what's called the inferior position, where you're kind of behind the curtain, right? So the stakes are bigger in a thriller, quite often. And so I've taken some pains. You're talking about *The Last Orphan*, which deals with a lot of abstraction. Evan basically finds somebody who's a power player who runs manipulations under his own code in a more global fashion. And for Evan, everything has to be boiled down. He gives these grand explanations, and Evan says, "That's too abstract for me." It's like the conversation you and I have a lot, right? Where your entry point is the theoretical or the abstract, which is a necessity as a writer, for me personally, to embody or understand, but it's not the source of where things start.
- 4.11** And so Evan keeps saying, "It's one boy, it's one girl, that were killed. It's all I care about." And there's all these bigger power machinations, but it's too abstract, and he loses his way. "I'm not going to negotiate up there. That's not my world. If you were responsible for killing this one boy, you're going to answer to me."
- 4.12** It's fascinating that, effectively, without giving away the spoiler here, becomes effectively the argument or the drama or, to some extent, the mystery of *The Last Orphan* is that differentiation between, as it were, a global power struggle and specific individuals that you can relate to who have names.
- 4.13** It's the global versus the local to some extent. And Evan doesn't play in the global in a bigger ethic. It's about that. And so, yes, that is the sanction. If I write a vigilante killer—and same for Punisher. Interesting story. That frame that your son illustrated. And you said that he killed a little girl, but he finds out that he didn't. That's a really good example of something where I had the Punisher—originally, I wrote the arc that he kills someone. I thought, what would it be like if the Punisher accidentally kills somebody as collateral damage? And I have a scene where he's sitting with a gun in his mouth. And then she comes to him. And the editors, my editors at Marvel, said in a proprietary sense, "The Punisher can't kill somebody who's an innocent. It can't happen. That's in our golden-bound book of rules." So I had to go back and reconfigure and figure how to make it work.
- 4.14** So there's a tightrope act that I'm doing when I'm writing Batman. We talked about this a little bit yesterday, where I want to bring my own ethic, but to it. They're hiring me, so I want to bring my esthetic and do something that's new or do something that I'm playing with. But I have to honor the character because Batman has been around since before I was born. Batman is going to be around after I'm dead. It's like a public trust, and it's handed to me, and I want to bring my own ethic to it and create something. I can't remember if yesterday, if I told the story about Commissioner Gordon and Batman in the room.

- 4.15 No, I don't think so.
- 4.16 So this is another example of how letting readers or letting viewers in on the plot. We talked about pop cultural awareness. Somebody was asking about that. So, Commissioner Gordon, of course, Batman always talks to. And what happens? Batman always disappears from a scene, right? You turn around and he's gone. And so I have a scene where there's a problem in Gotham City, as is wont to occur. And it's late at night, and Batman's in the room with Commissioner Gordon, and he's not sitting down because he never sits down. And he's in the shadows, and Commissioner Gordon's in his room, and they start talk and they have this exchange.
- 4.17 And Commissioner Gordon goes and he looks out the window and he says, "Oh, so we have to do this, this, and this." And he pauses, he goes, "Oh, this is the part where I turn around and you're not there." So he states it. And then in the next panel, I have a word bubble come from out of frame that says, "Nope, still here." And they turn around and they have this awkward eye contact, and then they go, "All right, then very well." And then they exit on different sides of the panel.
- 4.18 And it was so funny because this was just my little inclusion of the audience, of the readership. And it's done with love. Yeah, and it's done very lovingly. It's not snide for me because I love that motif and continue to make use of the vanishing Batman. But it's funny because I think it's the most quoted panel of everything I did in Batman because the fans just loved it, because they felt like they were in on a joke where I'd invited them into it. There's different rules and ways of engaging in different things. I don't own Batman. I don't own Punisher. It's like the rich kid who lived up the street from you had all the best toys, and you go to his house and play in his sandbox with all that great stuff and then go home. You have to respect the rules of that game.
- 4.19 But I wonder if that's got into Evan Smoak or Orphan X, because that line that you just mentioned, like, "You can't kill any innocents," that your editor gave you when you were doing Punisher. That is now one of the Ten Commandments that Evan Smoak has, isn't it? So did you appropriate that and carry that across that, "I, Evan Smoak, am not allowed to kill any innocents"?
- 4.20 Yes. And also it's tough to have a protagonist who kills an innocent.
- 4.21 Yeah, sure.
- 4.22 Right? The whole book's got to be about that if that happens. But Batman, what fascinated me with Batman was the ways that the rogues' gallery fits, which we discussed. Each rogue is a different facet of Batman. But also, to me, Batman represented the tension between perfection and intimacy, which I think are at odds quite often. Batman, he can't fly. He doesn't have a magic ring. He doesn't run at the speed of light. He's just a human, but he represents the pinnacle of what human discipline can accomplish. He studied mysticism in Tibet. He's in impeccable shape. He's got money, he's got tech, but he's just a human.

- 4.23 But to maintain that, he's perennially alone. His parents are both killed. Robin's always dying. Then you get a new Robin, and then the new Robin dies. He can't be with anybody. He's got a playboy public persona. Because intimacy—humans are messy. In Batman, I had to adhere to the rules of that. I can't have Batman enter an intimate relationship. I played with that, of what that meant to him. But Orphan X, in a lot of ways, is moving from the archetypal but connecting to the real. It's a story of becoming a human in a lot of ways. And so there's different rules.
- 4.24 He's getting more domesticated, isn't he?
- 4.25 I don't think he's getting domesticated, but I think he's learning to engage more with the sloppiness, the opposite of his OCD in his clean state and his Ten Commandments, the messiness of human interaction. Humans are messy. Humans will screw up your schedule. Right? Humans have complications. Humans make you feel weird ways. So if he was just constrained in his world and not moving out of it, I would have written a superhero like Batman. But that's not interesting to me thematically for a novel.
- 4.26 No, it would have been a boring story. I know that, well, yeah. Do you want to read that? Because I wondered if Kill Clause—this is about Tim Rackley referring back, isn't it, to his childhood? Anyway, do you want to read that?
- 4.27 "Another stark glance at death's encroachment—slow this time, but equally unrelenting. It struck him that when he was little, he hadn't understood death. Or he'd understood it better. It had seduced him. He played war, he played cops and robbers, he played Cowboys and Indians, but he played no game in which death had not been a participant."
- 4.28 And so I wondered, and that does provide a bit of a genesis story for Tim Rackley. Is that kind of your genesis as well, to some extent? You've been playing those—as you said yesterday, you've been reading all these incredible adventure stories as a kid, and because your parents wouldn't let you watch TV, probably the smartest move they ever made. And you were playing these kinds of games, presumably. So was there a death consciousness that maybe you got that from your dad and being in that kind of medical environment?
- 4.29 I did have some of that. I mean, it's interesting because I think part of being a writer, an artist of any stripe, there's an aspect of being a writer, of being an outsider, right? Because you're navigating, you're narrating. It's like you have a narrative. If you're thinking in stories, you're shaping. And I think that there's a level of human observation. And look, it's true for other fields. I'm not saying it's like a magical writer thing. I think psychologists are often this way. But it's very observational, because a lot of times I'm thinking about the story that is occurring. I'm constantly thinking about how I would write something if it occurs or what are the words I'd use to describe something.

- 4.30 And so it's almost like a bit of a barrier from being an outsider or feeling in certain regards not understood in full or not seen fully, which is a feeling that a lot of people have. But it's a benefit, right? It's a benefit. There's an interesting thing. A lot of creative Hollywood parents have a more lax parenting style, let's just say. I think a lot of it is compensatory in some ways, because if you're an actor, a director, a writer, you feel like you're this creative spirit that's in a world that is less creative. And so we want to open that up in your kids.
- 4.31 But you don't realize that there's a gift to being not fully understood. If you have the benefit of love and structure and affection, of course, but there's a benefit in being an outsider if you're an artist, rather than having all of that opened up to you necessarily. At least there was for me. I can't speak for the other side. I'm sure everybody arrives at this differently. But I look back with a lot of gratitude on the fact that I was raised in a stable, structured environment, but part of me was always reading. I felt very comfortable in stories.
- 4.32 Right, right. So you felt somewhat detached from that environment. I know there's a theory, and Lee Child is the one who embodies it to the max, I think, that you have to be unloved as a kid. You have to have an unhappy childhood in order to become a decent writer, that you're compensating for that. You want to be loved by your readers, so you write the best book you can manage and so on. Do you think that's right? Do you have to have had an unhappy childhood? Yours doesn't sound spectacularly unhappy.
- 4.33 No, I don't. I mean, look, it sounds like that's the case for Lee, right? And that's his understanding of what—
- 4.34 Although he may have mythified that to some extent, to justify his own argument. I'm not sure about that.
- 4.35 Look, I mean, I think it's funny because all this craft advice, even that I'm giving, or an approach to all of this—what's amazing and wonderful and infuriating about being a writer is all of this might work for you or none of it might work for you. Everyone has a different process, right? So there's advice, and you want to borrow, you want to steal bits and pieces that align with your own approach to the page. One of my very close friends, Robert Crais, he's a wonderful novelist. He's a meticulous outliner, but his work never feels like it's rote or he's filling in blanks. It's his processes that he arrives at in that way.
- 4.36 And there's other people who have zero version of an outline. And so you want to find the thing that works with you. You're aligning your kind of experience and outlet. And so there's a lot of variations. It's not like, there's not as many firm rules. It's not like being an accountant, where there's certain set parameters that are around us. Yeah, I think a lot about Kurt Vonnegut. He's so amazing. And when I read him, I just kind of marvel because you're just taking in what he does, but it doesn't seem to adhere to any

rules. There's nobody who writes like Kurt Vonnegut. It doesn't make any sense to me. It's such a pure expression of an ethic of a writer, for instance. But he's the only one who could do it. You never really know how he could do it. I don't know if it could be imitated, almost.

4.37 Yeah. He had that very specific experience. I think, was he a chemistry engineer or something? And then he got bombed in Dresden, wasn't it? That fed into Slaughterhouse-Five? But yeah, it doesn't follow that you need to have been bombed in Dresden.

4.38 But also the structure, the wandering aspects of how he constructs something. There's lots of rules, right? But everyone should be striving towards the fulfillment of their own voice and perspective because that's the unique thing. And voice gets elevated a lot, kind of preciously. Like, your voice is anything that you think, right? Your voice is you. Your voice is this identity. And so people can use it shieldingly or defensively. "I'm not understood. I won't take criticism. This is the pure aspect of me." It's very hard to differentiate that from ego or stubbornness or laziness or self-deception, right?

4.39 But burrowing through, which is a process, right? And I'm still undergoing it. There's not a point where all of a sudden you've got it. I've published 24 books. I don't feel like, "Oh, I've got this writing thing now. It's clear." But it's a process of trying to approach every sentence, every paragraph, every scene, every project, every book, from something that is from the source of yourself and the way that you exist and live in the world that only you can tell. So that's the thing that you're trying to uncover, right? That's the sculpture in the stone that Michelangelo says that he saw, but it's within yourself as a writer.

4.40 And you're trying to open up those parts of yourself. That's how you live in the world differently. And then you imbue all your characters through that sort of awareness and filter. So it's interesting because every character has to function on their own. We talked about with Rosencrantz and Guildenstern and building each story around each character, as if the whole world revolves around them. But you're also trying to access them from a part of yourself that is open and alive in the world that makes you different from anybody else who could write it. That's a life's work.

4.41 You've given us some of the rules of the game, the way you operate. I always remember that advice that Michelangelo gave to possibly would-be sculptors who were asking, well, "How do I sculpt an elephant?" And his advice was, "Well, you take a block of stone and remove from it everything that does not resemble an elephant." And that's really good advice, but it doesn't get you very far. I wonder if, we have all these courses now, don't we, on how to write and so on. You probably participate in one or two of them. And writing scores, creative writing degrees, of course, and creative writing PhDs and so on, which fundamentally are about craft or rules of the game. Do they fulfill a useful purpose to your way of thinking?

- 4.42 Well, I never took a writing course or—I mean, I read Stephen King's *On Writing*. I read David Morrell's *On Writing* because I know David in his work, and he founded International Thriller Writers. And so if I know somebody or have engagement—but what I like about, personally, of the format of this discussion is that I find it more useful. I'm trying to give what I found the most, what I would find the most useful, which in a lot of ways is like the ethic and the discipline and the approach to think about, that every writer should take and differentiate him or herself with.
- 4.43 So it's not necessarily saying, here's the rules of the game. We need some of that. We could spend time on saying, here's first person, second person, third person, free and direct discourse versus perspective. There's stuff we could do. We could do a structure seminar. It would be in some ways the most logical version of what can be taught. But I feel like it's helpful to talk about a writer's sensibility and an approach to story because, if there's one or two pieces that people take from everybody—and so I think in some ways, that's the most useful version for me, is when I hear things.
- 4.44 And I got a great piece of advice from James Patterson. I did an event early in my career. He'd flown across the country to L.A., and I said, "Oh, did you write on the plane?" And he looked at me and said, "Always, of course." He said, "Don't you write on planes?" I was on, I think, my second book. I said, "No, I have to be at my desk and I need my American Heritage third edition, and I need this, and I need that, and it's got to be quiet." He looked at me and he just said, "Learn." And it was so great because it was like, and then cut to X years later, right? I want to go to my kid's field trip and my wife's driving and I'm on deadline. I'm in the passenger seat, and we have a car full of squealing kids. And I'm, like, I'm trying to focus. I'm trying to finish something, right? I write on airplanes all the time. I write in the car on the way to different places. It was a piece of him saying, "Don't be precious. Build the muscle stronger" is a version of what that advice was.
- 4.45 He's fairly successful, James Patterson. He's done OK for himself. And so, it's like, OK, so that's a little piece about—and that was more about setting a higher bar for myself around my self-control or relinquishing an aspect that I was protecting myself from in some ways. And it's tied a little bit to ego, I think, too, because I'm like, I have all these conditions, I have all these parameters. I wasn't constructing them to say, "I'm important and an artist." But you get these pokes at different times. And some people have to listen to music, and some people can't do this, and some people can't do that. So you want to just borrow. But I think it's much more about how to approach the art of writing, how to approach the art of story.
- 4.46 Yeah, I mean, I think there is a tendency to get a bit precious. I remember in bygone days, I was at the Cullman Center in New York, and we got assigned these offices, and one bunch of offices was on the 42nd Street side, where anyway, you had natural light coming in. And there was another bunch of offices on the inside of the New York Public Library. Anyway, and I got assigned one of the offices on the street side. So I had

natural light coming in. And then I had this other writer, woman writer, coming up to me and saying, "Oh, Andy, do you think we could swap? Because I can only write when there's natural light coming through the window."

4.47 And so, of course, I'm adopting the anything goes approach. And, yeah, I can write anywhere. Said, "Sure. OK, swap. No problem." But she did get the better office. And subsequently, she stopped turning up, I remember. And I saw her at a party much later. And I said, "So you got the best office, and then you stopped coming. But what about that natural light thing?" She said, "Yeah, but I discovered that in the end, I could only really write properly when I was sitting on my bed in a particular room and the light was coming from the other direction." So it was coming from the—so you can narrow yourself down.

4.48 Careful what rules you set for yourself.

4.49 I hope she's still writing, but it was getting narrow and narrow, the place where she can actually write. But look, the funny thing when you said, OK, we could talk about first person and third person and do second person and so on. And omniscience and indirect free speech. I wanted to ask you those questions, but I also felt that I should not monopolize Gregg, and I should not be throwing him all of those questions, although I really want to know the answers to them. And I thought I should open it up a little bit more and ask you if you have questions, too, because I'm sure many of you want to know more about specific things yourselves. And so this is your shot, people. Question here, and mic.

4.50 Thank you. So a unique question for you, not to try to get political, I'll keep it very straight, is because you're a fiction writer, and then you talked about going through this mind control cult, I wonder if you have a unique lens, being in the real world, seeing media or politicians or the public, like, saying things in a certain way, and because you know the techniques when fiction writing to invoke emotion, if you see that? And the second part to that is if you have some ways to differentiate and realize when that's happening, so you can protect yourself from that?

4.51 That's a really good question. Yes, I've spent an enormous amount of time working pro bono in politics and culture, engaging away from extremism and fighting against polarization and doing a lot of work across the aisle and trying to wrangle both sides back. I actually, I just published a original comic book anthology called New Think, where I put a lot of my ideas strained through different genre in that, and different stories that are about trying to give people the skills through hard-genre stories to distinguish when those things are happening.

4.52 And part of that came in about 2015. I was looking at the cultural temperature of the country, and I started to recognize a lot of different mind control techniques that were being in play. And a lot of the use of persuasion—everything was popping to me and becoming very, very clear. And so I felt a responsibility or a calling to try to get

involved, to translate between sides, to interpret, to mediate in some extent, but also to start to call out and to try to unravel some of the things that were happening.

- 4.53** A good example about mind control cults—one of the first things that they do is they limit your access to outside information. You're out of cell phone range, you can't call your old family and friends, usually till a week in, when they have you call them to disown them because they never really understood you, right? But they control your access to outside information. So people are like, well, aren't the Marines a cult? Isn't the Catholic Church a cult? No, those aren't cults. There's not only a vertical power structure. You have access to other information. You're aware of what's happening to you. If you go into boot camp, they're telling you, "We're going to break you down to some extent to rebuild you." You're aware of the process that's happening.
- 4.54** Mind control is when it happens without your consent. Well, what's happening right now in the media landscape, what's happening on social media with everybody that we unfriend, with algorithms that are powered our way, right, by companies that literally hire teams of addiction specialists using deep machine learning to target exactly you and your information stream by what will most outrage you, in order to get the highest dopamine hits to keep you glued to that channel or that program or that news source—it's a game. It's a hard and fast mind control game that's being played. And it's also limiting access to outside information.
- 4.55** And so all of a sudden it's like, "Who's your expert? Who's my expert?" This is on both sides. This is not something I'm aiming in one direction. What's your news source? Do you watch this channel? Do you watch that channel? If you watch this channel, they say all your experts are wrong. If you do this channel, all these experts are wrong. And there's a way that we've self-centered and given up a lot of our freedom and ability to differentiate. I feel like luxury can be the death of us in some ways. There's so much we can do with the phone.
- 4.56** But I talked about privacy deprivation at a mind control cult, right? Everywhere you go, you go to the bathroom, someone walks you to the bathroom. They don't want you to have too much time alone. Well, our phones go with us everywhere, right? And they're a portal into people who are designed—like, your phone is a terrorist that's trying to make money off you. That's what your phone is. There's a lot of tools that are amazing with it. There's a lot of things that it does. But if we open up all these doors within it, we're being manipulated and shaped constantly. And it's something that I see very clearly as a result of that and have spent a lot of time engaging with. The means of engagement that's the most effective, in the lines of—you quoted *Game of Thrones* at the beginning, right? "Nothing can beat a good story." There's a lot of bad stories right now. A lot.
- 4.57** We have to find our way to a better story about our engagement, our health, the unity. What are the foundational values of the community at large? What are ways that we can pivot away from destructive, polarizing behavior and dehumanization to getting

things done effectively? And to talk about that in language, so this is another place that it's an overlap. You don't want to use clichés in writing. You don't want to say, "And then everything went black." We were talking about that. "He fell like a tree." Same thing happens with politics and culture. How many phrases do we use that take on a sudden, freighted meaning? Whether it's somebody's "mansplaining," if somebody talks about "family values." We have all these words that become captured shorthand for litmus tests from different sides.

- 4.58** And all of a sudden we're using language in a way that's signaling a tribal allegiance. And the breakthrough of a novel for the point of connection or a movie is something that's written often from first-hand experience that expresses an idea, whether you're being strangled or cutting someone's throat in a way that's new and surprising, in a way that makes you think, in a way that has a genuine respect for that character, no straw men, right? No straw, no characters that exist only to kick around. And so it's a very similar thing. We're craving a kind of authenticity in our public discourse that we're not finding as much as we'd like to.
- 4.59** It's not like we're watching a news show, and they say, "Well, do you think the President's speech today was good or bad?" And you know who's from what party and you know precisely what they're going to say. It's very rare that somebody offers something that's startlingly insightful and makes you view the world in a different way. So yeah, there's a lot of overlap. That's a sharp question.
- 4.60** Another question here.
- 4.61** Thanks. I'm curious. You spoke earlier about setting up the story. How much of the story, when you start writing, do you know the ending? Do you view your writing as more of a process of discovery, or how much set-up are you actually doing? You spoke about having an outline, a basic outline, but how much is actually mapped out? And then I was curious, speaking of the distractions, what does a day of writing look like for you? How do you keep out some of those distractions?
- 4.62** OK, good questions. I'll take them one at a time. So the first you're asking about, so the distraction one. Let me lead with the distraction one. So keeping in mind that your phone is a terrorist that's trying to make money off you, the best day for me is if I get up, and my phone is turned off, and I take it and my office phone and I leave it downstairs where my now-assistant answers it. But I used to do this before I had an assistant. I'd throw them out in the hallway and they're gone. I have to have Internet. I took all of my—I'm not on social media. I try and only engage in social media through my publicist and intermediaries. I like to write and engage with viewers and readers. So since I'm a writer, everything that I put out in that way from a marketing perspective, let's say, I have written, and I get key feedback that will come back to me.
- 4.63** But I can't engage in that. It's like slicing my brain into pieces. And when I go on book tour—I talked about this transition from writing in a cave to writing, all of a sudden, I'm

out and I'm on a book tour and I'm talking to lots of people—I literally have to reprogram my brain when I get back from a book tour or even an event like this where we're talking. I'm out here. So the ritual and the conditions are essential. If I write first thing before too many other things happen, that's really important to me. If I go down, if I read the news, if I do other stuff, my head tends to be a bit jumbled.

4.64 I remember I had a conversation with the great Dennis Lehane, who wrote *Mystic River* and *Shutter Island*, and he was quoting the Wordsworth, *The World Is Too Much With Us*, the poem. I don't want too much of the world with me when I go in. I don't want logistics. That's the wrong corner of my brain. So a lot of it is protecting the space that I'm in when I'm writing the story. I used to think of it as, like, I got to get the story out. And it's like, no, I have to protect my state of mind during certain amounts of time in a day as I engage with the story. That's almost the primary.

4.65 And so I took all my tabs and email and everything. I put them all in one file so that when I open Google, it's literally Google. And I took off the news sources even on Google so that I'm just searching. I find I have to put limitations around all those things. And ideally, I write—I don't have the same, I don't want to say luxury, but I have a lot of deadlines and schedules. And so if I can carve the first 4 hours of my day to purely write, everything's great. Ideally, I'd go back and write the next 4 hours of the day, also. But I carve that time out and I make it something that's sacred. And when I don't, I regret it.

4.66 I think Chandler has that thing about you've got to sit at the desk for several hours, even if you're not writing.

4.67 It's a way of life. Harlan Coben had a wonderful line where he said, "Look, I get up every day and I write." He said, "Plumbers don't wake up and say, 'I don't feel like plumbing today.'" It's a job. If you have the benefit to do it, show it the respect and show it the dignity of having the full application of your focus and your discipline as best as you can manage. If you treat it like a hobby, it'll turn into a hobby.

4.68 Was it Graham Greene who had that funny line when someone said to him, "What gets you started in the day then, Mr. Greene?" And he said, "Well, I like to start the day by reading the obituary column in the Times. And if my name isn't there, then I go on."

4.69 So two pieces of advice, just two little craft tips that might work or help. I like to stop. If I finish a chapter, I like to write a couple sentences of the next chapter to have a bit of a running start for the next time that I write, or I like to break into whatever the next scene will be, even slightly. There was a time when, even if I finished a novel, I would start the next. I'd crack the first sentence of the next novel even or go to the screenplay. I mean, now there's enough different forms, I move between them. So that's one thing.

4.70 The other thing that I do to get a momentum up is I start the day by reading what I've written the day before, or the session before, so that I'm putting myself back in mind

and I edit through as I go also. Now, you asked this first question. I used the metaphor yesterday of the rock climbing wall, right? Of knowing that there's big, chunky pieces? I usually know and have a pretty clear sense of what's going to happen. And I have placeholders for scenes that then, in that rolling outline, they flesh out. There's more opportunities that have happened. There's more things that are going to change. "Oh, I was going to set it in a warehouse, but this location that came up is perfect." It's more married to the plot. It's more stitched into it.

4.71 When I talked about choosing ALS as the symptom because he's a vet, you're always looking to knit together the world of the story itself. You want things to be of the story. And so there's ways that you'll discover that, as you're writing through something. And I'm always open to an ending changing. And in fact, one of my key characters in Orphan X, there's a young female hacker, 16-year-old hacker named Joey Morales, Josephine Morales. And she was supposed to die at the end of Hellbent. That's the third Orphan X installation. She's introduced. There's a scene at the end. If you read Hellbent, you'll know and see right where she's supposed to die. And I couldn't do it. I got there. I'd fallen in love with her.

4.72 Yeah, she's a great character.

4.73 Well, thank you. Her engagement with Evan illuminated so many aspects of his personality. It was so much fun, her interplay with Orphan X. Then I got to that scene and I was staring at the computer and I just thought, "I can't do this." And she's become a principal, if not the principal, supporting character in the series now. So you want to have a plan, but don't fall in love with plan A.

4.74 Actually, there's a quote there from Joey because I was so struck by her and she's this techy genius. Because Evan Smoak is pretty good, but Joey is streaks ahead of him. Do you want to read that? Because she's got this whole discourse, which is so brilliant.

4.75 "She tore off her sweater impatiently and hiked her sleeves over her deltoids. 'We're going to get a split payload in through this broad's email. We log in as her, put the bad payload in a PDF doc attachment, send it to herself, then modify it so it's, like, hidden inside the icon for a JPEG file. Next time she logs in on the secure network, my tiny little split election engine uses that hidden code and actively modifies private Windows update server with a series of corrupted patches. Then we use, like, a hidden reverse SSH backdoor for you to get in at will and see whatever data you need.'" And Evan says, "I understood the sit-on-my-ass-and-drink-vodka part." There's a missing first part to the joke where she says—

4.76 Yeah, she slips that in.

4.77 At the start. So she's making fun of Evan. So in the beginning, in Orphan X and The Nowhere Man, before I had Joey, who's a genius hacker, Evan's doing the hacking. And I have the scenes. He's a competent hacker. But part of this is, I didn't want him to be the magical MacGyver figure. And so I've introduced Joey, who's constantly

admonishing him for how, you know, he can't—"I bet, Grandpa, you can't program the time on your VCR." She's constantly making fun of him for his lack of hacking. And what's been helpful with that device for me is, A, it's fun. So it's fun to have him—he's like Ulysses. He's the man of many wiles, where he brings the totality of himself with all these different experts. We talked about this a little bit yesterday.

- 4.78 But additionally, it helps with the reader in that when Evan does do something hacking that, let's say, is a little bit magical, if I need to have something, I need to dust off some point of entry that he makes, because Joey has gone on and on and on at how incompetent he is, we sort of forgive the fact that he's a really good hacker in addition to a really good fighter. He's really good at all these things. But since there's other characters who are better, who make fun of him, when he does those things, I feel like the readers are in a better position to embrace them with totality because I haven't said, "He's a magical mixed martial arts master," isn't how I describe him. In the training scenes, I show him mostly getting his ass kicked as a kid by other people who are better at fighting than he is.
- 4.79 So that when he does stomp somebody's foot and describe it in exquisite anatomical detail, right, we're with him because I haven't held him up that he can magically do everything all the time. So when there's these flashes of it, in some ways, I've almost prepped the reader to engage with that like it's real and to have access to him as a real character.
- 4.80 So that is part of your realism, your mimesis, in fact. Yes. So another question over here.
- 4.81 So this would be more like a technical writing question. So when it comes to when you write technical terms, like you were talking for the laryngoscope. So is it better to first just mention the term, not do any exposition on it, and then just include a footnote at the bottom or in a glossary at the end, or to put it discreetly, like you mentioned, in the text itself? Like, what is it better for the reader to continue on the story?
- 4.82 So you always, in my estimation, I'm going to now give you an always rule after saying that anyone can do anything that they want. But in my estimation, it's immensely preferable to do it discreetly, because what a footnote does is it reminds you that you're reading. And when I'm reading a book, I don't want to be reminded that I'm reading. I don't want to be reminded that I need a footnote or I need glossary. This is my opinion on fiction. And so the more ways that you can have the reader lost in the world of the story, where they're forgetting that they're even reading, and every time you can have a little question and then it gets answered, and a little question, then it can be answered.
- 4.83 There's good kinds of mystery, and there's bad kinds of mystery, likewise with suspense. If something is a mystery, and you're confused and irritated as the reader, that's not good. But if something has you leaning in to go, "Wait, what's this term?"

What's the—oh, there it is. And, oh, I'm picking up and I'm keeping pace," you're leaning forward into the story and you continue to engage with it. So you're being pulled along by it. And that's generally what you want.

4.84 One over here.

4.85 Just curious as to how your background in psychology has influenced your writing.

4.86 Well, psychology to me was so fascinating. I studied English and psychology to some extent. It's not necessarily that it was the best combination to be a novelist, but it was the two things I love the most. And psychology was such an entry point for me. I talk about how Freud's case studies are like short stories. And then Carl Jung, who I also focused on, never wrote about anything that's not narrative. Everything he wrote about was narrative, as we discussed. And for me, that portal into understanding, I love abnormal psych. I loved seeing seeing the different ways that character nuance can come up. And so I had a lot of interest in that.

4.87 And the mind control techniques that I'm talking about, a lot of that is social psychology. And I was fascinated by the experiments. I especially liked the experiments before there were ethics boards Because there was outrageous experiments in the ways that people were mediating and studying human behavior and what humans do under pressure and what makes them act certain ways. And so I think it's helped me in understanding people better, to be able to flesh motivations.

4.88 I mean, there's a key—one of the key studies is Milgram's experiment, which I'm sure many of our viewers are familiar with, but where they had somebody shocking another person across when they got the answer wrong about something. And the person was a plant, but the subject didn't know that, so they weren't really being shocked. And they did this experiment where the person was given direction, to say, "Oh, they got the answer wrong. Can you shock them?"

4.89 And the shocks went all the way up until they reached a critical zone. And the people would be, like, sweating and begging for them to stop. And the subjects were quite agitated, and they didn't want to do it, but they would continue to shock the person, even if they said, "Please, please, I have a heart condition," if they were under stern—and there was all these factors that made it different. Is the doctor, the fake doctor, tall? Is he wearing a lab coat?

4.90 Yeah, the white coat was crucial.

4.91 The white coat. So what are all these factors that could make somebody do something that they're clearly agitated to do? So what's great about that is it keeps us out of the frame of black-and-white thinking and black-and-white characterization. And one of my favorite modern films is Michael Clayton. And Tilda Swinton plays a character in that who orders, basically, a hit, an assassination. She's a corporate person, and she's undone by it as it's happening. She's like, "Wait, what does that mean? Did we just do

that?" She's on the phone negotiating, and she's so clearly agitated. It's incredibly compelling, right, to have that be something that's occurring with a character.

- 4.92** And so when we're talking about, for me, my first book was a serial killer novel, and it was a little bit—I was playful with the genre, but serial killer narratives don't interest me particularly because it's like, well, what's their motivation? Well, they're crazy, right? They're bad, let's say. And no matter which way you cut it, that's where you're going to arrive at. Having characters who are nuanced, having a character who does something bad and then has some agitation in relation to it, like somebody from Milgram's experiment, or somebody who's using those techniques very sadistically from a considered cold engineering-brain place, there's all these ways that you can specify and humanize it within the characters that give it a different, that throw a different pall around a character, that lets you access them in a lot of ways more humanly.
- 4.93** Can I ask Gregg a question about what is kind of a serial killer story, except that it's a nonhuman serial killer, which is *Jaws*, the great Peter Benchley novel made into the movie, of course. You have a particular connection with that, don't you? Because didn't you read that very young as a kid?
- 4.94** I read that very young. It's the wonderful cover of the book.
- 4.95** With the shark.
- 4.96** The great phallic shark rising from the depths.
- 4.97** The little swimmer.
- 4.98** And the woman at the top. It's such a beautiful cover. So that was on the top shelf of my parents' bookcase. I scaled it. I climbed up there and got it down.
- 4.99** They didn't want you to read it.
- 4.100** It wasn't low-hanging fruit, let's just say. And so I read it. I was completely enamored. And then I went and read all the rest of Peter Benchley's novels. I read *The Island*, *The Deep*, *The Girl of the Sea of Cortez*. And I wrote him a letter when I was in fifth grade, and he wrote me back. And I said, "I love *The Island*, *The Deep*, *Jaws*, *Jaws 2*, all these things." He wrote back. He said, "Thank you so much. However, as I didn't write *Jaws 2*, I can't take credit for it." It was a novelization of the film written by Hank Searls, I think. But we had a bit of a written—I wrote him again in high school, and I wrote him again when I was in college.
- 4.101** It's great that he wrote back to you.
- 4.102** He did write back. What was really funny is then I published my first book. I was so excited and I said, "Here's our correspondence and here, here, here. My first book is coming out, and will you blurb it for me?" And he said, "No, I don't blurb," which was so funny. But he said, "I wish you well. I hope you have a—" and initially, his advice was

really interesting. He said, "It's a pretty lousy life. And if you can do anything else, you should. But if you have to do this, I wish you well." That was his advice to me.

4.103 That's good advice.

4.104 Kind of. I mean, it's like, yeah, if you can go sell commercial real estate or if there's something else that you love that's lucrative and has a clearer path and will make you happy and will engage you, why not? Because it's not an easy path. So he's very honest.

4.105 Was part of his disillusionment to do with what I think we all know now as a fact that he subsequently fell in love with sharks, so to speak, and felt that sharks had been, to some extent, demonized and vilified, largely by him, of course, and he wanted to backpedal to some extent? Was that part of it?

4.106 I'm not sure.

4.107 Did you ever say to you, "God, I'm so sorry I wrote that damn book, *Jaws*." He didn't actually say that?

4.108 No, but I did—I remember I emailed him once about, back when email happened later on in our correspondence, because I read a book about this series of shark attacks that was historical around, I think, Cape Cod, that he loosely based, or might have been Nantucket, *Jaws* on. And he said, "Why did you think this would be of interest to me?" Not rudely. That sounds ruder. I mean, he was very direct. And it was like, oh, he wasn't —

4.109 He didn't want to revisit.

4.110 Yeah, he didn't want to be a one-trick pony. And he wrote other books that were— but so, let's talk about *Jaws* for a minute, right? So *Jaws* is one of the things that he did quite well as he wrote. He did write from the perspective of the shark, but he didn't make him like a magical—he was trying to write from within the biology of the shark, right? And not make it too crazy. And so that's another thing. We talked about writing dogs for characters, right? You don't want to have Lassie who's barking in code that Timmy fell down the well, and so even if you're engaging with other species, even if you're engaging from their perspective—Robert Crais wrote a book.

4.111 With a dog?

4.112 Yeah, that's quite wonderful. And T. Jefferson Parker just wrote one that came out. And the key is to write from them, from a sort of sensory perspective. You have to embody them. We have no idea how sharks think. But if it's "the killer shark was hungry for more blood," that's not a compelling scene, right? It's too cute. It's too clever. But if you're writing about it being like a sheer predatory machine that's designed by nature, and here's the way that it perceives, and it's this unthinking force that got this taste for easy pickings right off the island, it becomes more real.

- 4.113 Yeah. So you have to see the shark's point of view. I think that's really good advice. Any more questions?
- 4.114 We have a question here.
- 4.115 I've been socializing, and a lot of us here actually work for marketing and advertising companies. Some of us are writers. I'm an art director. And so I just wanted to ask you a question around that. Were you ever tempted to get into advertising? And could you talk a little bit about the difference between writing for an ad and writing a screenplay or a book?
- 4.116 That's a good question. My first paid job was an advertising firm. I was so excited. I still remember it was like—I mean, I should say my first paid writing job, but I was so excited. I remember I got \$20 an hour and it felt like \$11 billion. Every 15 minutes, I was like, "I just made 5 bucks." Every half hour, I'm like, "I can buy lunch today." It was so exciting. And just to be paid to write, it was very exciting. I love advertising. I'm fascinated by it and the language of persuasion. There's a huge overlap with psychology and sales and selling techniques. And there's a huge ethic to it as well. There's different things that, like, you can use the language of persuasion to an extent that's almost too far.
- 4.117 But it fascinates me, in advertising, there's a bunch of different ways that you can view the world through as much as psychology, in a certain extent. Like Coca-Cola and Pepsi, that's one great division in advertising and marketing. Coke is the thing itself. It's America. It's Norman Rockwell. It's Santa Claus. It's baseball. There's only one recipe for Coke, and only 5 people in the world know it, and they never fly in the same airplane because if that airplane crashes. So what happens if you change the recipe for Coke, if it's sold that way? People lose their mind. When they moved to new Coke, people were undone by it.
- 4.118 Well, Pepsi is the other great template of model for that. Pepsi is the Pepsi generation. It's you. Do you want to be, like, at a Britney Spears concert? Are you Michael Jackson? You're the generation. It's all about you. Pepsi can change its recipe 20 times a year. No one cares. I think of it in some ways that it mirrors the distinction between football and baseball, in that when there's a steroid allegation in baseball, it's a huge deal because baseball is America and it's apple pie and we don't want cheating. And a lot of times in football, we're seeing like giant gladiators clash. And so if steroids are used in football, it's less upsetting to us in our sense of identity that we've imbued around it.
- 4.119 So the rules of the game around a brand are not dissimilar to the way that you are writing and setting a narrative contract. What's the narrative contract with a company? So when you're advising and you're thinking about that, what's the tone? What's the mood? What are you setting? And if you advertise a company a certain way, then they're going to have certain constraints. There's advantages and there's disadvantages.

- 4.120 Another wonderful example from advertising is the first example of positional advertising was Avis, car rentals. So we had Hertz forever. Everybody knows Hertz. Hertz is number one in the world. And Avis had a wonderful positional advertising slogan. They said, "We're second. We try harder." Amazing campaign, right? Because they don't want to just market themselves as Coke again, but by positioning themselves where they are, right, and then having a trade, like, who doesn't want to work for a company that's working harder to please you, right? So it's taking something that seems like it's a deficit, but it's expressing it through a means that makes them more palatable.
- 4.121 And so the process of advertising, the process of talking to—I've worked with candidates, I've worked with political parties, I've worked around movements of how do we talk about infrastructure even, let's say? How do we talk about January 6? How do you talk in an election campaign? How do you talk for a company? And the process of trying to discover what the source of that is in an unvarnished way and then conveying it from a way that people have some emotional reaction to it is not dissimilar to the process of uncovering a character that we talked about through psychology, to the question that you asked, of using psychology to apply to it.
- 4.122 And then there's a great number of psychological techniques that you can use in ways that things sell, the order of persuasion. One of the things, you need a cue for people to respond to. One of the things when toothpaste was starting to explode, they're putting people in mind of, like, "Don't you hate that slimy feeling on your teeth?" They were inventing a cue that people have internally all the time to then require a product more, even though it's also good for your health. And so there's ways that you can cue and move. And there's also a lot of responsibility and ethic.
- 4.123 And I found that, particularly, there's a question asked to me earlier about politics and about this cultural moment. And engaging in politics and engaging on behalf of certain parties or candidates or movements is a big responsibility because now we've crossed the line and I'm writing propaganda. So what are the steps that I'm going to take to kind of hem that in? And one of the things that I found that was fascinating to me, and I think this is true—well, I'd like to think it's true for companies— but if you can get the branding right, if you can get the story right, the strategic often aligns with the moral in a very interesting way. In politics, it's too big of a detour to get into right now.
- 4.124 But for Avis, for instance, if that's your logo and that's what you think, what you need to do then is make sure that that aligns with the ethos and the ethic of the company. And then, if in fact they are working harder to service a client better, and that becomes a prevailing value because you got the story right with where they're positioned, and they perform that way better, then you're selling something that's fair and that brings greater benefit also to the customers. And so there's a way of trying to align strategic and tactical and moral—tactical, strategic, and moral, let's say— and a story has a unifying ability to do all of that.

- 4.125 And stories are applied everywhere. And I see all the time, it's easier slim pickings, right —like, it's easier to say, well, "Hertz is awful," or "We did testing, and 4 times out of 10, people said Hertz cars smelled like cigarette smoke," oppo research, right? There's a bunch of ways to get at it more in different ways that are also effective. But you're choosing your lane and you're choosing the ethic with which you want to proceed to build a brand.
- 4.126 Peter Brooks has this great phrase about, maybe we can come back to it tomorrow, the "storification of reality." But I know you had a question in the front, didn't you? I know we're running short on time. I wanted you to be able to ask your question.
- 4.127 My question has to do with the global and local ethics and how writers can balance that and still stay true to pop culture and and have a good awareness, even though pop culture seems to be fluctuating all the time.
- 4.128 That's such a good question. I think, are we discussing this more at length tomorrow with sensitivity readers?
- 4.129 That does seem to be relevant, doesn't it?
- 4.130 Yes. Is that on the agenda?
- 4.131 That is on the agenda, sensitivity readers in particular.
- 4.132 It's a really good question, and it's a really good topic. And as a writer, the story has to be primary. I talked about that as being primary to even me and what I think. And what's really hard is a lot of times if people are writing, you don't want to write into a way that is also reactive against what's prevalent in the culture, right? Because then you're just as possessed by it in a way, right? So you can go all in ideologically on something, right? Or you can be reactive that you're not going to go in on that ideologically. And either way, you're reacting to that. And that's something that's external.
- 4.133 So if the story itself is real, you might have a sense within yourself. And when you're writing, it's important to do this. Are you ever getting a ping within yourself where you're like, "Oh, I need to soften this in case I get blowback"? It's a really weird relationship, writing to an imagined audience, and you don't know what that audience is or who they're going to be. And you can turn them into everything or into nothing. And so you want to write in a way that's considerate of them to bring them along. When we describe a laryngoscope as an L-shaped tool that slaps in the palm, you want to bring them with you. You don't want to lecture and you don't want to preach, and you don't want to have everything figured out that you think and have a preconceived notion.
- 4.134 And you see this a lot. I did an interview early in my career with The Advocate. That's a gay magazine, because as a straight writer, writing gay characters, I have occasional characters who are gay, but I didn't write them. There's a tendency for straight writers

to write them all as saints. Like, "Oh, and this one opened an orphanage and it's just beyond—" It's like, no one wants to read that either. It's real characters. Or people talk about, "Well, we got to write strong women." And it's like, "Why don't you write complex women?" No one says, "How is it writing Evan Smoak as a strong male character?" That's not the ethic.

- 4.135** And so if you feel like you're floating up into the abstract or the ethical or the moral, rather than how you're working them out in the story, then you know that you're engaged at the wrong level. And if you're reacting to potential blowback in some situation from one side or another, or getting reactive that you're going to make your point, that you're not captured like those other people, or you're morally superior in something that you're going to put forth, it's usually the wrong level that you're hitting at. Should we cover the issue of sensitivity readers or should we save that for tomorrow?
- 4.136** We're going to do it tomorrow, I think, actually.
- 4.137** So we'll explore that further tomorrow as well.
- 4.138** OK, great. We'll come back to that for sure. And so we've covered myth. We've covered mimesis. Tomorrow, momentum. Without momentum in the story or the momentum of the reader, none of that would make any difference. So that is perhaps the most important thing of all. Thank you, everyone. Thank you.

Lecture 5: Suspenseful Writing

At a glance — Suspenseful writing.

- 5.1 True story. I was on a train, subway train, well, on the London Underground, not very long ago, and I was supposed to get off— alight, as they say—at Highbury and Islington, on the Victoria line. But I was reading a book by Gregg Hurwitz at the time. And the next time I looked up, I'd gone way past Highbury and Islington. I was somewhere in Finsbury Park. So I had to alight there, turn around, go back in the other direction.
- 5.2 So I really want to ask the question, how does that happen, that a book makes you miss your subway station? And the simple answer to that is momentum. The train had momentum, the book had more momentum, and we're going to be talking about momentum today. We've covered myth, we've covered mimesis, but without momentum, none of those things, none of those things amount to anything. And momentum is a slightly elusive, almost kind of mystical quality. Gregg Hurwitz is going to help us to pin it down.
- 5.3 I wonder if momentum is the key difference, perhaps, between the literary and the commercial. And I think in particular of Marcel Proust. I used to have a volume of his great *In Search of Lost Time* on my bedside table, and I found that if I couldn't sleep at night, I would pick up the volume and soon I would be drifting off. I would not have a Gregg Hurwitz on my bedside table. I'd never get to sleep.
- 5.4 So I want to begin, by the way, by focusing, however, on a devastating review of Gregg Hurwitz's writing, just so that we cannot be accused of hagiography. And here it is, and it's a very negative review by a very kind of mean, miserable writer called Gregg Hurwitz. And here he is. Well, specifically, Andrew Danner's cop friend in *The Crime Writer*, who says, talking to the crime writer, "I think guys like you"—thriller writers—"are exploitative bastards. You dream up terrorist cells and serial killers and you feed off real people's fears and live large doing it." And then he adds, "Doesn't enough shit go wrong in the world without you glorifying it?" Gregg Hurwitz, you wrote that about yourself to some extent. I mean, what's your answer to that critique?
- 5.5 It's weird.
- 5.6 You're the harshest critic of yourself.
- 5.7 Well, aren't we all, to some extent, if you're paying any kind of attention? Look, anytime that you're putting something out into the world and it's finding resonance, there's questions around it, right? And it's somewhat linked—you know, it's like, the thing with novels, the way that I think of it is, I want to be read as widely as I can. And that means that you make more money if you're read more widely. But you got to keep all the incentive structures straight also, right? Because if I could write more and more exploitive stuff, if I could write stuff, let's say, that gets more and more propagandistic

—let's say, I find my tribe and I'm writing to them and I'm firing them up in one direction—there's all these tendencies that pull on us all the time.

- 5.8** I think you feel it probably every time you're gonna post something on social media where you're like, "Uh, what does this signal? What does this say? Is this too much? Is this too little? Do I adjust this?" And with books, you don't, you can't drive yourself crazy trying to figure out how you're gonna slide through in terms of all these ethics. But by the same token, I'm putting stuff out with a lot of violence in the world. And for a lot of years I didn't think about it much because I just love the form so much and so purely.
- 5.9** But I always write with some underlying ethic that I'm trying to get at. There's some underlying thematics from the book, especially in *The Crime Writer*, and that's got to be the thing that governs it. So the cop, while he's a wonderful critic, he's the cop and he's viewing this from one perspective, from one individual, and he's angry, and he's pissed off at the character. And that's a fair perspective. It doesn't happen to be mine.
- 5.10** So if perhaps, as this cop character suspects, you somehow unleash not the dogs of war and not Rhodesian ridgebacks, but say, a serial killer, say, somewhere like—the figure who comes back to my mind, René, in *The Nowhere Man*. And for those who don't recall René, René not only kind of abducts people, steals all their money, and kills them, but also he sort of injects himself or bathes in the blood of virgins or the blood of young people in order to renovate himself, to remain sort of eternal. This is his dream, to attain eternity in some way, but by killing people. And it's like some great fairy tale in which you bathe in a bath full of blood.
- 5.11** There's a study where they would take rats. And if there's some old decrepit rat and a younger rat, if they switched their blood, the old rat would start to rejuvenate. But then you have to put the blood somewhere so the younger rat doesn't die. But when it gets the older blood, it ages more rapidly. And so you can do that in humans. Right? So that was the basis for me to thinking about a character, René. So, you know, I read a study like that, and I think that's fascinating. And then I think, well, that's a modern vampire, right? So then I think, well, what's a story around it? And what's the guy gonna be like?
- 5.12** This is the beginning of that book, effectively, that scientific experiment involving mice or rats. And you thought, OK, what if—
- 5.13** It was the beginning of him. The beginning of that book was, I'm a big John Fowles fan, and I love *The Collector* and *The Magus*, and I wanted to do kind of a thriller version of a locked room mystery. So Evan basically is captured, and he wakes up, and he's in this glorious chateau with a window overlooking—like, he doesn't even know where he is. And everything, everything is not what it seems like. The windows are bolted a certain way. Like, he doesn't have—like, there's nothing he can make a weapon with. The doors are locked, and he's basically held captive. And it's a bit like the *Watchmen* trope,

where they're like, we've locked Orphan X in here. And he's like, "Uh uh, you guys are locked in here with me." And so it's this whole dance through a captivity.

- 5.14** But when I was thinking about who was doing that with René, that's an example of where, like, you know, the highly annoying first question, Andy Martin, of "where do you get your ideas?" that everybody asks, but that's an example. Because I read that study, and it's like, oh, apply that to people, which they already are. Well, now it is. When I wrote it, it wasn't yet being applied. And then he's a vampire. So what's a vampire look like? What's a vampire do? What's a vampire want? Right? And then, so it kind of rolls out from there. And he's obsessed with keeping his age. He's got a lineup of different pills and supplements as he's kind of aging and decaying. There's a Norma Desmond aspect to him, almost.
- 5.15** And do you think you have now—OK, you had that brilliant idea, and you've written about it. Do you think you've now planted that idea, you know—real Renés of the future?
- 5.16** Well, there's billionaires who are doing this blood washing. So, look, it's very complicating. Because you—I mean, I remember, technology is moving so fast. I wrote, when I wrote *The Kill Clause*, it was my fourth novel. And I remember the whole marketing team at HarperCollins was freaking out that our phones had these things in them called GPS, and they could track our location. Like, how quickly we've moved to literally, like, you can be—and I was describing it. Like, "GPS stands for global positioning satellites, and there is something that follows your phone and hits towers." Like, I was explaining it.
- 5.17** And we're at a level of cultural shorthand now that if you're in a TV show, you can just have your characters do something. Like, all of a sudden, cops show up and they go, "Oh," and pull a phone out of their pocket and go. And the person throws it out the window. And we all know what that means. It no longer bears any description because it's completely worked its way, like, it's worked its way into our culture with such clarity. So the question is, am I out ahead of the curve or am I encouraging the curve? I think that's part of what you're asking.
- 5.18** I don't worry very much about the impact of specific acts of violence that are gonna lead to acts of violence. So Stephen King has a wonderful line where he said, they said, "Would you feel angry if somebody, like a serial killer, went out and killed somebody, as characters are killed in your books?" And he said, "No, I would sue them for plagiarism." So I have a starting position that's a bit more like Oscar Wilde, right? The art is the art. The work is the work. You can't be responsible for all the twists and turns in someone's brain.
- 5.19** Another anecdote. A.M. Holmes, wonderful writer, she wrote *The End of Alice*, which ends quite brutally. She was asked, "Would you feel guilty if somebody killed somebody in the manner that someone was killed in your book?" And she said, "I'd feel no more

guilty than the makers of the kitchen knife that was used to stab them." Right? What are the tools of responsibility? And so I wrote an op-ed about this because there was a guy, forget where, a school shooter who'd watched Oldboy, the original Oldboy, South Korean horror movie, and was, like, dressed up from that and went and shot a bunch of people.

- 5.20 So do we really think that if he didn't have that, like, are we gonna take his vestments, right, and the war face he puts on as being causal? Like, if he didn't see that movie, he would have been fine and just be married with 4 kids and live in a house with a white picket fence? So he's appropriating imagery from something that's horrifying. But does that then turn it causal, or does that mean that he's searching for images? And if it's not that, it would be The Joker, or if it's not that, it would be something else that he came across. So it's very hard to determine that.
- 5.21 I mean, so for me, increasingly, there's a few things I won't do. I will not design a bomb from housemade things that have all the constituent steps for someone to do it. But there's a ton of destructive ideas all the time that I'm putting out and that I'm dealing with, and they exist in the world. One of the things that's always been an argument for me against censorship of books because they might lead to ill in the world—I had an argument with a Canadian friend once about Clockwork Orange that he said he went and saw it, and afterwards, these kids were, like, ready to go do violence, this pack of people, and he talked them out of it.
- 5.22 But one thing I've noticed is, whenever it's about that, like, somebody committing an act of violence, their concern is never on behalf of themselves. I haven't talked to anybody who's like, "I can't read that book, or I'd be a mass shooter." Right? It's always on behalf of other poor, feeble minds that are going to be more readily influenced. But if your mind's not—like, I've read a lot of dark stuff. I've researched a lot of dark things, like tapes and crime scene photos. I've swam around in plenty of darkness.
- 5.23 But you're still at liberty. This is the thing.
- 5.24 That's right. I've not been tempted to go and become a serial killer. So we're so concerned with other people. And so it's interesting because I feel like when we talk about ethics in literature or ethics in art or ethics in entertainment, we get the resolution level wrong. This happens a lot in the political conversation, right? Like we're screaming about one bill or one pronoun or one thing, and there's—it's like these tentacles go down, and there's these way bigger problems and conversations that are happening. And if you run around and jump from thing to thing, it's like playing Whac-a-mole, right? Because they just keep going. And that's sort of the point, is for those arguments to keep going up there so that we keep yelling about all them and never get down to what's happening.
- 5.25 So the part that I've started thinking about, I sort of skip the "are you responsible if people go out and shoot people like Orphan X?" Because I just don't, that doesn't

resonate with me as being something that's significantly causal. But one thing I think a lot more about is what is my—down here, foundationally within the culture—what's my responsibility for the types of stories that I'm engaging in? And how do I not turn that into propaganda? I'm not gonna make a feel-good unity story to save the country. Because then I'm not doing— A, it's arrogant, and B, then it's not art, right?

- 5.26** But this, but I think that the proper level is like, sort of, what are we telling and feeling in our entertainment, right? Is it merely crassly cynical? Is the violence, even violence that I've written—like, have I been writing it in a way that I no longer want it to be as dehumanized? I want it to matter more, right? And so I have—there's a Batman that I wrote one time where Batman comes up. It's Tweedledee and Tweedledum. I reinvented The Mad Hatter after I reinvented Scarecrow and Penguin. I was doing, I was going back through the rogues' gallery, and he meets one of the guys and Tweedledee, and his jaw's kind of hanging off.
- 5.27** And he says, "Yeah, you know that there's one time you swung in through the skylight and you hit my jaw." And he then describes the entire injury of the jaw. "It's like you knocked it off. You fractured my skull this way. I had 19 surgeries." Like, I literally wanted to show the impact of one of those cool panels that Batman goes and smashes through somebody. And then, of course, Batman is not sympathetic, if he says, "If you don't stay in line, I'll knock it clear off your face." It's his response after you think there might be a whisper of empathy, but there's real-world damage that happens when people are injured.
- 5.28** And that, to me, starts to get really interesting and really compelling, just like we talked about Tilda Swinton's character calling in an assassination in Michael Clayton. But she's very shaken up by it. The more that I think about violence, it's like I wanted a higher resolution level instead of lower. And that seems to me something that's worth spending time and adjusting my focus on. But that has to do with wanting to have a different relationship about the realness of violence, even if it's being conducted in ways that are aesthetic or badass or driving suspense. But I want to engage with it in a way that feels—
- 5.29** Yeah, it's so interesting you introduce that kind of complexity even within the comic book and certainly in your non-comic books. And perhaps we can come back to comics. But it does seem to me that your main responsibility then is to the reader to enable them to keep reading. Because what happens is, we pick up a book or we download an e-book. We start reading. So far, so good. But what is it that keeps us reading? What is there in the story that hooks us and makes it, as they say, unputdownable? And the answer must be contained in the structure of narrative somewhere.
- 5.30** But to understand that, do we have to understand the reader first? Maybe the writer needs to think like a reader to some extent. And you are a reader before you become a writer, I guess, actually. And is there a sort of physiology of reading that we need to take into account, or that you take into account when you're writing? I mean, you

mentioned the other day how writers, screenwriters, had to shift from where they would build in the cliff-hanger. Because yeah, because we'd switched from television to streaming. And so do you try to think, well, how would the—if I were the reader, how would I react to that? Are you thinking about the reader first or the writer?

5.31 I think from writing.

5.32 Right.

5.33 Look, there are some writers who say, "I can't read when I'm writing because I get infected with the other person's voice and I need my own clarity." I mean, I'm writing all the time, and that would mean I never read. So I'm somebody who came to writing with a passion—I was a passionate reader and still am, and I don't want to relinquish that. And so as a writer, they're not distinguished in my head, so I'll think about clarity. It's a different mechanism. But I'm not thinking, "Oh, how will people receive this?" and let me work backwards from them. I'm writing from my perspective and my craft outward.

5.34 You can't think too much about too many people. You can't try and chase market either. Books are slow. You write a book, it takes a year. If they maybe takes 6 months to sell it, maybe it takes another year to come out. And you have the key that's going to be The DaVinci Code. And all of a sudden it's in 2023. Like, you have to write the thing that you love and hope that you are The DaVinci Code or Harry Potter or Mystic River, that you're going to collide with the zeitgeist in the right way, not sort of be chasing where readers are, where marketing is, where publishing trends are. Like, I don't find much of that talk helpful. And if you have too much of a focus on your readers, then you're creating kind of like populist-driven entertainment, which I suppose is OK, but that's not what I do.

5.35 Can I ask this question on behalf of readers, though? Because I think it's the question that most readers want to know the answer to. How many words do you do a day? Do you have a— you know, I've got to do this as a minimum, otherwise it's a wasted day.

5.36 My schedule right now is chopped because I just have so many projects.

5.37 Your work in progress. I mean, where are you at the moment? I mean, what have you got?

5.38 So I'm launching The Last Orphan next month, right? So I'm editing the manuscript after that, which is the next Orphan X, and I'm rough draft writing the manuscript that's after that one. Right? And so there's these different, like—

5.39 You're doing the outline of the next one. You're rolling.

5.40 Yeah, I'm in the clay, right? I'm in the clay of it. I'm up to my elbows, let's say.

5.41 So you've got two simultaneously.

- 5.42 Yeah, but and then launching Last Orphan. Right. So there's, so it's weird because there's this— we should talk a little bit about focus and ethic towards the craft, right? Because with success, like, when a film comes out, when a comic comes out, there can be junkets, there can be interviews, you can, right, there's all sorts of things. There's marketing materials and how do you sort of differentiate that? So I have those things happening. I'm working on a comic. I'm in the middle of a rewrite-first screenplay. So things start to kind of collide. And how do you carve out properly the time?
- 5.43 And we had this discussion, and as far as I can tell, the rules are exactly the same for a starting writer and me now. If I can't carve the time and make it sacrosanct, my excuses to not have that happen are higher and more complicated maybe. The excuses are higher in their appeal, I should say. Not higher in a moral sense, but it's the same answer. So I'm like, "Oh, I should really tweak the end of the screenplay because I have to get it. And I have a podcast I have to do with England, and I have this, and I have that." It's like, everything needs to be in its place.
- 5.44 And the relationship, your relationship with the creative, it's intensely personal. That's a relationship that has to be cultivated. And you cultivate it through ritual, and you cultivate it through respect. It's really interesting because we're doing this seminar on Exodus right now over with Jordan, and so much of it is about covenantal covenants. What are the covenants that we make in all sorts of ways?
- 5.45 The contract.
- 5.46 Yeah. And there's a contract. Like when I sold my first book, I was right out of grad school. I was very, very fortunate. But the first thing that I did was I broke it down and thought, if I live in the cheapest way that I possibly can, how many months of writing do I have? So, money, initially, in my career, I viewed as like gas in the tank of the car that I'm driving, that I get to write every day. Because if you have an opportunity. It's not like a doctor has a bad series of days and then he has to be a janitor if things get thin. Like, your job doesn't change. Right? But if you can't support around writing, if you get an opportunity to write full-time, it was very important to me to take that really seriously. And I was like, this is what I've always wanted to do. I have an opportunity. I will write from 9 to 5 every day. I will treat it with immense proper respect. A lot of friends were like, "Let's go to a movie. Let's go here." Screenwriters or others. And it was like, "Uh uh. That time has to be squared." So it's really important.
- 5.47 And the other thing that's really important is that—sorry, while we're talking about this piece of the ethics— what work you're doing is also really important. And the good thing is, is when you're starting in your career, almost anything can be really exciting. I mean, I remember I wrote like an advertisement for Kodak or something. I was in college. Like, you're excited to be in print. I mean, I was writing theater reviews for \$15 that I'd, like, drive an hour to San Francisco and watch a 2-hour play and drive home for an hour and take 2 hours and write it, and I'd get \$15. But it's like, there it is. You have a byline, right?

- 5.48** Engage with things that are exciting. That doesn't mean that you're going to have, like, the greatest choices right out of the gates. But if you can make things really special that you're tasked with, if you can really put your mind to it—"how you do anything's how you do everything"—you can really find interest in little jobs and things that you're doing and try and just make everything as great as it possibly can be. And then there's sort of more opportunities.
- 5.49** But as you're writing, just generally in any sense, you got to write towards what it is that you love. You just have to do it. And if you're writing a bunch of stuff to go, "Look, I'll just take this for money," I mean, I have a lot of—when I'm on book tour, I see a lot of people who are like, "I really want to be a writer, but I need money and stability. So I became an accountant, but I'm going to retire in 10 years, and then I'm going to write a novel." And it's like, the interceding 35 years, you don't emerge from that unaltered. Right? So for 35 years, you're somebody who wanted to write a novel, who never did, because there's a story about making money that got between you and your passion, right? That alters you in a way that you're no longer gonna have the drive and interests, probably, that you did.
- 5.50** Maybe you can, and good on you to do it, but don't think if you're still putting it off now for 10 more years, like, we are what we're doing. And so make sure that you're choosing things that are good. And it starts to come up a little bit later with different jobs, with offers and money, because there's some stuff where I'm like, I could write it, but I'm not overwhelmingly excited and the money's decent. But if I engage with it that way, I feel like I'm dissipating my talent. I feel like I'm not respecting it fully. And that doesn't have to do with the height or the sophistication. It has to do with if it's lighting a fire in me. I'll go do it to reinvent the Penguin, if it's alive in me, even though nobody wants that story. They think.
- 5.51** Well, I wanted to quote Lawrence Kasdan here. "Being a writer is like having homework every night for the rest of your life," I think, which will put a lot of people off who think, well, "Perhaps I will become an accountant after all." But I wondered, and to bring the tone right down, what is it that you—there is no magic pill. Is there any stimulus that you seek during the day, if you start running out of steam? Do you have to take the dog for a walk? Is it more coffee? You know, is there some magic smoothie or something like that?
- 5.52** I have all that, but it kind of comes, it's like feeding. When I work now, I'm like, what is the fuel that I need to stay here and in the space?
- 5.53** What fuel? Is there a fuel?
- 5.54** It's coffee. I'll have smoothies, but it's not—yeah, it'll come in. I eat clean. A lot of times I'm just eating at my desk, and it's trying to hold a certain space in relation to my work. And it involves not having to deal with a lot of stuff. I don't go out for lunch. I used to do that a lot. Like, I'd take a break and go out to lunch for an hour and—

- 5.55 No going out for lunch. OK.
- 5.56 I mean, if I have a meeting, I'll do it. But those things are more disruptive for me now because I have too many other intrusions. So I'm pretty lean on what the time is and what the schedule is. And then at night, I'm usually taking things to try and slow down, like bourbon.
- 5.57 Ah, now there you touch on a point. I was thinking of Raymond Chandler when you were talking there, actually. And there's a story that's told of him, that great drinker, of course, but he was in the middle of—he was writing the screenplay for a Hollywood film. I forget which one now, but, and he, and the way the studios used to work then, is that you'd start writing, they'd start shooting. So they get halfway through the film, and then Chandler gets writer's block. And they're going, "OK, what's going to happen in the next scene, Raymond?"
- 5.58 He's going, "I don't know. I haven't written it yet." And they go, "OK, quick, we're going to set Mr. Chandler up with—upstairs, he's going to have his typewriter and a bottle of bourbon, I think, on the desk. Downstairs, we have an ambulance ready to take him to hospital to dry him out again and then drive him back and get him down to work again." It worked for Chandler, apparently. You don't have the ambulance waiting downstairs?
- 5.59 I don't, thank God I don't have an ambulance. But no, it's— I think everybody's working to occupy the best version of themselves, or we should be, right, if you're aware of it. And so you don't want to be too reliant on other things. But in the course of a day—
- 5.60 Stimulants.
- 5.61 Yeah. I mean, Lee drinks, what, 40 cups of coffee a day when he's writing?
- 5.62 This is Lee Child. I think he certainly hit 30-something.
- 5.63 Yeah. I mean, he's fueled. The key is to be in there and to stay in there and to hold focus and to be in the story that all you're thinking about is the story. Michael Connelly describes it as being like a surfer when you catch a wave and you're in the tube and everything that you see around you is story. And you're just holding that moment. And it's magical. And it's so frustrating when it gets interrupted more and more.
- 5.64 I don't know if, to carry on that metaphor, because the thing—well, I certainly expect in the tube is the next thing that happens is the wipeout. So it's really hard to sustain.
- 5.65 Not very optimistic, Martin.
- 5.66 No, no, it's not. It's just realistic.
- 5.67 Look. So here. So let's talk practically for how people do it. You asked how many. So I don't have a word count every day. Because some days I'm like, wait a minute, I need to go backwards a whole bunch. I've had prodigious word counts. I've written, I mean, 5 to 10,000 a day isn't a big deal. There's one time I wrote a fourth of a novel in 3 days.

That was for a book I wrote called Don't Look Back. I got to the end. Structurally, it was like a coiled spring. And then it just went, and I barely left my desk. It was harder for me to not be writing than be writing for those 3 days. So I wrote 33, 35,000 words in 3 days.

- 5.68** But you allow yourself kind of a year, you were saying, roughly, to finish a book, to go from zero to completion.
- 5.69** But, look, when you're writing towards the end, often the beginning is toughest because you're making all these choices. As you're writing to the end, things should be starting to come inevitable. And so there's a lot of times where I'll have a runaway kind of couple days that are great, and then I'll hit something and be like, "This is boring. It doesn't feel right. Is the problem here? Is the problem backwards?" So I don't just set a straight goal, because the job is to get that elephant out of the block of stone. You don't always know. Like, maybe you need to go do a bunch of detail work on the tail for 2 days, and that's gonna unstick what you're doing with the front leg. Right?
- 5.70** So, and I'm working in different areas, but the key thing, I think, is to ritualize it if you're starting. Let's talk about, to the people watching who want to be writers, it's like, does it mean if you have another job that that's 2 hours twice a week, no matter what, and you just start with that? How's the 2 hours feel? Like, pick something that is achievable, that you will honor every time. If you start to pick it and move it, then you're going to start to not trust yourself. And it sucks when we don't trust ourselves with discipline. It's like going to the gym. If you say you're going to go to the gym, and that's your plan, you don't do it for a week? What you're learning is you don't trust yourself. And then if you do it, it's operant conditioning, right? That's what it is. That's how slot machines work. Right?
- 5.71** Can I ask about drafts?
- 5.72** Yes.
- 5.73** How many drafts? Because, OK. Our old friend Lee Child that we're referring to maintains that he just does the one draft, and that's it. And he allows the editor maybe, like, 3 comments and he might react to one of them. So it's kind of, it's perfect the first time around. Very few people— so he says—very few people operate like that. I mean, do you tend to do a quick first draft and then revise, or how does it work?
- 5.74** I'm happy to say what my process is, and it's changed, so maybe we should walk through the different processes, because even within one career, you have a lot. I mean, initially, when I wrote my first book, I just sat down and wrote with no outline or no anything, when I felt like writing. And I wrote a— like, I think it had pieces in it that were compelling because I got representation and eventually sold it, but it wasn't very good. And it was, like, half the length of a novel, and nothing was in the right place. And it needed help at every level, like dialogue, character structure, all of it.

- 5.75** I wrote 16 drafts before I sold that. And, you know, it's like, I could have gone and written 16 drafts. I could have written 16 drafts of 16 different novels and not sold any of them. Right? But I was trying to learn. You want to get the thing that you're writing as exceptional as it can be. And so a lot of times, like the first, let's say if you're starting in your first pass at something, is 50% of what it should be, right? The next 30 is as hard as the first 50. The next 10 is as hard as that 30. Right? The next 10 is harder. The next 5 is harder.
- 5.76** Let's say to sell something in one of these fields, you have to be in the top 5% to even have a conversation to compete, meaning, to have representatives, you got to raise the bar pretty high. So when you're working on something, you want that thing to be as good as it possibly can be, because the competition is unbelievably intense to get attention. But a lot of times I'll be somewhere in the last—you know, the last bit is so much. So anyways, my first two books I just wrote, both of them were messes. Both of them required elaborate editing process and tons of drafts. Third book was the first time that, when I wrote a rough draft, when I finished it, it looked kind of like what a rough draft would be. I then did a decent number of edits and then went through the proper editorial process.
- 5.77** Well, then I got to a point where I was outlining more and more. And the peak of success of that approach for me was my 7th book, where I outlined everything. I had an 89-page outline and every plot point covered. And the book was incredibly tight. So structurally, it worked really, really well. But I realized when I was writing it that I didn't feel— I didn't like having those pieces connected of the thinking. There's a weird ratio between the planning and the execution. And on the day, I like not knowing exactly how a scene is going to work. I like having a kind of shell of a scene and a bunch of ideas, but find my way in and be more inventive.
- 5.78** And so with an outline, I felt a little bit like one part of my brain that's, let's call it just wilder, is like, rampaging with blue-sky ideas. I, like, talked to that part, and then I talked to kind of a craft part, and they were separated in the process, and I didn't like that. And so for the next book, I went back to no outline. And then I slowly kind of combined it to now this rolling outline, which is the balance that I need that's kind of—
- 5.79** It's not an 89-page outline.
- 5.80** No, it's 15 to 25 pages with lots of grouped bullet points. We discussed it the other day, and that way it gets to live and breathe. This gets to live and breathe. Whatever parts of my brain want to come in and kind of chew on the story—a lot of times with a story, you're masticating it, right? You're trying to figure out what it is. I always think of the image, like, babies have the most nerves in their mouth. That's why they put things in their mouth, to understand what they are. And it's like you're trying to get your mouth around a story and figure it out, right? You can't get your arms around it.

- 5.81** And I don't like separating out the parts of my brain that are fiddling with it. Because sometimes I'll go through and go, "Oh, I don't wanna just fill this in. This could be a whole rich vein, right?" But I need to go back and I need to go forward, and the scene's gotta change, and this has to twist. So it's very weird. It's all about the space within myself that I'm accessing in order to move forward.
- 5.82** I wanna come to the question of the twist. But you mentioned Stephen King, this great book of his, *On Writing*, which I recommend to anyone who hasn't read it, but lovely account of growing up and how he becomes a writer, but also his process. And one of the weird things in there, at least it seems fairly weird to me, is that when he's writing, he locks himself away in his cave. He has loud rock music playing all the time, so all of his books are written to a very loud soundtrack. How are you on music while you're writing?
- 5.83** I'm the opposite. I can't do words, right, because the words start to tingle up for me. So I do different white noise in my office and I just put it really loud in surround sound, and the door's locked.
- 5.84** You literally have white noise on to block out any possible distractions, right?
- 5.85** Yeah. Phones are out of the room. I have white noise on, and the dogs come in sometimes, but then they start to wrestle and they're giant Rhodesian ridgebacks and so, and if people don't know the breed, they think they're killing each other. So I was on a Zoom one time and one of the dogs jumped up on my lap, like the big front paws. I mean, I had one that weighed 125 pounds. And so my chair started rolling. I was in an Aeron and I grabbed my desk, and my desk also was rolling. So we just kind of rolled across the room on the Zoom call. So if the dogs are behaving themselves, they can be present because they don't bother me with, like, properly enunciated consonants. Right? I can deal with the guttural. But if the words come in, they start to get in my head if I'm listening to music. So it's like, it's white noise. It's around all that focus. And that's the kind of way to play.
- 5.86** You know, I remember Georges Simenon, who wrote some of the, author of the Maigret novels, wrote very short novels, typically. Haven't added them up, but 30,000 words, maybe, I would think? Whereas your books would typically be 90? 100,000.
- 5.87** The rough length for your average book that you're submitting, let's say, is about 100,000 words, and you're pretty fine from 90 to 110, maybe 85 to 115. And certain books are much longer. I have one book that was 145,000 words. Was it Winston Churchill who said about women's skirts, that it should just be long enough to cover the subject? Like, a book's gotta be the book, right? But a lot of times, if you're writing something and it's long and you're not incredibly proficient in your expertise, it's because it's bloated. So it's a good parameter in a lot of ways.

- 5.88** I remember Simenon once, and I think he actually did this in reality. It wasn't just a plan, that he set himself up in some Parisian cafe or bar in a kind of glass cubicle. Him and a typewriter.
- 5.89** Yes, in the window.
- 5.90** And typed the next novel, while everyone else was watching, as it were. And he could put up with that. Guessing you probably wouldn't fancy it? I mean, that's like a YouTube thing now. You could be on YouTube. We could be watching Gregg on YouTube, sort of update every day to see.
- 5.91** You could be on YouTube watching an AI representation of me write the books.
- 5.92** Yeah. Right?
- 5.93** And then we could just sell them to AI readers, and then we can just, we don't even need to have it do anything anymore. I mean, I can focus elsewhere, but that's preferred. That sets the terms of ritual. Right? Like, if you go to the gym, if you go to yoga, if you go to church, if you go anywhere, it's like you dress a certain way, you put on the vestments, right? You enter a space that has different rules and parameters. There's a process, and I don't know if you feel that. Like, if you're going to the gym, sometimes when you're walking in, your nervous system's recognizing all these cues and it's in a certain mood.
- 5.94** And so that's something that's important to set in a workplace. As a writer, we don't have workplaces, so those have to be invented. We don't have to put on a tie and go to a big law firm and there's coffee in the lobby, and you go up and you sit at your desk and you say hi to your assistant, and the cues aren't necessarily there. And for me, as somebody who—one of the most useful aspects of training for me, people point sometimes to my education and talk about that. But being an athlete was a huge aspect of my training.
- 5.95** Was it pole vaulting?
- 5.96** I was a pole vaulter in college. And it's another one of these things where it's like, you always have something more important to do than train day 17 for the state meet that's at the end of the year. It's very similar. And I think that with athletes, and this can be applied to any venture that you've done that requires discipline. Maybe you've played chess, maybe you play a violin. Just pick something that requires excellence through a hierarchical standard that can be objectively judged in some sense, right?
- 5.97** But the engagement in it, I think about it with baseball, and by the way, your metaphor with Raymond Chandler reminds me of Babe Ruth, that they said, "You can't party, you can't have women, you can't do anything." He went like, "Oh for five?" And they're like, "Forget it. Here's women and booze. Just show up tomorrow in the batter's box." But if you look at what distinguishes a great baseball player, to my mind, when they're incandescently brilliant and on point, we're all, we can all do that. A triple A player can

have that moment. That's the best moment in their career, right? That they're up there and everything's working.

5.98 But a professional player raises the bottom of the game also, right? So they're not going to have a terrible day. So if you have a pro in the field, ideally, even if they're not hitting that day, like, they're doing something smart with base running, right? They're helping work with the team in other ways. They might make some spectacular fielding play. Did they get pinch run when somebody else walks? On a bad day, they're still functional and productive, and we think a lot about just pushing the top end of our performance towards excellence. But for me, when I'm in the mood and going and writing, I don't really need much help. I feel like I'm channeling what I need to be, in the place that I need to be.

5.99 But one of the things that's important to work on in a field that doesn't have a lot of parameters is, what are you doing to bring up the bottom of your experience? If you're not feeling that great, and you're tired and you're sluggish, that's where you need, I think, those rituals and those cues to say, do you light candles? Is it in this room? What's your, is it hard, is it heavy metal music and you're Stephen King? Is it white noise and two Rhodesian ridgebacks and it's me? Right, at a certain point, like, what do you need to keep reminding yourself that you're gonna be productive?

5.100 And so the writer's block thing, like, I don't get writer's block. Oh, watch. Let me knock wood. I just, it's not something that I have. I get distracted into uselessness. Right, that's different. But if I'm sitting and focused, I have enough cues that I can be productive. And even if I have a day that it's not going great, I can get something down that I can fix the next day or in the next session. And so that's really important because a lot of people just wait around till they're in the mood for, like, you know, the muse to visit them. And it's like, it's a job. Deal with it with respect. Deal with ritual. Approach it with discipline.

5.101 You know, we've sort of talked about the OCD side and how, to some extent, the writer has to be an obsessive compulsive. And the thing I was wondering is, you know, you've spoken about how you get up for a day's work. How do you come down again? Because I've sort of got this image in my mind of, you know, you back at your house and your wife comes in or your daughter or something like that. And they say, "Hey, let's go to the supermarket." And you're thinking vampires or guy with his jaw hanging off. And how do you kind of exit?

5.102 It's really, that's really difficult. There's something we say in TV or in production. We talk about reentry with your family.

5.103 Reentry, right.

5.104 Because it's like, if you're in a show, it's this weird, like, there's a camaraderie. There's dynamics. You're in a production, it's super intense. You have all these super intense relationships. Ideally, they're going well, but you're also running at a different speed. I

mean, I was shooting a TV show in Canada where I was there producing the show, and I was rewriting two shows later. No, I was rewriting the next show, and I was on the phone with the writers' room that's breaking the show after that. So you're busy, but you're also—and it's cool and it's fun because you have a lot to do and a lot of responsibility. Right. And that's always exciting.

- 5.105** But you're also, in another sense, like a rented mule, because your time up there, like, they are owning you, but they'll get you everything that they need to feed you. So you're like a machine. And I was on set. I remember I was on the phone. I was writing the thing, and the set crew guys came over. I was on the tall director's chair and literally just, like, built a properly sized desk out of, like, 3 pieces of wood hammered together. Yeah. So, like, I'm writing, and they just bring it and put it in front of me. I pick my laptop up and slid it on and just kept writing because we're on set.
- 5.106** And so it takes a lot to hold that focus and to feed yourself because you're there to do a job. It's like being an athlete in a certain way. When you're fortunate enough to reach a place that you've written your way into a position that you're essential on a project. And then you come home, and it's like, there's a whole different set of rules. You still have to get home. You still have to engage like a human being and not, it can't be like, "Wait, I need coffee to stay awake. I need, right, can you make sure that you got my hair and makeup right, like, before we come here so that my head's not shiny," and, right, there's all that, there's a lot of stuff that goes into this, right. Make sure you're fed and that there's cars.
- 5.107** And then you're home. And existing in a world where it's important to be of service and maintain real relationships. Right? And not have those things come unhooked. So I don't like when writers or artists, from a very young age—I made a call not to use it in any way, to, like, excuse excesses of behavior or revel too preciously in the idiosyncratic nature of the creative. Like, I'm plenty idiosyncratic on my own.
- 5.108** No, but not using it as a kind of an alibi. "Oh, sorry, darling. I can't go to the market now."
- 5.109** I've had friends be like, "You know, I can't. If someone comes in, I'm juggling, and it's so intense, and then everything crashes down. And, like, Gregg, can you tell them why?" And it's like, "No, I set rules. It's like, I'm in my office, the door's closed. Like, tell me if someone comes in and they're on fire, right? If something's burning down, come get me." And I remember when my daughter was young, you know, I never could distinguish between babies' cries because they all just sounded like screaming babies. And then you have your own baby.
- 5.110** I think for a lot of guys, you have your own baby, and then it differentiates babies as a category of, like, they reach a higher resolution level. And I could tell, "Oh, that's a, that's like, she's hurt." And if she's hurt, I'm out of my office. Right? "That's that she's annoyed or hungry." I'm not out of my office. Right? Like, you set different hierarchies

in motion. But for me, the transition time between the creative day or the disciplined day, and that roll back is really key. And so that transition, for me, I can't just jump right in. Right? It's really good for me to take a walk with the dogs. It's really good for me to have a drink. It's really good for me to go, like, I do Bikram yoga in 110 degrees.

- 5.111** Like, what's a transitory state, right? And there's not always a luxury to do that. But, yeah, it's important. There's a lot of people who excuse, who excuse bad behavior by aligning it with creative specialness. And it's weird because there's some things, like, there's some ways that you have to be weird to get to your innermost version of what your voice is. It's necessarily weird, right, if you want to be a writer.
- 5.112** Because there must be times, I was thinking, when you're in the zone and, you know, your phone in the Orphan X thing, it's called the roam zone, isn't it, that—have you ever attempted, when you pick up the phone, to say, "Can I help?"
- 5.113** "Do you need my help?"
- 5.114** "Do you need my help?" Sorry. Let's get the line right. Do you need my help? That's right. That's the Orphan X line.
- 5.115** No, but if you call 1-855-2-NOWHERE, you could see if Orphan X answers the phone.
- 5.116** I'm going to try that.
- 5.117** Give it a go.
- 5.118** All right, well, look, we talked about the writer. We're going to come back to the writer, but can I just move on to the reader? Back to the reader and use that great Freudian term, "epistemophilia," where Freud is saying we have this desire to know, and this connects us with the unveiling or disclosure side of narrative. And I've mentioned this. I take this from Hayden White. He suggests—I don't know if this is right or not— but there's an Indo-European root of narrative to knowing that they're cognate in some way. Whether or not that's right, I think that the simple term that probably applies is curiosity.
- 5.119** We have curiosity, but the purpose of the writer is to excite that and to some extent, frustrate, I think, curiosity, so that the reader suffers from this sense of an information deprivation. So the question in my mind is, how does the writer whip up the reader's desire for more? And, I mean, I know you've spoken to me about the rules of the first act, what the hook is. I thought you might like to read. This is the chapter one, first paragraph.
- 5.120** The beginning of it all.
- 5.121** Of Orphan X, yeah. And how you did, well, actually read it and how you came up with that and whether you had to fine-tune it and so on.

- 5.122** "After picking up a set of pistol suppressors from a nine-fingered armorer in Las Vegas, Evan Smoak headed for home in his Ford pickup, doing his best not to let the knife wound distract him."
- 5.123** OK. So that plants so many seeds, and it's the very beginning. I mean, the first thing that occurs to me is, did you kind of go back to that after you came up with a nine-fingered armorer further. You thought, "OK, I've got to mention that." And the knife wound, saying, "Hold on." Did you go back? I mean, because so many things were already going on in that one sentence. And did he have a Ford pickup right in the beginning, or did—? Was it all, you know—
- 5.124** It just came out that way to start the story. It was wild.
- 5.125** Right. Well.
- 5.126** So think about what we're doing. Think about how, how do you flirt with somebody? Like, do you go up and say, "I find you really attractive and I have a question"?
- 5.127** Please.
- 5.128** But is good flirtation to come up and say, "I think you're really attractive and I like you, and I want to go out right now"? Not as much. Right. So why is winking considered flirtation? Right? You're denying somebody momentarily the pleasure of your gaze, the pleasure of your eyesight. Right? It's why a lot of times when people are posing in provocative fashion, they're not starkly nude. Right? Often there's, like, lingerie or things are covered or things are suggested. And so appeal is not having everything all at once. Right? We were talking about this with explaining the laryngoscope, right? Like, you gotta give a laryngoscope some lingerie.
- 5.129** Right.
- 5.130** You know, you don't want to just say, "Here's a laryngoscope. Here's a description of a —" You need to sort of hide things in the process. "Well, here's a tool. Here's a name. What are they doing? He's choking. Oh, it's gonna go there. You're gonna do—" You want the reader constantly leaning forward. So, OK, so who's Evan? Right? A nine-fingered armorer. That sounds pretty cool. That's Tommy Stojack, who looms large, of course, in the life of the series. And what's the knife wound, and where did it come from? There's a flurry of questions that open, and I don't get to the answers particularly quickly either.
- 5.131** And so you want to constantly be raising things that are—it's more about, it's not the frustrating and annoying kind, I hope, of mystery, right, where I'm saying stuff and if the reader's confused, going, "I don't get where I am right now," but what you want is enough intrigue that they're moving forward in the action as all these sort of plot things start to slowly paint ambiance around them. Character notes and other things. And you're sort of tracking it, but you're picking up an overall feeling and a mood with other pieces that you hope get fleshed out more. It's like these mosaic pieces. Right? And

you're trying to kind of grab them all until you can discern the picture fully, but you have to turn them over in the right way.

5.132 Right. Right. OK. So that's this kind of gradual process.

5.133 But wait, and one other thing, because we talked about narrative contract yesterday, so real quick, I think it's important to say. Most everyone knows what first person is in a story. Right? "I walked up the street." There's second person, which is used much more sparingly, except in one exquisite Faulkner short story. I did—

5.134 It was also in *The Rains*.

5.135 I played with it a little in *The Rains*.

5.136 "If you're reading this," it starts out, isn't it? So it's an address to the reader. Yeah.

5.137 Yeah. Second person, more purely, is, you know, "You come down the hill, you do this."

5.138 Right. Which is rare.

5.139 So third person is—there's different levels of intimacy. I just want to talk about this because we're talking about the opening. There's different levels of intimacy that you have with different characters. That's a big choice. And people don't think about that. You're setting narrative contract. You're writing from multiple different characters' perspectives. How intimate do you get with them? There's third person. "She walked over to the stove. She put her hand on the stove. She yelped and drew her hand back. There was a burn on her hand." You're outside her. That's a pure third person.

5.140 Then you can drop in where you're assimilating perspective. "She walked over to the stove, put it down. The pain coursed through her hand." Oh, we're in that character. We're in her perceptual framework. "She felt it pulse through her hand. She yanked it back, the throbbing deep beneath the surface, and she turned to press for her favorite ice pack." So you also know what her ice pack is. So we're more intimate in the way that we're connecting with that character.

5.141 Henry James' mirroring consciousness.

5.142 That's right. So do we want to get more intimate yet? Right. "She goes into the kitchen. She looks across at the stove."

5.143 But what about Evan Smoak? Well, Evan Smoak headed for home. I mean, I was—were you thinking of saying "I headed for home in my Ford pickup"?

5.144 Well, I've written books that are that way.

5.145 Yeah, you have.

5.146 But just let me just finish this point with a third person. So we have third person. We have perspective. Then we have what's called free indirect discourse. Right? "She walked in the kitchen. 'God damn it. That kid left the stove on again.'"

- 5.147 Right?
- 5.148 Right? Frustration. "She blew her hair out of—'Do I have to do everything around here?' She walks over and does." So you're approximating first person with her. Do you understand that? It's a different, it's a closer reach. Even though you're staying in third, you're saying how she thinks, right? Like, "Evan looked out across the rooftop with his sniper rifle, adjusted the scope, clean sight lines." Right? "Trash fluttering in the gutter, indicating wind direction." Like, all of a sudden, I'm in his mind, talking in his words without using "I." That's more intimate yet.
- 5.149 So just within third person, we have 3 different layers of how closely we can connect with somebody. Well, guess what? If you don't play with that and you're not aware of that, and you don't build a hierarchy of that, it's confusing, and people are popping all around, and most editors and readers and writers don't understand why. So let's say that you have a story and your main character is with a secondary character, but you're going to free indirect discourse, that very intimate, very close third person with the secondary character, you better do that with effect, because your first character has been diminished in primacy or your protagonist, right? You've gotten less intimate with them.
- 5.150 But that's OK. You can do that sometimes. Like, if I have a scene where Evan's a stranger in a town, and I want to take him from the waitress's perspective to highlight his strangeness, that's a specific kind of choice. But where you can really get jumbled is if you start doing a lot of this within one chapter. Right? So you can't say, "Evan came in, sat down, looked around, good lanes, you know, back to the wall. The thing. The waitress came over, like, young guy looks weird, you know, fussing with his stuff." All of a sudden, we're bouncing too much.
- 5.151 A friend of mine calls head hopping. So you don't want too much head hopping.
- 5.152 Right. And even when you are doing that, if there's a scene with a bunch of characters that you're in, decide the hierarchy of the scene, right? Because whose perspective are you in? How close are you allied to them? And then the other characters can't embody that scene, too. Or you're trying to show two movies at the same time. And readers don't really understand that, but they'll just feel confused and they'll get lost. So it's like, it's an interesting concept, and that's part of setting narrative contract. Right?
- 5.153 I did this in my second book. I wrote from too many perspectives. And I realized, I was like, wait a minute. That's a big cast. Let me take these 5 characters that I write from their perspective, push them into straight third person, so we're just kind of observing them. Whenever I'm in a scene with these characters, here's the order of who we're going to be intimate in perspective.
- 5.154 Yeah. Well, I had to learn that because my second book was such a big ensemble. You can get away with it if it's a sort of more straightforward book. So Evan is primary, right? I write Evan from third person. I write Evan in perspective. I write Evan in free

indirect discourse. At times I'll do that with other characters. I don't do that with too many characters because you're losing the thread. So picking a story, I had that image of the metaphor of the rock climbing wall. Do you remember? I'm gonna give you a different one.

- 5.155** If every character is the center of his or her own universe, like *Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead*, every piece that you have to tell the story, you have to choose the piece that's going to paint your mosaic. So I could tell, if Evan walks into a room with a dozen people at a dinner table, I can choose to tell that story from any perspective in that room. That'll do different things. Right? So which mosaic piece am I going to pick for this chapter? Like, what's the scene through whose perspective, right? And you pop that in the wall. What's the next scene that you're going to tell? Who's that scene from that perspective?
- 5.156** So the way that you're charting your course through, and the choices that you're making in the level of engagement with the characters, is something that needs to be navigated. I did all this subconsciously until I ran into problems and had to examine why a book wasn't working. And then I had to learn and figure out these pieces and push them into consciousness. So I'm not suggesting you sit down with charts and graphs and abacuses and determine it all, but if things aren't working, look at your narrative contract and look at what you're playing and who you're, who you're—if are you being too inclusive in viewpoints, so that you have a mosaic where all the pieces are spinning all the time and they can't solidify into an image to behold?
- 5.157** A mosaic already is a collection of pieces, right? So you want to see it like pointillism almost, right? Where they come together to form something. And if all the pieces are rotating all the time from all these different perspectives, it just feels like a mess. And you don't have a point. You don't have an onboarding point for the reader.
- 5.158** Yeah. I wonder how you were, I mean, with *Orphan X* in particular, ask that "I" question. Were you tempted at all to be *Orphan X* in writing it, or you wanted to have that kind of distance? Or was it that *Orphan X*, because he's such a kind of OCD but kind of controlled sort of character, did you feel that doing it strictly from his point of view would impoverish the—you needed a little bit more freedom to get outside his character?
- 5.159** It just fit the form of it. So I wrote a bunch of first-person novels, starting with *The Crime Writer*, around the *Hitchcock Everyman*. And you're much more limited. Right? But there's advantages to that. Anytime you have a limitation of form, there's advantages. Right? So I'll give you a quick example. Comic books, right? So when you're writing a screenplay, why do we not like voiceover in screenplays, right? We discussed this. Because it reminds you that you're, you're—that it's being written. You want to push.
- 5.160** I actually like voiceover, but that's me. But I know it's not very popular.

- 5.161 Yeah, well, like Shawshank Redemption. OK, right. But other stuff where, you know, "blah, blah, blah, years ago, these people." But so you need to push everything to the visual, right? Everything's gotta be spoken, everything's gotta be seen. And so you lose a lot of things that you have in a novel. Right. You can't give internal character stakes. And there's other stuff too. Like, I was just watching Body Heat again, and there's a scene where there's a flirtation scene at the beach, and he goes to get ice cream cones and comes back and she's gone, but her sweater is hanging over the rail. And it's such a great visual. Because him coming back, and it's an empty fence, at a— like, he's waiting for her kind of on the beach. Having a sign of absence, right, is kind of required, whereas you don't necessarily need that in a novel, right. "He came back and looked around, but she was gone and there wasn't a trace of her" suffices.
- 5.162 But for film, the arresting notion of "he comes back with two ice cream cones and her sweater's slung over something" brings something else out. OK, so now you're writing comics. With comics, instead of having a camera that moves, that can only pick up what is spoken or seen, you have a camera that you can take 4 to 6 snapshots per page. So how do you choose them? You can't show Batman punch someone. You can show the windup, the point of impact, or the aftermath.
- 5.163 Well, then that gets really interesting, because sometimes it's really cool to just show the aftermath, right? You come in on a scene and Batman's breathing hard and his cowl's torn and his knuckles are cracked and there's blood on the wall, and he's just breathing hard. It's in the wake of it, and there's a voiceover describing what happened. That's sort of compelling, right? Or you show something that's leading up to something. So you have to be much more judicious in how you're choosing when to take those pictures. Right? Well, that's the same thing that we're talking about here.
- 5.164 In other words, in any one scene, you kind of have to get in early and get out before the end of the scene.
- 5.165 There's a famous line says, "Start in the middle of a scene and write your way out," right? So I think a lot about, like, writing myself into a corner and then figuring how to get out of the corner, is another way to look at it. But I also have a scene, for instance, as we're talking about playing with readers' understanding, and you're playing with the form in a certain way. So part of it for me is, I wrote—there's an Orphan X book called Out of the Dark. And there's a scene where two cops come to arrest Evan, and he's in a crowded cafe, and he just very calmly describes to them, like, "If you want to arrest me, I'm going to pick this up, and that's going to throw that. I'm going to kick this table." Like, he describes to them the whole fight sequence that will ensue. And they don't kind of back off, and he says, "So we're going to do this?" And they kind of say, "Yes," and I end the chapter.
- 5.166 Fast forward to the next.
- 5.167 Yeah, I never, I never show that happening.

- 5.168** Back in Castle Heights or something.
- 5.169** Yeah. So I never show the fight. But then 3 chapters later, those cops show up, and they have all the matching injuries that he described that he would inflict on them. So the reader, and that was something I thought of from working in comics a little bit, it's a really fun way again to be with the reader in a scene. It's like, we already, I'm not going to describe to you the whole fight scene and then just write the whole fight scene and then show the aftermath of the fight scene. So what can be left out? That's always a key aspect or consideration.
- 5.170** OK. Economy. All right. That's really helpful. And OK, that's a pretty, OK. That's more practical. I just want to mention a slightly academic reference point. Roland Barthes, great French critic, the hermeneutic code. I think you've, in a sense, covered the hermeneutic code because—great book of his, *S/Z*—because I think what he's talking about, and he uses the word enigma or puzzle, that you begin with an enigma. And everything in the hermeneutic code is a way of gradually solving the puzzle or throwing light on the enigma. So there's a kind of ultimately you work towards some kind of tentative resolution or revelation.
- 5.171** Then Christopher Volger's call to adventure. Yeah, *The Writer's Journey*. That, I know, is a very popular book among Hollywood screenwriters, in that he sets out a kind of set of steps that you conceivably can follow. And we're coming to the question of plotting here that I think a lot of people kind of worry about. Is there a way of— you mentioned how you can write a scene. Do you think that, OK, that's part of, I know what the plot, I know what the structure. The plot is an architecture. And do you have to have that architecture in place so that, you know, you're going A, B, C, D, or do you feel it's going to sort of look after itself to some extent?
- 5.172** Do you have a—well, dare I say, and I know writers hate this word— formula? Is there a formula to what you do that—you know, can you get an algorithm, as you say, let's get the AI writer over here and, you know, feed in the algorithm. And OK, there. Go. To some extent, Christopher Vogler's book, which I do think is definitely worth reading, and it's very clever and rather witty and full of interesting analyses, not only of books, but of films as well, but sort of suggest that to some extent.
- 5.173** I don't have. I mean, I look at plot. Everyone says, "Is plot more important or character?" And for me, as I mentioned, I think plot is character in movement, in motion. And we're tracking character in motion. So what the character does at every venue, at every outlet, with every dialogue, with every fight scene, is illuminating of what that process is. And that's the way that I think about it. And so a lot of times, at the end of a day, if I write it—let's say there's a scene that's got, like, an exposition dump.
- 5.174** You got a lot of stuff that has to be described in some way. I might write that scene and get all that stuff down. Those scenes take me the most time, and then I'll go back and

figure out, how do I make it not sound like exposition? How do I make it clever? How do I break it up with what's called business? Actors use the term business, right? Like, if you have a line of dialogue, you have a cup of coffee. Like, do you pause and gesture it? Or like the soap opera one, right, where you tear off your glasses dramatically.

5.175 Something has to be happening.

5.176 Or just something that's punctuation. It's visual punctuation. Action can function that way, too. Right? So is there something that's happening in a motif that goes on and on? I'll give you an example. There's a scene between Jack and Evan when he's young, and he's on a sniper range, and he's shooting the targets.

5.177 Jack being the mentor figure.

5.178 Jack's his father figure. And Evan's 15. He's belly-down, sniper. And they're having a conversation, and Evan's shooting, shooting, shooting. And Jack's looking, and he goes, "You're missing the mark." And at the end, and the cap on the end of it, like, Evan shoots. Jack looks. He misses it. Shoots. He misses it. And the end of the scene is, Jack says, "You're missing the mark." And Evan says, "Wrong target." And Jack raises them back to a further one in the distance. And that's the one he's been shooting at. So that's this nice bit of business that wraps a scene and contains it, rather than them just having a conversation about excellence and training without building a bit of a scene with action scaffolding around it that also exemplifies the conversation that they're having. That's pleasing because it's like a little nesting Russian doll, where the action is also what's being said.

5.179 Yeah, I remember that scene. And isn't that the point at which the student starts to surpass the master? Because he sort of has somewhat mystified and bamboozled Jack, not the other way around? Yeah. So that's a bit of a turning point, isn't it?

5.180 Yes. And so it's the action. Right? And so sometimes things will happen, too, where I'll write an exposition scene. Maybe I didn't think of that frame. Right? So I have the scene between him and Jack, but they're, like, sitting in a truck. Right? And it's like, yeah, I want more. Like, if I think—part of the thinking through scenes is thinking, like, how do you get the character and the movement to be happening with momentum? Momentum's such a key word. How's everything illuminated as we're moving forward in action?

5.181 I couldn't help but think, under that similar heading, suspense. Is suspense built? I mean, I think that's a thing that a lot of writers kind of struggle with. "OK. I think this is interesting. I think it's beautiful. I think it's lyrical. Is it suspenseful?" Where does the suspense come in? I know Dan Brown used that phrase. It's not peculiar to him, of course, the ticking clock.

5.182 Well, Hitchcock's example, of course, is that there's a—you know, if there's a bomb on a table, right, if everyone's sitting around a table and then a bomb goes off and kills

them, you get a jump scare. Right? But if you go and show the ticking clock under the table and then go up to the conversation, you have suspense. Audience is now in the superior position. Right? And we're starting to get nervous. Steven Spielberg discovered something amazing when he shot *Jaws*, right? The damn shark didn't work, and so he's using it kind of sparingly. And there's the first scene when the shark comes out of the water. And he was in a test screening and the audience just, like, left their chairs. Right? I mean, the technology and the scare was terrific. And he loved that. He's like, "I want to go get another scare in there."

- 5.183** So I don't know if you remember the scene where Dreyfuss' character goes down and he's swimming and a head pops out. All of a sudden it's another big jump scare. And the audience jumped like crazy. And then what Spielberg saw, observed, is that when the shark comes after, the audience didn't jump as much. And it was like, "Oh, you only have a limited number of jump scares." Right? So there's a difference between jump scare and building suspense.
- 5.184** There's anticipation that you're focusing on.
- 5.185** Yeah. And now and then, a jump scare, great. But if you're relying on that? Right? And so building suspense is really about building a point of uncomfortableness within the reader in certain ways. And by the way, the other thing, just to tack back to that scene, the sniper scene— there's also times where, like, if there's a bunch of exposition—this is always the hardest thing. I'm going to talk to you guys about exposition dumps. Because when you're writing on anything, the hardest part is, like, I need all the guys to say everything, right? That's the scene in movies where they're like, "OK, Earth is this tennis ball and this banana is the orbit." And right? There's all these ways that we're trying to concretize the action to come, while not having people fall asleep.
- 5.186** But the other thing that's really important is that you think about the motivation of all the characters. And so it's really interesting if you have exposition. If it's not necessarily offset by action, another thing you can do is like, well, it's exposition, but this really is about one student is jealous of another student, or one of the guys in the spec-ops team is jealous of the other one. And as the exposition is coming out, their competition, and who's interrupting who, is almost what you're paying attention to, so that the exposition's dropping in the background, so we don't feel like we walk out and tap the podium. "Here's the exposition we're going to deliver." You distract them.
- 5.187** And those are the best clues, too, right? If you have a clue where it's, like, he came in the house and you list 4 things that are on a table and one of them obviously is a clue to a murder, but so a lot of times you want to move the gaze in another direction. So to give an example, I had a clue that I used in one of the books of what unified—I don't want to give the book away—but there was a key thing that had to be seen. I had to, to play fair with the audience, right, to have my sixth sense contract that everything that is discovered is discoverable by the reader, also, by the time it gets discovered.

- 5.188** You were concealing at the same time.
- 5.189** Yes.
- 5.190** You were burying it.
- 5.191** I had to have a particular company be in evidence in all these different places. And so what I did is, I had a magnet of the company in one of the places that you don't really know, and it was attaching something else to the refrigerator. So if I came in and just said there was a refrigerator with a magnet of blah blah, blah company, it's like glaring, either red herring alert or clue alert. So what I did was I said, "Pinned to the refrigerator beneath a blah blah blah magnet was something else that we think is a clue." So that you're drawing the eye away from that in a way. And so some of the gracefulness when you're writing and creating is that you don't, you're moving, you're moving things in a reasoned way, drawing the eye away in another direction, even literally in how you're conveying that thing.
- 5.192** It's a misdirection to some extent.
- 5.193** Yes. And it's dropping it in quietly and subtly, rather than dropping it in in a way—
- 5.194** Right. Yeah.
- 5.195** Yeah. And so it's like, that's true for exposition, it's true for emotion, it's true for clues. It's true for almost everything, is where are you steering? Where are you putting the reader's attention? Where are you focusing them? And how are you also being fair? So that as they're reading, you don't get to the end and all of a sudden come up with a whole bunch of unsatisfying conclusions that's based on materials that they haven't seen or witnessed or been invited to. The aha moment is when it—when you get there just before them, and they're shocked, and it makes perfect sense because it's been there all along. And there's a moment of undeceiving from the reader, right, where they've arrived, that all the pieces coalesce.
- 5.196** Undeceiving. I mean, I'm gonna have to ask you about the notion of the twist here and whether or not you need a twist. Now, I have seen the film that you scripted, *Sweet Girl*, quite recently, in which there's a tremendous twist. And the thing is, I cannot explain the twist, because it would be a terrible spoiler. There is a big twist. So my—and the twist, I think, by the way, in terms we've already developed, is a variation on the hermeneutic code, I would say. I mean, it's tweaking epistemophilia, because you think you know what is going on, and then you go, "Ah, I didn't know. Now I know." So there's a big turnaround.
- 5.197** Do you feel the need? I mean, certainly, clearly, you had a big twist there. I mean, traumatic twist. Is there a necessity for—crime writer friend of mine, it's all about the twist. That's the thing she works on more than anything else. Not sure you feel that need, but how does that work for you? Do you need a twist, or is that—?

- 5.198** Look, a twist is a tool. It's a key tool, right? You want a twist to be something that's in your bat belt of tools that you're going to use when you approach a thriller. But twists work in different ways. There's smaller twists where it's, is it this one? No, it's this one. A movie, like *The Usual Suspects*, is entirely reliant on the twist in a wonderful way. That's not a criticism. It's one of the great twist endings in cinema history. It's spectacular. But that's a movie that is built and designed for the twist. Well, that's a type of story.
- 5.199** A twist can be something else. A twist can be—Lawrence Block is a wonderful writer. I mean, one of his books ends with his main character, who's walking into an AA meeting and just saying his name, my name, and "I'm an alcoholic." And it was like, that's the thing that had been put off the whole book. So that's not a big aha twist that we're building to and working to and waiting and it's shocking. Right? So there's different gradations and levels of twists, right? There's different types of suspense and cards that turn over in different ways.
- 5.200** But I don't think people should approach, like, everything has to be a M. Shyamalan movie, right? That's something that is *Night's* engagement in the form quite often is building something around a big twist. I've had a few projects like that. *Sweet Girl* certainly is that way. But they also can be in different ways. Like, sometimes the action has subsided and the twist is a big emotional thing that knocks you off guard in a different way. And so the twist is the emotional payoff, but not the plotting payoff.
- 5.201** Having just seen *Where the Crawdads Sing* on the plane coming over here, I'm not going to tell you what happened there because you may or may not have read the book that it's based on, of course. But that is a great twist ending as well. It's almost comparable with *The Usual Suspects*, I think, actually. But we're going to, in terms of twisting, we're going to pause there, have a break, and we'll come back to the climax after break. Thank you.

Lecture 6: Narrative Mastery

At a glance — Narrative mastery.

- 6.1** Gregg, we've spoken about technique, and we've spoken about inspiration, where ideas come from. Is it still true to say that lived experience gets into the novel? I mean, they used to say, didn't they, "Write about what you know"? But, you know, there's a lot of stuff that you do know. But does lived experience, I mean, the places, you know, L.A., San Francisco, does that provide some of the texture of your writing? The kind of the micro level of detail?
- 6.2** Yeah, of course. I think—
- 6.3** It's like a diary to some extent. Well, I mean, it's all about you at some level, but go on.
- 6.4** Well, yeah, I do get to talk for 400 pages uninterrupted, so it's why I'm enjoying being more conversational here. But look, I always laugh when I go to the movies, and it's like a big whatever event. And it says, "inspired by real events." Is anything not inspired by real events? What would that look like? And so people are always writing about themselves. Like, if Stephen King's writing about scary clowns, he's writing about himself. If Philip K. Dick is writing about the future, he's writing about himself. It's impossible not to. Right? We're the assimilating ego of our own lives. We're moving forward, pulling and navigating all the poles. And the stories that occur to us are going to be run through our filters in all those ways.
- 6.5** Yeah, well, they say, or they used to say, don't they, that "style is the man." And I just pulled out. "Style is the man." That somehow your style, you know, if you could analyze it scrupulously enough, you would, you know, obtain—it would be the DNA, would be the whole biology and biography of a writer contained in just a style choice. And there was something that struck me here about some of your style choices. I'm sure people, well, I folded it up anyway.
- 6.6** "They tornadoed down at him." Prodigal Son. "Daniel shot out the end of the alley, knocking over crates of cabbage and pinballing off a dumpster onto the main drag." And this one, which really kind of kills me: "He got off six more rounds, Swiss-cheesing the five-ring of the Transtar." So the thing that struck me there is, of course, how—and I think it's a Shakespearean thing, without wanting to put you under pressure—taking a noun and turning it into a verb or a participle here very often, which struck me. But one thing I've got to ask you. What the hell is a five-ring, anyway, on a Transtar? No idea.
- 6.7** It's a target. It's a shooting target. So it's the five-ring.
- 6.8** That completely bamboozled me. But, OK, I was struck by the Swiss-cheesing kind of line. Is that something, when you're playing around like that, in a way that reminds me a little bit of so Dylan Thomas, the way he'd have this kind of grammatical swerve of

style—is that something you're conscious of or you're just automatic, that you're just thinking in those terms?

- 6.9** It's automatic. I mean, it's very funny that you mentioned Shakespeare, right? So that's called alchemization, right? When you alchemize a word from a noun into a verb, and what's amazing is you can have a word then that's pulling double duty, right? Because "he got off 6 more rounds, like punching holes in the five-ring of the transtars," just describing what it's doing. But Swiss-cheesing is—I mean, look, you look at—
- 6.10** It's built-in metaphor, right?
- 6.11** That's right. And if you look at the process, I think the process of what is superior or closer to the reader and the experience is when you're illuminating notions without belaboring them, right? We talked about that with research. But if you say, you know, "He ran down the street, you know, he was panting like a dog," right? I'm panting. I'm choosing something that it's like. It's a simile. I'm telling you now, by using the word "like", that you're reading writing.
- 6.12** Sometimes they're too perfect, and you just have to use a simile. Right? So this is not, I don't, like, I don't feel as strongly about similes as I do about the necessity for the Oxford comma, for instance. Like, there's a good time and place for similes, but metaphor is better, right? Because then you can say, "He picked up a pace, running jaggedly. He kept up a canine pace." There's a way, all of a sudden, that you start to move it to metaphor and then you start to tighten it. But there's a word, like, "he chased him doggedly." Well, how's that word move into the lexicon? So there's a movement from words that are further out that we pull in more and more.
- 6.13** And Shakespeare, of course, in Hamlet, there's hundreds of words new to the English language. Eyeball, upstairs, sunrise. The words are so logical that we're like, "Of course that should be a word." Bedroom is a new word that he invented. I mean, there's a list of them that are just spectacular. Not even to mention the ones that are witty or clever or have humor in them, right, or the phrases.
- 6.14** We owe bedroom to Shakespeare? I didn't know that. So before that, we said it's the room with a bed in.
- 6.15** Yeah. Or it just wasn't—
- 6.16** That you go to sleep in?
- 6.17** It just wasn't alchemized. And there's a movement of words into greater economy. Right. So a lot of times words will have hyphens for a number of years, and then they'll just come together and not have a hyphen anymore. Right, and so, and there's some that are always in between, like nightstand right now. It depends on which dictionary. Is that two words? Is it one word? But what if you alchemize in a way that's playful? Right?

- 6.18** Another example from a book that I wrote is I said the cop came over, the guy gets pulled over for a ticket, and he had "big, shiny, reflective, failure-to-communicate glasses," right? So that's a line from *Cool Hand Luke*, the famous line of *Cool Hand Luke*. "What we have here is a failure to communicate." It's repeated and repeated, and he's got these big, shiny glasses. And so that's something else where it's like, it's evocative of a cop. It's evocative of a posture. I don't have to describe, "He was tall, he looked down, he was intimidating." But it's also joining with the reader in a way.
- 6.19** And so with Swiss-cheesing, that's something that's active. It's an image. I'm not saying he punched holes in the five-ring of the Transtar so it looked like Swiss cheese. Clunky, right? You're reading writing. "I made a metaphor. Look at me." Right? So by pulling it in and turning it into a verb, it's pulling double duty. And then there's an esthetic to it. Like, there's a coolness to it, I think. I love writers. James Wolcott, who's a wonderful, wonderful writer, written a lot for *Vanity Fair*. He's a journalist. He does a lot of social, cultural commentary. And he's wonderful with this, of picking these perfect words that are— they're so witty and they're so charming and they're always in the right place. And they're often an alchemization that makes something just stand up and come alive.
- 6.20** Now, I know we're going to open up to questions from the audience shortly, but there are a couple of quick things I wanted to get in while I've still got you to myself. We spoke about the beginning and how you plant all these kind of seeds which gradually develop. Is there a rule for the ending as well? What's that great old book, *Sense of an Ending*? Kermode, Frank Kermode, yeah. The denouement.
- 6.21** Do you feel—you know, I can't help but think of *Shane*, that great movie, you know, with the characters, you know, riding away over the horizon or something into the distance at the end of the film. Is there a way, do you feel you need to end on a certain note? Is there a way of pulling things together or leaving them dangling? Do you have a sort of sense of the end of the symphony coming up? How do you approach the ending? Is an ending as hard as a beginning?
- 6.22** There's so much momentum going into an ending, and if you've paid attention and if you've done it properly— again, I keep using this phrase to say, it should be surprising, shocking, but also inevitable. There should be an inevitability to it, but one that's sophisticated enough that it still is surprising. And so when you're talking about gathering everything up, you can have ambiguity, but you better choose it to be ambiguity, not just that you dropped the thread or lost the thread. So you want everything gathered, but that doesn't mean everyone's happy. It doesn't mean everything's solved. It could be that something remains in a purgatorial state that's frustrating, because the world is frustrating.
- 6.23** But there's a certain satisfaction level that must be met within the life of a book, certainly crime fiction, which is what we're predominately talking about. So I won't cliff-hang an entire book without anyone knowing what happened. I did that in my first young adult book a little bit because it was a duology. There was two of them. It's very

aggressively cliff-hangy. But I cliff-hang a lot of the Orphan X books, but only, in my estimation, once I have satisfyingly concluded the story that's told, and then I sometimes will flip over another card that's indicating what the next adventure or mission or book is going to be.

- 6.24** But there's a level of satisfaction that's required. But Dennis Lehane is one of my favorite writers. I mean, he wrote a book called *Gone, Baby, Gone* that's exquisite. And his endings often are ambiguously difficult in ways that they're concluded. The undeceiving is finished, but the outcome is not wholly morally satisfying. And we're left with a view of the world about what's possible. Even as somebody operates with their code upon the world, we still wind up with results sometimes that are confounding. But the completion is complete in the undeceiving, and the characters might have to realize that their engagement with the world can't carry the world as far as they want into alignment with their code. That's still an ending with ambiguity, but no threads are dropped there. It's just not satisfying. It doesn't wrap up everything.
- 6.25** Right. So you're trying to be fair to the reader. One thing I've been struck by in your—perhaps we can come back to the question—pronouns, actually, although I know maybe you want to address it quickly, because I sort of want to come back to your different genres that you're working with in. But OK, pronouns. Just because this question was raised the other day of pop culture, there's an anxiety about—I refer, of course, to personal pronouns in particular, actually. I think we're all OK with it.
- 6.26** This friend of mine in New York said he was planning to write a novel in which it was going to be first person, but he would speak like the Queen used to speak, so it would be "one did this" and "one did that," and that's very French, because they use this pronoun "on" all the time, or very frequently to replace, you know, well, "I, he, we." So they have this one pronoun. Maybe we're heading in that direction. I'm not sure. Maybe all characters in the future will be "they", just be on the safe side. But I know you, you're still fairly happy with "he" and "she" and "they" as distinct from. You don't have a problem with these.
- 6.27** Well, so here's the thing. We're at this moment in the culture in a lot of regards, that, for me, there's a way that language functions for me, that works, that I work with. Evan is a male. I use male pronouns. I do the same with—and there's not the same sort of tense issue. If I was writing, I assume you're referring to the transgender issue, if I was writing a character who's transgender, who identifies as a male, I would say "he", but I don't want to get into grammatical confusion that people don't know what's happening.
- 6.28** And I don't want to also overextend to start to use pronouns in a way that then—because it's an issue that has not been negotiated and resolved within the culture, I think we can say that fairly from all sides—my using of a pronoun in a particular way for the sake of using it in a particular way is, in fact, a signaling of an allegiance with a tribe, immediately. And I don't want to do that. I'm writing a book. I have a different focus.

Right? And so I'm not going to go out of my way to appropriate something that is having a difficult negotiation in the culture in a way that's signaling a very clear perspective on it, because then a lot of people will read the book as propaganda, because I'm making a point that's about the culture. And it might even screw up the tenses within the book.

- 6.29** But, I mean, I'd be happy to write a trans character if it was relevant to the plot, and that's what occurred. But then it would adhere to the rules that make the story and my unfolding of the story the most—my perception of the most beautiful and compelling within my esthetic. That's, my esthetic is what's the governing. My top allegiance has to always be to that over the political or the culture. Or the cultural.
- 6.30** I take your point about the tribe. I forget which writer now said, you know, "I don't want to kind of specify my audience because I want everyone to read it," not a particular constituency of it.
- 6.31** But it's not just that. But it's that, of course, because you don't want to alienate people. Like there's a certain amount of pragmatics, but also it alters what you're doing. It alters the work itself and my job. I don't just mean pronouns, but I mean, let's say that I use a phrase that's a captured phrase. We have so many of them now, right?
- 6.32** What are you thinking about, for example?
- 6.33** Cuck. Woke.
- 6.34** Right? OK.
- 6.35** I mean, there's dozens of them on every side, right? Pick an insult. Regressive, socialist left. Bible-thumping right.
- 6.36** Labels.
- 6.37** Yeah, but they're labels that are captured and they're dead. So they're stones that you throw against somebody. It's not an incisive assessment of some point of idiocy on the left that's described in unique language that illuminates it, or the same for the right. They're phrases like, "Oh, he's mansplaining." Right? If you use that earnestly, it's a piece of armor. It's an armoring place to insert oneself into an argument. It's a way to dismiss somebody.
- 6.38** It's not necessarily a helpful description.
- 6.39** Well, it's also like, I'd rather describe somebody who's very, very boorish in their explanation and overbearing, who happens to be male, because there are men who do that. And show how they appropriate space and push in and they're forceful. Right, I'll show that, and have one character who does that. And so I don't want to use phrases that start to limit what the work is by dint of kind of aligning them. My job's not to use clichés. I don't ever want to say, you know, "He fell like a tree. He went down like a ton of bricks." It's not my job to do that either, right? That's writing. I'm writing with

something that's received. So be clever, be inventive, be original. Have the writer in a process of experiencing and thinking and engaging with the story in a way that's new.

- 6.40** So, yeah, you want to describe someone who's misogynistic? Have at it. There are misogynistic people. Me writing and not writing about them doesn't make that the case. You want to talk about somebody who's a radicalized, chaotic anarchist? Great. Write that character and make them real and show who they are. Don't use preloaded terms that's flattened out and three-dimensionalize this so that all of a sudden we're trading cards. We're not engaging in a story.
- 6.41** I think, if I remember correctly, that great book of yours, *The Crime Writer*, Gregg allows Andrew Danner, his crime writer alter ego, I think, every now and then to write things because he's writing the story as he's living it, to use the occasional clichés. And you have the editor come along, who's like a sidekick of his, and scribble, you know, in the margins, literally, of the book. So don't download an e-book. It's much better to get the real book, I think. And the editor will say, "Oh, come on, you gotta come up with something better." You know, there's like "a ton of bricks" metaphor in there or "like a Swiss cheese" or something. And the editor goes, "Come on, man, you're better than this."
- 6.42** And so to give an example, like, mansplaining's a word that Joey might use if she's making fun of Evan and using it slightly, with a slight measure of self-awareness, right? Like, "Quit mansplaining. We're doing that," where she's aware, in using the term, that she's making fun of it and poking him with it in a way that's not legitimate.
- 6.43** Right. She's a vehicle or a channel for, to some extent, popular culture.
- 6.44** In a lot of ways. Well, everybody is because we have a lot of different popular cultures. Right? But so where, it's also like, is the narrator using it? Is the narrator using it earnestly? Is the narrator privileging a particular worldview in a way that feels captured? Right? That's a different question than having characters banter and play and use terms.
- 6.45** I mean, I've been struck, I was going to say, by the, you know, these different genres that you're working in, and movies, of course, but also comics. And just struck by this, in *Dark Horse*, obviously, which is a novel: "Reymundo was poleaxed, his expression migrating to sheer wonder, as if he'd just witnessed something from the pages of a comic book." And you who jumped between, and I was impressed by the number of different projects you're working on simultaneously, often in quite different genres.
- 6.46** Do you feel yourself tempted? I mean, I think because we've put the emphasis on the book here and on your novels. When you're working within a novel, are you tempted by the comic book in particular? Do you think, OK, we need it. This is a kind of Batman-type scene here, or Penguin scene, as the case may be, or do you think, OK, there's a kind of movie technique which one can use. I mean, the cut or the jump cut, as the case

may be. I mean, do you feel yourself, you know, bestriding those genres or, you know, hopping, hopping between them?

- 6.47** It's not a temptation. Like, if I'm, it's—let's use a sports metaphor, right? If I'm playing basketball, I'm not tempted to bring a baseball bat onto the basketball court, right? But if I've been working out and doing all kinds of training in baseball and running the bases, my stamina is going to be better for basketball. And so there's, and some pivots or some coordination or some tricks, but when I'm writing something, I'm in that thing, I'm not thinking. Stories really suggest themselves to me clearly, if something's a novel, if something's a screenplay. I've been pretty lucky. I haven't had a lot of ideas where I'm like, "Oh, it could be anything. What should I choose?" They tend to impose themselves on me with a form.
- 6.48** But there's a lot I learned, I told you guys already, that with comics, the fact that you have to limit even more acutely than in film, what you can show, that gave me a lot of ideas for novels. Do I show the before? Do I show the after only? Do I skip the main thing? Do I only show the main thing but slow it down and describe it in every detail?
- 6.49** And in film, one thing that's really useful—you know, every scene that's not essential in film gets left on the cutting room floor, or it should, because it costs so much money. Right? Or TV. Like I said, you're shooting. It's a quarter-million dollars a day. Speaking, by the way, of writer's block, like, you're not allowed to have writer's block if you're gonna shut down a micro economy, right, as a result of doing it.
- 6.50** That is a case where they're filming while you're writing, effectively?
- 6.51** Yeah. You're behind and, right, I mean, that's me writing. That's right.
- 6.52** Come up with the next thing.
- 6.53** But a whole economy. Right. There's gaffers and there's caterers. There's actors and there's agents. And so there's a certain responsibility there. But I got, I lost the thread. Where were we before I detoured off?
- 6.54** What were you talking about? Yeah, the possibility of comic books and movies. And you were saying that you're not going to bring a baseball bat along to the basketball game. So that you—
- 6.55** Yeah. So the techniques, that's what we were saying. So comics kind of taught me that. Film, what I was saying, is that you won't ever have a scene that doesn't really drive the plot forward. It's two characters talking, and it's in a new location that you haven't already used. Right? Because there's all this stuff. It's like, that's another location move. The cameras have to set up again. You need transportation. Right? It pushes out a day. So it's like, wait, why do we have one random scene at a post office? Like, can't that be in the foyer of the building? Can we tack it onto this scene?
- 6.56** So there's so many considerations around the physicality of shooting a scene that it demands that a screenplay is unbelievably tight. Well, it turns out that that

constriction, much like first person, which is very limiting, but there's different things you can do in first person. I mean, *The Crime Writer* is very much a mystery because it's first person. The audience needs to be in a position of inferiority. There needs to be a big twist in a certain way. But so, you know, I take that to the novels, right? I don't want my novels to have a lot of excess and fat. Now, there's some more play I can have. There's more thinking. I can add a little funny scene here.

- 6.57** My budget's unlimited, right? If I type, you know, 400 Ferraris blowing up, it costs the same as if I have them driving an Uber. It's the same, right? There's no limitation in comics on budget, but that notion of make everything work, make everything compound, make everything hold together in a scene, do as much as you can with everything all the time—I've tightened, I've worked that muscle out a lot in screenplays, so it informs the novels, even if I allow myself to be more expansive in them. So there's always, there's lessons in everything that we're doing and working on if we're paying attention.
- 6.58** You know, talking to you, you're quite a funny guy. Do you, you know, you've got these great moments of humor, especially in *The Crime Writer*, I think, actually. And there are certain lines that make me laugh out loud. What's your approach to humor in the thriller? Is that almost kind of, like, semi-prohibited or you're allowed?
- 6.59** Humor should, humor should never be prohibited.
- 6.60** Right. OK.
- 6.61** Humor's truth and humor's a veil.
- 6.62** Right.
- 6.63** So humor is a way that you—look, in the Shakespearean court, the jester was the only one who's allowed to speak the truth. Right? Because he hides it. It's indirect. He can make fun of the king, and everyone kind of knows, "Oh, the king's obese and he likes food," and he can kind of mime that, but everyone's laughing, so it's OK. Right? But God help you if you want to go up and have an indication about the obesity of the king that's direct, right? You have to bring things in through angles.
- 6.64** So people communicate to each other constantly that way. And I don't have very many friendships that a big part of the engagement isn't humor. So in a way, Evan doesn't either. His humor is much more buttoned down. But, like, Tommy's really funny, Joey's really funny. They also have distinct senses of humor that work in different ways. So there's kind of—here's my rule on humor. Something either has to be laugh-out-loud funny or give you—actually, an editor friend of mine, Jess Taylor, who I based the editor in *The Crime Writer*—
- 6.65** Oh, yeah.
- 6.66** Had this theory once. So I'm appropriating this from him. It was a great piece of advice. He was my kind of a freelance editor and my one-time agent. But he said, "Either

something makes you laugh, where you just bust out laughing, or there's a thing where you have this internal moment of a private, like, huh, that's clever." Like, where it really catches you and you're like, clever. Anything that's not those two, I don't want to have in a book. I don't want any joke that's standard. I don't want any, you know, like, "Right, ma'am, we have to search you." "Don't you want to buy me dinner first?"

6.67 Like, any plug-in humor or anything that you're like, OK. Anything that's going to require polite laughter, even in the internal thinking of a character, people will do that sometimes where someone will have some joke, right? Like, "I've had it with Starbucks and all these different sizes of the ordering cups," and generic humor that doesn't really do something if it doesn't make you pop with the cleverness and kind of go, "OK, that's clever," or really hit you. So those are the things. And then there's, of course, the situational stuff where you're just deadpanning. Like, when Evan gets his boots stuck on the bed and falls over and the phone rings and he answers it from his back and says, "Do you need my help?" Like, when he's, like, stuck on the floor, it's just straight situational humor.

6.68 Yeah, yeah.

6.69 Right.

6.70 OK, so that. All right, so that's possible. And while we're on the subject of tricky things, and this might be my last question to you, actually, before we open it up, I've got to ask you about—I mean, you gave me some good advice earlier on flirting and what not to do. I've got to ask you about sex scenes and how you handle sex scenes. And in England, you can win a prize. It's the bad sex prize, which goes to writers once a year for the worst written sex scene. I don't think you've been up for that. And I believe Lee Child won it one year. He was quite embarrassed about that for his book, *The Affair*. Worth looking at, nevertheless.

6.71 But, I mean, if I remember with Evan, has he—I hope I'm not giving too much away. Has he reverted to, you know, this kind of monastic sublimation?

6.72 No.

6.73 He hasn't. Because he's this monk-like character at the beginning, that's withdrawn from society and indeed contact, unless he happens to be in a fight.

6.74 Look, when Evan was 15, 16, Jack literally had him trained also with prostitutes because he was, like, "You can't lose your mind over women. I'm sending you into all these other areas. You think you cannot know about that? And you will treat them with respect. And here's why." Right? "Here's why, strategically. Here's why, morally. Like, they're clean, it's safe, you're gonna go. But you need to understand this part of yourself." Right? He's trained to be a tool that is a weapon. So you can't send somebody out to do spy work without any notion of women or fully abstaining.

6.75 So he can have sex, but he's not allowed to fall in love with anyone?

- 6.76** Yeah, he doesn't. I mean, he has an ongoing, complicated relationship with Mia. His relationship with Candy is complicated. He's had a number of kind of one-night stands that have been written about through the course of the books. But it's—everything is with the utmost respect, and Jack, like, breaks it down for him. "Here's why you will be respectful. Also, countries that it's a strategic imperative, and American imperative, because countries that treat women well perform better financially and economically." Like, he connects the whole argument to him of, like, "You're gonna have this engagement, and you're gonna approach it in a proper way." So Evan is very much a gentleman with women. It's a big part of his identity, and it's a big aspect of what was trained into him.
- 6.77** Right. So would you say that, to some extent, the same applies in this realm as to what you were discussing earlier? The ticking bomb? You're better to have the ticking clock than the bomb actually going off? The big bow?
- 6.78** Meaning, like, Evan gets married and settles down and? Yeah, nobody wants that. Everyone thinks they want that, but it's like, it's Moonlighting, the TV show, Moonlighting. Right? It's like the flirtation is so much of it.
- 6.79** I don't know that.
- 6.80** Bruce Willis, amazing TV show. At the center of it was a constant flirtation.
- 6.81** Right, OK.
- 6.82** Cybill Shepherd, right? Between him and Cybill Shepherd. And it was this—they had unbelievable chemistry, but they were never together, and they're solving cases. It was a very, like, 80s TV show.
- 6.83** Right. Sure.
- 6.84** But the minute that they get together, it's like something gets lost. But it's like, you know, with Evan, I don't know. I could write some angry Cormac McCarthy story when I'm, like, 80, that he's, like, in a shack with a wife and a kid and, like, do the whole. Take it a whole route. But that's, it's very different. So for the moment, his engagement with his own world precludes him from having—I mean, he has this conversation overtly with Mia. That's the single woman who lives downstairs from him, says, like, parts of him aren't real. She doesn't know what to do with that. It's an engagement that's romantic and it's wonderful and it's appealing.
- 6.85** And he does things that other people can't do. And she's been in a couple situations where he's had to intercede with the full lethality of his purpose. So she kind of has a sense of who he is, but they can't ever really talk about it. But he's in another realm that, at the one hand, is alluring and palatable to her, but on the other hand, she's like, "It's also weird—like, you're not real the way other people are real. And I don't know what to do with that fully. Like, how do we do that with me still feeling like I'm my own emotional self in this relationship?"

- 6.86** So he's always an outsider in a way, and I don't shy away from his engagement with the quotidian and how complex that is. It's another iteration of him not knowing how to be in the elevator with Ida Rosenbaum, who's squawking about oil leaks in the garage, and he's trying to hold a knife wound together. Right? The engagement with the real for him is a constant challenge, and that extends to settling down.
- 6.87** OK, I'm going to ask you one more question, having said that, that was the last one. So on behalf of writers and would-be writers, moreover, pitching a story, because I think perhaps that's the most difficult thing. In other words, how do you pitch a whole story on the back of an envelope? Or how do you sell an idea? And you mentioned how hard it is for writers to get going, and you were saying that difficulty is not doing a degree in writing or creative writing, but actually what you do at the end of it.
- 6.88** That first step of getting through the door with a pitch, which you've probably done literally, perhaps with films, where you walk through the door and say, "I've got this great idea and what do you think about that?" And maybe it goes well, maybe it doesn't go well. I'm not sure. But is there, you know—can you give any advice for that?
- 6.89** On pitching?
- 6.90** Yeah.
- 6.91** So here's some advice. I'll go back to the second commandment. "How you do anything is how you do everything." Every single aspect of your creative life, every single aspect of it should reflect the esthetic of your work. Right? So it's funny because I had a friend who wasn't a writer, who sent me, like, a treatment for a TV show, and the treatment's written, like, describing it all, like a Wikipedia entry, and it's like, well, no, that's it. But when we write it, it's gonna be amazing, and this will be wonderful. And it's like you're not—when you're writing, you're not evoking the mood of the thing that you're doing. Right?
- 6.92** So don't fool yourself into thinking that your words and engagement on a pitch are the things that matters as much as your nervous system being engaged in the story as you're telling it with genuine excitement. It's like anything, right? Anything we care about, we give ourselves to fully. And so the best piece of—because there's a bunch of stuff. There's plenty of material available to tell you how to build a pitch and how to do that, and you can go find it. But the advice that I would give that's the most useful is, everything is an aspect of your presentation. Everything is an aspect of your work when you're in that role. And so make sure that you kind of fulfill that, that you find the excitement, that you hold it to a standard of excellence and that it's reflecting and embodying the same style and aspect of the work.
- 6.93** That's true, kind of top to bottom for things, right? Like, that's what we're talking about with ritual, in a way. You know, how you, how we dress matters. How do you dress to go do yoga? How do you dress to play soccer? How do you dress if you have an event, right? It's all the parts of you. And so people sometimes are like, "Oh, well, that's

marketing, or that's a pitch. Or I can just describe this. Or my idea is, nah, nah, nah, nah." It's like, everything should have and contain the esthetic of the thing that you're trying to describe as best you can. It's really hard. I'm not suggesting it's easy.

- 6.94** It's tough advice, because you're saying it's no good writing a great book. You can't write a great one page synopsis.
- 6.95** Or at least write it in the style, even if it's not great, where maybe it's in the style of voice, maybe it has attitude, right? Maybe there's got to be just something in it that's a point of connection, right?
- 6.96** Yeah. It's got to excite the reader.
- 6.97** But maybe before we move to questions, I was thinking about, like, we should talk a little about why we are doing this course here. What's the use of this course? Because part of this is, we're not doing this, and a lot of people who are watching this, a lot of people who are engaging with this are not simply hoping to be bestselling thriller writers, right? Or write and get produced movies. So we're having engagement around a topic which is writing and story-telling. And we've talked a bit about marketing. We've talked about some other aspects and ways that stories shape things.
- 6.98** But it's really important to remember, like, I think that one of America's greatest inventions is the liberal arts education, right? It's like bourbon, jazz, liberal arts education, right? And part of it is we forget in a lot of ways, because the way that education's kind of bifurcating, that we tend to think of things as sort of, like, on task. Take a writing course to then be a professional writer and to move on. And part of that is, some of you here are very serious writers, right? Some of you here want to do that and to progress and all the advice is for that.
- 6.99** But keep in mind, when you take a history class, it's not so you become a historian. Right? When you take a math class, it's not because you want to be a professional mathematician. And so there's something that's really important here, I think, at multiple levels, that's important to kind of talk about, which is, look, if you're an aspiring writer, great. We've talked about a lot of things. You have a lot of tools, but maybe you're a reader and you want to enjoy and embark in your reading with more joy and to see different aspects of the way that the craft and the art function. Or maybe you're in marketing and you're thinking about stories in different ways. There's pieces to take from it.
- 6.100** And the other thing I would say is that you can also practice. Right? Like, you can be a hobbyist. Right? There's a bunch of discipline that's required advice I'm giving if somebody wants to be a professional writer. But there's an enormous amount of meaning that people find in writing in all sorts of ways. It could be journal entries or short stories. And so the strictness of discipline that I'm talking about at a professional level, I think it's really important to pull out and talk about also at kind of a liberal arts level, which is, often with the liberal arts education, you're taking all these courses not

to have a job, right, not to have a hard skill. I always joke that I would have done way better when I graduated undergrad with all my degrees, if I'd taken a certificate course in graphic design. I actually could have got a job because they're not interested in jobs.

- 6.101** Part of education, part of education is to say, we're training you to be a visionary. We're training you to think. We're training your brain to be able to approach reality and subject matter from so many different perspectives that it's like the Nude Descending a Staircase, right? It's like Cubism, where you're able to kind of rotate all around something. And writing, I think, is such an essential and engaging skill for people to engage as part of that at different levels. And so write a story. See if you like it, right? Spend a half hour twice a week, if it's not 2 hours twice a week. There's a whole host of ways that this form and understanding this form and taking enjoyment from it and dipping your foot into it as a subject can kind of open up more things around the world.
- 6.102** And so I just think it's important because we're here in an educational capacity, that we don't turn this into something that the only key is for mass commercial success, because the frames that we're using here can be engaged in illuminating in one's own life and in any writing that we do, if we write to know what we think, right? That's always a part of that and to apply to all these other disciplines.
- 6.103** So I think there's a structure that we just want to open up and make sure that people understand, that this is stuff that's intended to have points of access in any ways that are relevant and take and choose what you want. And the sterner aspects of my discussion around discipline is for if that's something that people want to pursue professionally.
- 6.104** It's a very good point, because I think that provides a kind of a take on that book I've mentioned a couple of times, Peter Brooks, *Seduced by Story*, where he talks about the storification of reality. And I think what you're saying is, I mean, so he gives a simple example of that, by the way, in case you're wondering, because he said he just bought a packet of cookies, and he finds looking at the—and those of you who are doing advertising might be partly responsible for this. And he sees before he even gets a cookie out of the packet that there's a whole story on the side of the packet, which is "our story," how, and the cookies' story, how these cookies came to be and the whole deep background and so on.
- 6.105** So everyone, especially in the political, the public realm, I think, everyone has a story now, as if that's the crucial thing more than, shall we say, truth, the truth of cookies. And I wonder if what you're talking about, the approach to story, equips you with a kind of critical intelligence in approaching so that one is perhaps not quite so seduced, necessarily. You still want to be seduced, perhaps by stories, but to have a certain kind of perspective on those stories.
- 6.106** The alignment and approach to doing anything with excellence, with proper intentions and motivations, can lead to the same sources and founts of wisdom. You can stack

them right on top of each other. Right? And I do this a lot, I talk about this a lot in Orphan X, right? Like, if he has a knot in his arm that he has to work out in a particular pose, right? If we have an injury, the muscle tightens around it, and if you don't pay attention to it, more muscle tightens around it, and more muscle tightens around it. And, well, that's what happens with political thinking, with ideology. That's what happens emotionally with trauma, right?

- 6.107** The Freudian cathartic process is to go in deep to the thing that is the most painful and expose it with excruciating pain, to liberate it. Well, that's if you have a trigger point. And you're getting a painful massage, it's the same thing. And so with writing, what I'm hoping that we're illuminating is that to take the topic really seriously and to try to engage in it thoughtfully, right, involves a—it's a discourse within yourself, within different parts of yourself, and the world and a craft, but it should be illuminating for everything.
- 6.108** And so, yes, I think that if you think about story and persuasion and manipulation and what are ways that we use language to elicit emotion in people, you can think about that next time you turn on cable news. You can think about that in the course of your own life, of what is the story that you're defining within yourself, right? And so there's a lot of reasons—I feel like we're at a place now where we have so much definitional collapse within the culture. Like, words don't even mean what they mean anymore, right? Like, what's left and what's right? And things are just so upside-down that it's important to kind of talk foundationally again about, and to sort of reset in certain ways, first principles.
- 6.109** And so one of the first principles here is that writing is immensely important. It's an immensely important way that you organize your thinking and that you organize yourself. And when applied creatively, that you're projecting in a manner and learning about yourself and practicing different modes of being. Right? And then applying certain tools of being unique, not using captured language. There's so many aspects of it that can be applied elsewhere, and so if you practice it in earnest, it's a wonderful mode of entry. It can be all things.
- 6.110** Talking of pain, I was reminded, actually, I mentioned that story of how I missed my subway stop reading one of Gregg's books. And I remember what the scene was now, talking about the pain. It's where the hero has just been impaled on some steel bar or something like that. And most of the chapter was to do with dis-impaling himself off this flipping construction—I think he's on some kind of construction site. It's underground, and I think that's what was compelling me. But there's the pain. One shouldn't forget the pleasure of the text, and it has been a tremendous pleasure reading your works. But can I throw it open to the floor? I'm sure you've got lots of questions. Over here? That now we need the mic.
- 6.111** So I have three questions that are related with the difference. Do you want to hear all three, or do you want to go one by one?

- 6.112** Let's go one by one.
- 6.113** All three of them had to do with constructing characters and the plot, especially around morality. So the first one is, I realized that I think that, like the most compelling characters, for example, antagonists, are those with who the audience maybe likes their personality or even agrees with the ideology, but disagrees with their actions, and with protagonist, kind of like vice versa. Maybe they don't like who they are as a person, but they do agree with what they're doing. So my question is that, how do you find a good balance between a character's personality and their actions to make them more compelling for the story?
- 6.114** That's an interesting question. It's a very interesting way to break that down. I hadn't thought of it as such. So in terms of liking or not liking a character, I'm less interested in that than if you—if I'm trying to write characters that people find compelling or that they're fascinated by. And I think if you have those two traits, then you have curiosity, and then you have allure, and you can lean into them. And what you're describing is a really, it's a very thoughtful way to differentiate things, like a character who you agree with a lot morally, and they're doing bad things, that's very interesting. You want to know more about that because there's a tension that's there that you've set in place. But I step back to what is compelling? Right? Compelling is my point of entry. Not necessarily, "Do you like them? Are they nice or are they kind?"
- 6.115** You mentioned Evan. Just to clarify, I haven't read your books. So I don't know if you do, like, going to details within your narrative. So I'm just gonna ask that. Is that, for example, yesterday you mentioned that he does not care about perspective on global scale. He only focuses on the personal, on the local. So he doesn't take into account what his actions might do on a global scale. He only cares about the personal.
- 6.116** A little bit different. He cares about his actions. He doesn't, he doesn't fix global problems. He fixes individual, on the ground, concrete problems that he can see, in effect.
- 6.117** OK, so related to that, is that, so when it comes to the character's moral codes, like, for example, that he cares about fixing stuff that he can see on the ground—so how far, when constructing to make them more compelling or a more compelling plot, how far do you question that character's moral code, by showing the repercussions of their actions in the story?
- 6.118** You should show the repercussions of actions when appropriate. I can't do it every time. If he's killing a bunch of people on his way into, like, a cartel entry, I can't stop and do that. But I like those things to be reflected in a broader way. So we should see some of the outcome and income. Or else you're just kind of reading an action hero.
- 6.119** And the other question is also with the moral codes, is that, how do you separate the characters between protagonists and antagonists when it comes to the morality or their actions? How do you separate those two?

- 6.120** I separate them around their specific impact with the concrete details of the story. Right? Because I could have my antagonist go off and have a lovely exchange in a cafe after. And that could be his whole story. But in the story that I'm writing, with the events that happen, what are the choices that they're making in relation to those events and to each other? Right? That's what makes them fall. It's not a theoretical thing that I've sort of dreamed up overall. So characters' engagement in story and action is always key.
- 6.121** My question was, how do we write for new audiences? And should we alter our technique to, I guess, accommodate for sensitive audiences? What's the right way to do that?
- 6.122** What's the right way to accommodate for sensitive audiences? So there's this very odd tension that we're having right now. Because one of the points of art is to illuminate and to challenge and to make uncomfortable. Right? Art's not there to make sensitive people feel safer. It's there to speak to sensitive people in certain ways, to open them up to different ideas and notions. Now, there's been this acceleration in the culture, of course, of concepts like sensitivity readers and cultural appropriation. And the rule I settled on for myself, I noticed initially I was very kind of reactive to the topic in general because I'm very territorial about my writing and my process and what's going to infect that.
- 6.123** You didn't want a sensitivity reader, or you object to sensitivity readers?
- 6.124** Yeah. Well, I'll explain how I've chosen to approach it, right? So I look back, and culture evolves in different ways, right? Like, I'll look back to characters that I wrote at the beginning of my career. I've been writing now for decades, which is weird. And I'm like, wow, I wrote this character, but it was very much from, like, my perception of that cultural element, right? Like, I didn't, I didn't dive in deep enough. OK, that's not something I'm gonna, like, self-flagellate about and that it, like, that I committed some horrific sin because I didn't write about guns as well either. I didn't write about Los Angeles as well either. Right? I was accessing different people and modes and having all of them feel less three-dimensionalized as I was developing.
- 6.125** And as I get older, and ideally better, the aim that I'm trying to kind of guide to is that I want to have a sophisticated and honest engagement with different people and characters and cultures. My culture is explosively diverse. I live in California. I mean, it's like every color, every orientation, so many nationalities, so many places on the political spectrum. I have just an explosively diverse environment, truly diverse, meaning all the way around the gamut. I'm not going to just write stories that are about me. I don't want to do that. That doesn't reflect my life. It doesn't reflect my personal community. And when I'm writing about other people, I don't want to also reduce them to equations.

- 6.126** And part of formal sensitivity reading can be that, like, "Is this character sexualized, and this character isn't sexualized?" And "how many characters are of this ethnicity? And how many are that ethnicity?" It turns it into math in a certain way, and it's not math. And so the rules that I, that I have in place that keep evolving now are, I will write about a culture when I understand that culture lovingly. And that doesn't mean that I write lovingly about the culture, but it means that somewhere that will be expressed that I know and have engaged with it. So Dark Horse, I have all sorts of like cartel, Mexican violence, everything else. I grew up in California. I have, I have a Mexican aunt. I have Mexican friends. The level of integration of that culture within my life and community is extensive.
- 6.127** And so if I'm writing with the one side, you can also really see in other places that I'm writing with a knowledge and a lovingness around that culture, that it's not all one-dimensionalized. And I'm also not going to make everyone a saint if they have, like, a particular skin tone. That's no longer writing characters. But I really want to get things right with everything. We talked about it. Like, I'll go watch somebody carve up a cadaver. I'll watch somebody, I'll go up on a stunt airplane. And so with Dark Horse, just to give you an example, what I prefer to do is to cover that base, but from a much higher, from a higher position that's more aligned with my morality as a writer.
- 6.128** And so I have a dear friend of mine is called Luis Urrea. He's Pulitzer-nominated for Devil's Highway. He's one of our great Mexican-American writers. He's one of our great writers, period. But he's an incandescently brilliant writer and he's a friend and he loves thrillers. And so it was very easy for me to say to him, "I want to make sure I got all this stuff right." And we're friends with respect for each other's craft. So he's not going to come back at me with equations, but he's like, "No, you spelled this wrong. And that slang here, we'd do that. And who says this? Like, we don't call it, we don't call this chicano this way."
- 6.129** And it's engaging like I would with a car expert, if I'm writing about a car, or gun expert, when I'm writing about a gun. I want to make sure that I have that right, because if not, I'm tone-deaf. And so if I'm holding myself to the highest account as an artist, the way that I do about other topics, I don't want to approach a culture wrongly or dumbly, right? And any more than I want to talk about L.A. wrongly or dumbly when I'm choosing what images I'm going to write about Los Angeles. But that doesn't mean coming from a sense of, like, reverence and apology to engage with the culture in a way that I either have to, like, revere it or else be fearful that I'm being disparaging of it either. But it means you want to get things right.
- 6.130** And if things wind up where I'm writing a character flat in a way—like, there's, there's certain phrases we don't always know how they hit other people. It's like, I'm fine to hear about that. "This phrase this way, this was offensive." It's happened here and there with something. And it's like, OK, I'm a writer. I'm writing to a broad community. I'm happy to hear from that broad community that I'm writing to and can take things

into account. But it hasn't happened very much. I've been shown a lot of grace by my readership. And I think part of that is that I write and approach cultures— it's not with respect, it's really with love. I really love a lot of these different cultures, and I'm not going to write about one that I've predetermined merely to be bad.

6.131 So you don't get too much blowback then. I mean, I was just thinking in light of your question, a couple of books I've read recently. Farewell, My Lovely. I think that was full of Mexican stereotypes. And I actually felt a certain discomfort myself. And if I'd been a sensitivity reader of Chandler's work, I would have, "Oh, come on, man. You're gonna have to rewrite that." Too late now, of course. Similarly, Moby Dick. "Come on. A whale is not a fish, man. You need to replace the word fish by mammal. Can we get that straight?" You know, if you go, you know, like Victorians on Shakespeare. No. Come on. We can have some happy ending.

6.132 So the question is, who are your interlocutors? Right? When I'm writing this scene in Dark Horse, I'm calling people who are my friends. I'm calling people who have great slang. I'm calling people who I play sports with and go to family events with. And then when I'm going to turn over my project that is a piece of writing, that's a novel, I want to get it—if I have the opportunity to get it—in the hands of somebody who's a brilliant master practitioner of the form of writing. It's so far above what, like, a sensitivity reader who has whatever training from whatever program is going to come and apply to the text. It's like, I almost want to just go above all of that, in a certain regard, within the realm of—and by above, I mean in my personal moral hierarchy of how I approach my craft and my role.

6.133 And for me, what is above that's sacrosanct is my role as a writer. Right? I don't want to have other things come in where it's like, "Oh, I did it to, you know, I have a degree in this and I'm going to do a report on this." And it's like, OK, it's a piece of data. Let me talk to people who I admire greatly up here. Let me make sure I'm getting things right. So it's not like you can just react against it and go, "Oh, there's all this woke stuff and forget all of it. And I'm just going to write everything from my perspective," because it's like, if you're writing stuff that's flat or tone-deaf or offensive to a culture, you at least should kind of know you're doing it or have a character be doing that, knowing that they're doing it. You want to know more, like, you want to know what all those tools are called. So the education process is, it's important to approach, but it's also important not to subjugate your role as a writer to prevailing cultural times. And that's tricky.

6.134 Yeah, it sounds as though you've got director's cut on your books, I guess. There were questions over this side.

6.135 And we have one—did you have a question up front? Let's go up front. And then we go to the side.

6.136 OK.

- 6.137** So in the age of AI, with technology like chatGPT, and that can write coherent chapters in seconds, how can writers expect to compete? And what kind of long-term impact do you think this will have?
- 6.138** Oh, boy. I've been thinking about this and talking about this nonstop for— so I'm the co-president of International Thriller Writers, and we've been having a lot of conversations about this, and I don't think anybody can give an answer to AI right now with great confidence, because any answer that I give, I could generate 10 versions of me through AI having an argument about AI, and then that'll have an exponential impact on whatever answer can be given. We don't know what's coming. As of yet, and in this moment, the quality of writing feels like it's, it's the mean, it's average. I asked it to write Orphan X dialogue; it was terrible. But it's coming, and it's coming very fast.
- 6.139** And so I've been thinking about this a lot, and part of my responsibility for International Thriller Writers is to be protective of writers, right? And there are arguments that I feel about ways that novels should express an individual human perspective through a work and through a work in time. But the question becomes very complicated of, like, well, what constitutes using AI? Like, if you search Google, you're using AI. And if I go on chat—I started to go on to play with it a little bit—and if you ask, like, "How do you turn on a meat grinder for a torture scene?", it'll describe it exactly, instead of me having to go to websites and pull specs and read them. And then if I take two of the three of the words in a row, are those technically words that are written by AI, even though I'm using them for research? And is it different from me talking to a researcher?
- 6.140** So it's very hard to figure out. I'm always a little tentative about slippery-slope arguments because I feel like they're a bit of a refuge for the weak-minded since we have to exist on slippery slopes. But I don't have a handle right now on when and how that'll work. I am arriving at a couple things that are perhaps solutions to the issue for myself, feeling protective about the form as a essentially human form and about the writing community, which I also feel protective of because I want to foster writers who are coming up. And I think that the unique perspective of an individual making something and carrying that through is important.
- 6.141** So I think that one of the things that's really important is, we used to have what was called appointment viewing in television, right? Like, oh my God, it's the—there's a joke about Heather Locklear in a nightie in one of the books, which was like a Melrose Place moment when I was in college. Everybody would tune in of, like, it was like Melrose Place or 90210. And of course, people have had it with destiny.
- 6.142** That's the line.
- 6.143** And the last time we've had that in a substantial way in America that I saw was Game of Thrones, like when people were caught up and really waiting, but now it's like a new season drops of White Lotus, but I wait 2 or 3 seasons and then people say it's really good, and then I catch up. So streaming has removed appointment TV, which is a

community engagement around a narrative. Well, that was fun. It was fun the next day in class when everyone's, like, abuzz about some giant thing that happened on ER, when that was a show that was doing such a thing.

- 6.144** And so I think that the solution is, because we're getting close, where AI could literally say, you know, "Write me a Tom Clancy novel combined with Gregg Hurwitz in the tone of William Faulkner. And I don't want it to have any violence towards children because that upsets me. And do it at—my IQ's 110 and write it at that level." And then your wife can have the exact same one and decide that she wants to add it and turn it so that it's more romantic and has a happier outcome. And then you could do, like— so we're at the point where we're going to be so fragmented into different realities with AI.
- 6.145** So for me, the solution to this problem is the solution to every problem, I'm increasingly convinced, which is community. If we can't figure out how to rebuild community to have—and so with Orphan X, there is something about that a book comes out every year, right? There's something about the people read it, that they have the next chapter in an event, right? I have people who are following this story. I mean, I have—Orphan X I think of, and I just kind of realized, I'm thinking of it—there's going to be a set of 10 that closes a certain chapter in this, and then more will come, but it's going to be a little bit different.
- 6.146** So there's a process, there's reading, there's an evolution. And being in touch with people through my newsletter, through social media, through YouTube, I have very good publicity and marketing team. But for me, it's very important that that exists as part of a community, that we're all reading the same book. I don't want to read a book that's only written for me. Even if I could read a book that says, "I could read a book that's as good as Faulkner. Write me one every day for the rest of my life," right? But then it's too much-ness, right? It's like eating beyond satiation. And I have that sensation now.
- 6.147** Sometimes I'll be in bed at night trying to figure out what to watch on Apple TV, and I have like \$500-billion of content at my disposal with the twitch of a thumb. And I don't want to watch any of it. It's all flattened. It's all become less special in a way. And it used to be, I mean, I remember lining up around the block for when Tim Burton's Batman came out, right? I mean, I was waiting online for 6 hours to get in opening night. It meant something more in that way. So I think that the solution to this is, we're not going to stop AI. It's going to massively accelerate and alter the way that we see the world. And what's important is that we figure out modes of engagement around community. That's another part of why International Thriller Writers is important to me, as we're figuring out how to navigate this issue, and we figure out communities around something that is a joined narrative.
- 6.148** And in this case, for my writing, the joined narrative is the Orphan X books, right? In your narratives, in your writing of whatever you're doing, or your company that you're doing the branding for, the ways that you can kind of pull community together, those

will be ways that then you're using AI as tools that are augmenting to the good of a community that ideally you've oriented properly and is connected. Right? And so we can use this at time of massive and accelerated change. But we want to make sure that we're still embedded in conversation with each other, so that it's not like Wall-E and we're all just floating around obesely with, like, our phones staring at them and our own, you know, ever, ever, you know, bottomless abyss.

- 6.149** It's still an event that The Last Orphan is coming out in February. And I think it's really helpful that you've got a broken finger as well because I think it demonstrates to people watching this that you're not an AI construct, an avatar. It makes you real.
- 6.150** It would fool them for sure. So the broken finger, yeah, they'd never know how to do this. I feel you're probably owed an explanation. There's two explanations for how I broke this finger. The first is it got stuck in the ejection port of a Benelli combat shotgun when I was training and it just tore the finger out of joint. And the second is that I dislocated it tucking in my shirt. So we can choose whichever one of those appropriate.
- 6.151** Right? Either. Questions over here.
- 6.152** I have two questions. The second one is a no-brainer. The first one would be, you mentioned that you read 5000 volumes before your first novel. Is that correct?
- 6.153** I'm just estimating. Yeah. I mean, I just read everything I could get my hands on. And 5000 is a number that suits the story well.
- 6.154** And I definitely believe you.
- 6.155** Don't fact-check me, man.
- 6.156** The reason why I'm asking this is because there's a, there's a term, I don't know if it's appropriate to use it, which is called contamination. In terms of whenever you're writing, how much, how much contaminated can your writing be? As to, whenever you're revising your content, you might be thinking, man, this is too much, too, too Shakespearean, or this is too X, Y, Z. So how do you deal with the fact that you have hundreds of hundreds of authors under your belt and influence, and how can you detach from them without negating the influence and having your own voice?
- 6.157** So anxiety of influence. It's a very smart question. I never struggled with this a great deal. I mentioned earlier that a lot of people said, "I can't read when I'm writing because of this contamination," but I'm a writer because I love reading, in part, and so I always want to be reading. I haven't struggled with this a ton. Here and there, and young, I have a pretty strong esthetic at this point. I have a pretty strong tone and approach and style that feels pretty distinct. And so it's confident at the borders in a way that might be different when you're younger, but there's ways to separate it. It's kind of like, and maybe in the beginning you can't fully, right? It's a process to become the fullest version of ourself in every arena. And writing's no different, right?

- 6.158** Like, how much of your engagement with other people a result of something that's unresolved from an influence from your childhood or someone who bullied you or someone you admired? Right? It's a constant process of what we're doing as humans, and so it's OK to keep developing and getting that wrong and finding it out. And the more pure you become as an artist—we understand when artists are in a pure state in certain ways. There's something that feels like they're wholly of themselves. There's a place that people get where they're distinct, but that takes a lot of work. So don't be afraid to play around.
- 6.159** But also think about it. You can also uncomplicate it. If you're a baseball player and you watch 5000 baseball games, you're still playing the game when you're playing the game, right? You might be trying to imitate something from, like David Ortiz's stroke or, like, Robby Thompson fielding at second base, right? Like, there's moves, there's all the stuff that you see, but you're going to move in your body a different way. Right? And it's the same thing—how do you separate all your thoughts from everything you've read? Right?
- 6.160** This is a very bright group that is here, and my guess is those who are viewing and tuning in, right? There's a certain hunger for adventure and for knowledge that seems to exist around this whole enterprise of what this academy is and what everyone's trying to do. But you don't know what thoughts are yours and what's Plato and what's a teacher and what's everything. You're figuring that out all the time. So don't fear that in writing, I would say. Read widely and robustly and take stuff in and maybe write something in someone else's voice and go, "Wow, that's weird. I want to take 5% of it. 95% of it's a bad imitation, but I can learn this thing. And I'm going to take this piece and I'm going to take that piece and I'm going to borrow it."
- 6.161** And all of a sudden everything goes into the blender, right? And all of a sudden, one day, you're going to start to have a tone and a cadence. It's first going to be on a project where you're like, "Wow, this is my voice. This is me. This is all the influences around me organized into something that's cohesive." And that's what we try and do anytime that we're thinking clearly. And there's no essential difference between thinking clearly and writing clearly, or thinking purely and writing purely. It's a process, and both of them approximate the same thing.
- 6.162** Thank you. Second question. Stranded on an island. You cannot pick the book, "How to Get Off on a Stranded Island." Thus, what two books would you want to have with you, and why?
- 6.163** I'd have the complete works of Shakespeare. I'm allowed an anthology, am I? I probably—oh, it's so hard. I probably would choose the Bible because the stories are so foundational. It's like, I'm thinking about something that you could reread and reread and, like, I love *The Great Gatsby*, right? But at a point, you'd have it memorized. Like, I almost, I almost anticipate the sentences now because I've read it so many times, right?

So what's something that you could study endlessly that has endless connections and is also just foundational for what lays beneath a culture and other works of literature? So.

6.164 And then Shakespeare feels to me, like, you can discover the world of knowledge through Shakespeare and you can discover—Shakespeare, to me, is inexhaustible. You wouldn't have Freud without Shakespeare, right? You wouldn't have, like, the range of influence throughout all of the arts and the range— you can make discernments about politics through Shakespeare, right? Through culture, through sexuality, through roles, through hierarchy, right? There's an expansiveness within that body of work that seems preternatural.

6.165 A few years ago, I wrote a book and proposed it to my publisher. It was about the 6th historical novel I'd written. It was set in the 60s, and the main character is a woman, a black woman, a singer, and her love interest is a Sicilian piano player. And my publisher said, "We love it. We love your idea. We trust you. But you have to write from the point of view of the Sicilian mobster piano player. You can't write from the point of view of the woman," because I don't share her skin tone.

6.166 And it was really a, you know, there was a really a battle, and you've described kind of what you've done, but it was—the limitation actually made the book better, I think, in the long run. I took the challenge. I wrote the book. It's been published. But when it's a first, when it's a main character, you know, what is your, what's your feeling on that? And, you know, you said, maybe what your, your cast is diverse. I've written diversely my whole life. But that was a very specific thing when they said, "No, you can't," because it was the main character I had to write from the Sicilian man, which I'm not Sicilian and I'm not a man.

6.167 Can I just ask what the title of that book is? Because I want to read.

6.168 It's called the Songbook of Benny Lament.

6.169 OK, cool. Thank you.

6.170 Well, first, I think it's important to answer with the level of the statement. So they're saying you can't write the book that way. And the answer—what they're really saying is, if you write the book that way and submit it to us, we will not publish it.

6.171 Yeah, they were saying they were afraid.

6.172 Yes, but that's different than you can't write it. Do you know what I mean? And so a lot of times, institutions speak with a sort of authority that we feel like—when you're not in publishing in a way that's longer, it feels like this giant walled monolith from which wisdom and decrees are stated. I've had projects that get passed on again and again and again and again and again and then they get made. Or they get bought. I mean, hundreds of times for different reasons. So I think it's also important just to differentiate that that's from one sort of corporate power that's concerned with their

own engagement with the culture, and they're making a set of determinations and giving you a decree in that sense.

- 6.173** But I think the starting answer is that anyone should write anything that they want to write in any way. Writing's thinking. You can think through any way that you want. If that makes sense to you, and you feel like the limitation made the book better, then, then you did the right thing. If the story's better, that's all that matters. If that perspective made more sense to you. But we're integrally engaged with corporations—means of propagation— that are making assessments about what kind of risks they're willing to take and aren't willing to take. And that's a negotiation that goes back forever between artists and entertainers. Right?
- 6.174** How much can Dave Chappelle say and still stay on Netflix? Turns out Dave Chappelle's a pretty pure artist, a pretty pure, soulful, proper court jester. Right? And that's a sacred role within the society, and he didn't deviate from that role. And so he's been given a platform that has now—or he's aligned himself in a way that he has a platform that has stood behind him and stood behind him because he's, he's been uncompromising in what that is. But the art's also all the way there, in a lot of regards. Right? Which doesn't mean he's not gonna make, that everything he says is gonna be for everybody, but it's like, he's a brilliant embodiment of the form, and he broke certain structures in a way that he's allowed to have—he's shown a kind of deference, is what I mean to say.
- 6.175** So we're in negotiation all the time, as artists, as creators, as people versus corporations, or multiglobal or legal departments or human resources. It's something that we're always navigating. And when you have less power, it seems like you have less power and that you need to say, "OK," more to directions that they're going to tell you. But it's not always obviously the case. Also, sometimes you have more options than you think you might have. But if they said that it's not working, and you undertook a rewrite, and the rewrite turned out to be to make the book better—
- 6.176** It was just a proposal. I don't, yeah, I'm lucky because I only, I propose, and they, like, we want the book or we don't. So I had—it was literally a proposal that they said, "Yes, we want it, but we want you to write it this way." And I decided to go forward, and I think it's my best work. So maybe the, maybe the limitation, looking at it and saying, "OK, I'm going to still write this story, but I'm going to write it from a different direction."
- 6.177** And weighing input about market and about strategy does not mean that you resist the realities of a marketplace and advice that you're getting, if you can still write something that's amazing. Right? So it's tricky. It's not like every time you do something, it's a mistake and you haven't stood up for something either. Right? It sounds like it was a complicated negotiation, and if you wanted to do this book in this context with this publisher, that's a route you chose to do, and you made the best of it. Right? And you dodged, from their perspective, what they're willing to do.

- 6.178** There was a certain level of controversy they didn't want to have, and had you felt really strongly, "I have to embody this voice. I'm hearing it in my head. It's the only way I can think of this story," maybe you shop that proposal to different places. But if something opened up and it made sense, I don't think that— it sounds like the stakes in your response to them, it sounds like you handled quite gracefully the situation in a way that led to a good creative outcome.
- 6.179** Yeah. The book will have its day, I guess.
- 6.180** Yeah.
- 6.181** Yeah. I was trying to imagine what it would be like to interview Orphan X, Evan Smoak, and this is a guy who has difficulty having conversations in the elevator. So I've got a feeling it probably was better to have Gregg Hurwitz, rather than Evan Smoak, to have a conversation with. And I feel really grateful, I must say, that we've benefited so much from your huge experience. And I've really enjoyed, and I hope you have too, Gregg's thoughts and observations and ruminations on the artist's story. So thank you very much. Gregg Hurwitz.
- 6.182** I appreciate very much having you as my interlocutor. It was excellent shape to this, and I think being in conversation around something that—it brings out the unexpected in a lot of ways. Right? It gives a good shape to it while letting us range around a little bit. And it's, writing a book, writing is a messy, complicated endeavor. So it's good that we have a bit of elbow room to have the discussion. So I appreciate it very much. I'm very glad for all you showing up and for everybody who's watching. And I want to thank the crew and the team behind this series of courses for making this all happen in such a good way.
- 6.183** It's been a pleasure. Thanks.